

WHEN WE WERE TWENTY

The Summer We Thought Would Last Forever

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Chennai • Ludbiana • Somewhere between June and memory

Dedication

For everyone who thought
they were merely organizing events,
only to discover years later
that they were collecting memories.

For the friendships that survived misunderstandings.
For the people who became home.
For the nights that became stories.
For the ordinary moments
that refused to remain ordinary.

And for everyone
who has ever looked back
and quietly whispered -

"Those were good days."

Epigraph

जातस्य हि ध्रुवो मृत्युर्ध्रुवं जन्म मृतस्य च ।
तस्मादपरिहार्येऽर्थे न त्वं शोचितुमर्हसि ॥

*For what is born, death is certain;
and for what dies, birth is certain.*

Therefore, do not grieve over the inevitable.

- Bhagavad Gita 2.27

Time takes almost everything.

Memories are stubborn.

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When We Were Twenty

PREFACE

People often ask when Paradox begins.

The official answer is easy. There are dates on posters, schedules on websites, and opening ceremonies that tell everyone exactly when the event starts.

The real answer is much harder.

Paradox never begins on the day people think it does.

It begins months earlier, in late-night meetings where nobody is paying attention to the clock. It begins in spreadsheets that grow faster than anyone intended. It begins in phone calls that were supposed to last ten minutes and somehow continue for two hours. It begins when a group of students decide to attempt something slightly larger than their experience, their resources, and occasionally their common sense.

Most people see the events.

They see the registrations, the competitions, the photographs, the certificates, and the closing ceremony.

What they do not see are the stories that exist underneath.

The friendships. The arguments. The misunderstandings.

The inside jokes that make absolutely no sense to anyone outside the group.

The people who become important without announcing themselves.

The moments that seem ordinary while they are happening and become unforgettable years later.

This book is not the story of Paradox 2026.

At least not entirely.

Paradox is the setting.

The real story is about a group of young people trying to build something together while simultaneously trying to figure out who they were becoming. Some succeeded. Some failed. Most of us did both, often within the same week.

There are chapters in this book about events, meetings, sponsorships, volunteers, and chaos. There are also chapters about beach sunrises, long walks, late-night conversations, broken friendships, second chances, and the strange magic of being twenty years old.

Because that is what remains after everything else fades.

Twenty years from now, very few people will remember how many registrations an event received.

Nobody will remember the exact contents of a spreadsheet.

Nobody will remember which presentation had the best design.

But people will remember who walked beside them.

They will remember who stayed.

They will remember who forgave them.

They will remember who made them laugh when things were falling apart.

And if this book succeeds at all, it will remind them of those people.

This is the story of one summer.

This is the story of one community.

This is the story of the days we did not know would matter so much.

This is the story of when we were twenty.

"One day, without realizing it, you and your friends will have your last ordinary day together.

Nobody will take a photograph.

Nobody will make a speech.

Nobody will know it is happening.

Years later, you will remember it anyway."

– For everyone who was there.

PART I
WHEN JUNE WAS STILL FAR AWAY

*"Some stories begin with a dream. Ours began
with a notification."*

Chapter 1

People Who Had No Idea What They Were Doing

At 2:13 in the morning, Aman sent me a message that should probably have been illegal.

Most reasonable people are asleep at 2:13 AM. Most reasonable people are certainly not discussing event planning, volunteer structures, registration strategies, and the future of a student society at that hour. Unfortunately, neither of us qualified as reasonable.

I stared at the notification for a few seconds before opening it. My laptop was still on. Several tabs were open. A spreadsheet occupied most of the screen. An unfinished assignment occupied a much smaller corner, where it had been quietly losing a battle for my attention over the previous two hours.

Aman's message was short.

"Awake?"

I laughed.

There are certain questions close friends ask even when they already know the answer.

This was one of them.

I replied immediately.

"You literally know I am."

The typing indicator appeared almost instantly.

"Good."

That single word should have worried me.

Whenever Aman began a conversation with "good," it usually meant more work was about to arrive.

Sure enough, another message followed.

"I have an idea."

The dangerous thing about ideas is that they sound harmless in the beginning. Nobody ever announces that an idea will eventually consume months of your life. Nobody says, "This thought is going to become a spreadsheet, three meetings, two arguments, a volunteer team, and several sleepless nights."

If they did, most ideas would die immediately.

Instead, they arrive disguised as excitement.

"What idea?" I asked.

For nearly thirty seconds, there was no response.

Then a document appeared.

Then another.

Then a screenshot.

By the time Aman finally explained what he wanted to discuss, I was already laughing.

The idea itself wasn't absurd.

The timing was.

Outside my window, the world was asleep. Entire cities were resting. Responsible students had probably completed their assignments and gone to bed hours ago.

Meanwhile, two members of Sportify had somehow convinced themselves that the middle of the night was the perfect time to discuss the future.

Looking back, I wish I could say this was unusual.

It wasn't.

By that point, late-night conversations had become part of the culture. Some meetings happened officially. Many happened accidentally. A message would arrive. Somebody would respond. Another person would join. Before long, a simple discussion would transform into a planning session that lasted far longer than anyone intended.

Nobody ever seemed surprised when it happened.

Least of all Aman.

For reasons I still cannot fully explain, he possessed an endless supply of energy whenever a new idea appeared. Time, sleep, and common sense all seemed to become optional.

"Just imagine," he wrote.

Whenever a sentence begins with those words, productivity immediately becomes impossible.

I leaned back in my chair and listened while Aman explained what he was thinking. Some of it involved future events. Some of it involved improving existing systems. Some of it involved plans that would not become relevant for months.

What struck me wasn't the idea itself.

It was the certainty.

The confidence that things could be improved.

The belief that trying was worthwhile even when success wasn't guaranteed.

That optimism was contagious.

Many of the people who would eventually become central characters in this story shared it. They approached problems with the strange

confidence unique to students who had not yet learned how many reasons existed to say no.

Perhaps that was our greatest advantage.

Nobody had explained our limitations yet.

The conversation continued for almost an hour. New possibilities appeared. Existing plans expanded. Additional tasks somehow materialized out of nowhere. By the time we finished, the original discussion had grown far beyond its starting point.

The assignment on my laptop remained untouched.

I wasn't particularly surprised.

Somewhere during the previous year, Sportify had quietly stopped being an extracurricular activity and started becoming a part of everyday life. Not because anybody demanded it. Not because anybody forced it.

Because people cared.

That was the simplest explanation.

People cared enough to stay awake discussing improvements. People cared enough to volunteer their time. People cared enough to keep showing up, even when nobody was paying them and very few people knew how much work happened behind the scenes.

At the time, I didn't think much about it.

It simply felt normal.

Only later would I realize how unusual it actually was.

Before ending the conversation, Aman sent one final message.

"We should probably sleep."

I checked the time.

It was nearly three thirty.

"Probably."

Neither of us left immediately.

A few more messages followed.

Then a few more.

Eventually, the conversation drifted into completely unrelated territory, as most good conversations do.

The future could wait until morning.

At least that was what we told ourselves.

The truth was that morning had already begun.

And although neither of us knew it then, the summer that would eventually become this book had already started.

The conversation finally ended sometime after three thirty in the morning. I closed my laptop, looked at the untouched assignment on the screen, and briefly considered making a responsible decision.

The thought lasted less than a minute.

By then, my mind had already moved on to everything Aman and I had discussed.

That was becoming a problem.

Or perhaps a lifestyle.

At some point during the previous year, Sportify had stopped being a student society and become a permanent resident inside our heads. Conversations about events appeared during lectures, during meals, during travel, and occasionally at hours normally reserved for sleep. Every new idea led to another discussion, every discussion led to another plan, and every plan somehow produced three additional tasks.

The strange thing was that nobody seemed particularly unhappy about it.

Most of the people who would eventually become central to this story had joined for different reasons. Some came because they loved sports. Some wanted to contribute to the community. Some were looking for friends. Some were simply curious. Whatever the reason, they all ended up staying for longer than they originally intended.

That was the effect Sportify tended to have on people.

You arrived expecting an extracurricular activity.

You left with responsibilities, friendships, inside jokes, and a calendar that somehow became busier than your academic schedule.

The next morning, after far fewer hours of sleep than I would publicly recommend, my phone began vibrating again.

The first notification was from Aman.

The second was from a Sportify group.

The third was from another Sportify group.

By the fifth notification, I accepted that the day had already started.

As I opened the messages, a familiar pattern emerged. Somebody had an idea. Somebody else had a concern. A third person had already created a document. A fourth person had somehow turned the discussion into a larger project than anyone originally intended.

The machine was functioning normally.

One of the most interesting things about Sportify was that it never really had a central operating hour. Some societies came alive during meetings. Others became active during events.

Sportify seemed active all the time.

At any given moment, somebody was designing a poster, somebody was planning an event, somebody was discussing outreach, somebody was

reviewing registrations, and somebody was almost certainly creating a spreadsheet.

Especially the spreadsheets.

Those multiplied at a rate that should probably have been studied scientifically.

A few days later, during one of our regular discussions, I found myself looking at the growing collection of people around me and realizing something unusual.

Most of us had no business being this confident.

Not because we lacked commitment.

Because we lacked experience.

We were students.

Enthusiastic students, certainly.

Dedicated students, often.

Capable students, most of the time.

But students nonetheless.

Yet every time a challenge appeared, somebody volunteered to handle it.

Every time a new initiative was proposed, somebody found a way to support it.

Every time a problem emerged, a group of people gathered around it until a solution eventually appeared.

The process wasn't elegant.

It was rarely efficient.

But it worked.

Aman was one of the easiest examples of this phenomenon.

His default response to new ideas was rarely "No."

More often it was something closer to:

"Let's see how."

That mindset spread surprisingly quickly.

People who spend enough time around optimism eventually start borrowing some of it.

Not because they intend to.

Because it becomes difficult not to.

Around the same time, other familiar faces were becoming increasingly difficult to imagine without Sportify.

Methelesh and Nikhil were slowly expanding the technical side of the society, turning ideas into systems and systems into tools that made everyone's lives easier.

Deepak, Saurabh, and Ashwin seemed to possess an endless ability to create posters, videos, graphics, and content, often under timelines that would have frightened reasonable people.

Jahanvi and Pratishta were working relentlessly to build stronger participation among women students, investing time and energy into conversations and initiatives that rarely received the attention they deserved.

Ansh had unofficially become one of the people responsible for preventing the rest of us from collapsing under our own ambitions.

His contribution was difficult to quantify, but extremely noticeable.

Every team has someone who quietly keeps things together when everyone else is busy running in different directions.

For us, Ansh often played that role.

The funny thing is that none of this felt significant at the time.

There was no grand realization.

No speech.

No dramatic moment where everyone suddenly understood they were building something meaningful.

Most days simply felt normal.

Meetings happened.

Work continued.

Ideas evolved.

Life moved forward.

Only much later would I realize that some of the most important chapters of our story were already being written during those ordinary days.

At the time, however, June still felt impossibly far away.

Paradox was somewhere in the future.

The events were somewhere in the future.

The memories were somewhere in the future.

None of us knew how quickly that future was approaching.

A few days after that conversation, I found myself staring at a spreadsheet that had somehow become larger than the original problem it was supposed to solve.

The spreadsheet had started innocently enough. Most dangerous things do.

At some point, someone needed a place to track a few details regarding future plans. A simple table was created. A few columns were added. A handful of entries appeared. Under normal circumstances, that should have been the end of the story.

Instead, the spreadsheet began growing.

New tabs appeared.

Additional sections were created.

Colour coding entered the picture.

Links multiplied.

Comments started appearing in cells.

By the end of the week, the document had evolved into something that looked less like a planning tool and more like the operating system of a small nation.

The most surprising part was that nobody seemed concerned.

If anything, people appeared proud of it.

One evening, I opened the document to review a few updates and immediately noticed that several new tabs had appeared since my previous visit.

There was a tab for event ideas.

A tab for future initiatives.

A tab for pending discussions.

A tab for tasks.

A tab for timelines.

And, for reasons that remain unclear even today, a tab called "Future Possibilities."

I clicked on it.

The contents were exactly as dangerous as the title suggested.

Ideas filled the page.

Some were practical.

Some were ambitious.

A few appeared to have been written by people who had temporarily lost contact with reality.

Naturally, those were the most entertaining.

As I scrolled through the document, notifications began appearing beside different entries. People were actively editing the sheet while I was looking at it.

One suggestion appeared.

Then another.

A comment popped up.

A response followed.

The spreadsheet had somehow become a conversation.

A few minutes later, Aman called.

"I have a question."

"You always have a question."

"This one is important."

I waited.

"How many tabs are too many tabs?"

I laughed immediately.

"That depends."

"On what?"

"Whether you're asking as a normal person or as somebody who helped create this monster."

The silence that followed told me everything I needed to know.

"Fair."

The truth was that the spreadsheet represented something much larger than planning. It was evidence of how quickly the society was changing. Every new tab represented an idea someone cared enough about to write down. Every update represented time somebody had voluntarily invested. Every comment represented another person trying to improve something.

The document was messy.

Occasionally confusing.

Frequently overwhelming.

But it was alive.

That mattered.

Around the same period, Sportify itself was beginning to evolve. What had once felt like a relatively small team was gradually becoming something more structured. New people were stepping forward. New responsibilities were emerging. Different departments were finding their identities.

The growth wasn't dramatic enough to notice on a daily basis.

Growth rarely is.

Instead, it happened quietly.

One conversation at a time.

One initiative at a time.

One person at a time.

The people inside the society were becoming increasingly different from one another, yet somehow the differences made the whole thing stronger.

Methelesh approached problems the way engineers approach complicated machines. If something wasn't working efficiently, he wanted to understand why. Once he understood why, he wanted to fix it. Many of the technical improvements that would later become essential to our operations started as casual discussions that eventually reached him.

Nikhil shared a similar fascination with systems and technology, and together they gradually expanded capabilities that most people never even realized existed behind the scenes. Participants saw events. Organizers saw infrastructure. Methesh and Nikhil often saw possibilities.

Elsewhere, Deepak, Saurabh, and Ashwin were fighting an entirely different battle.

Visibility.

Every event needs participants.

Every participant needs information.

Every piece of information needs communication.

And communication requires content.

Posters appeared.

Videos appeared.

Announcements appeared.

Promotional campaigns emerged one after another.

Whenever I opened our design groups, something new was usually being created.

The remarkable part was not the quantity.

It was the consistency.

No matter how ambitious an idea became, somebody was always willing to turn it into something people could actually see.

Looking back, that willingness to contribute was the defining characteristic of the society. Nobody waited around for perfect conditions. People simply started building with whatever resources they had.

At the time, however, none of us were thinking about legacy, leadership, or future memories.

We were simply trying to make things work.

The irony, of course, was that those ordinary days would eventually become some of the memories we valued most.

One evening, sometime during the middle of that semester, I joined a routine Sportify meeting expecting it to last thirty minutes.

That expectation survived for approximately seven minutes.

The meeting itself was not particularly extraordinary. Nobody was announcing a major initiative. No urgent crisis had appeared. No event was collapsing. It was simply a discussion about ongoing work, future plans, and a handful of updates from different teams.

The problem was that Sportify meetings rarely ended when the agenda ended.

The official discussion usually lasted thirty minutes.

The unofficial discussion could continue indefinitely.

By the time the planned topics had been completed, nobody seemed interested in leaving.

Somebody mentioned a future idea.

That generated another conversation.

Somebody else proposed a modification.

That created another discussion.

Then a completely unrelated topic appeared from nowhere and somehow became the focus of the evening.

This happened so frequently that nobody considered it unusual anymore.

Aman was, unsurprisingly, one of the primary contributors to this phenomenon.

The moment a conversation appeared to be ending, he had an almost supernatural ability to introduce another topic.

Sometimes it was useful.

Sometimes it was dangerous.

Most of the time it was both.

I remember looking at the participant list that evening and realizing how different everyone was.

Methelesh approached discussions the way a chess player approaches a complicated position. He rarely rushed into conclusions and usually spent more time thinking than speaking. Then, when he finally did speak, everybody paid attention because there was a reasonable chance he had already identified something the rest of us had missed.

Nikhil possessed a similar curiosity about systems and solutions. Many people looked at a problem and saw a problem. Nikhil often looked at a problem and saw a process that could be improved.

Deepak, meanwhile, somehow managed to remain calm despite operating inside what appeared to be a permanent storm of posters, videos, graphics, revisions, and last-minute requests. The design team routinely received impossible timelines and somehow continued producing quality work anyway.

I once became convinced that Deepak had secretly discovered a way to create additional hours in a day.

There was no other explanation.

Saurabh and Ashwin were equally dangerous in their own way. Give them a rough concept and they would immediately begin discussing how it could be improved, redesigned, expanded, or transformed into something more ambitious than originally intended.

This tendency was extremely useful.

It was also occasionally exhausting.

The conversation continued moving between ideas and updates until someone casually mentioned participation numbers from a recent initiative.

That immediately shifted the discussion.

Within seconds, people were debating outreach strategies, engagement approaches, communication plans, and future possibilities.

The funny thing was that none of these conversations were mandatory.

Nobody was being paid to stay.

Nobody was being forced to contribute.

Yet people remained.

Not because they had to.

Because they wanted to.

That realization stayed with me long after the meeting ended.

Student communities are strange places. Many people join them. Far fewer stay long enough to build something meaningful. Fewer still continue showing up when the excitement disappears and the actual work begins.

Sportify somehow attracted those people.

The builders.

The planners.

The dreamers.

The slightly unreasonable optimists who looked at a challenge and immediately started discussing solutions.

Looking back, I think that was the real reason the society grew.

Not because we had perfect systems.

Not because we had extraordinary resources.

Certainly not because we always knew what we were doing.

The society grew because enough people cared.

And when enough people care about the same thing at the same time, remarkable things begin happening almost by accident.

At some point during that meeting, the discussion drifted toward future events. New possibilities appeared. Potential collaborations were suggested. Somebody opened a document. Somebody else opened another document.

Within minutes, the conversation had once again transformed into planning.

Nobody seemed surprised.

This was simply how things worked.

What none of us realized at the time was that many of the ideas being casually discussed that evening would eventually become part of a much larger story. Some would succeed. Some would fail. Some would evolve into something completely different from their original form.

All of them, however, were helping create the summer that was slowly approaching.

June still felt distant.

Paradox still felt distant.

The future still felt distant.

Yet every meeting, every discussion, and every late-night conversation seemed to move it slightly closer.

None of us were paying attention to the countdown.

We were too busy building what came next.

The easiest mistake to make when talking about a student society is to describe people through their responsibilities.

It sounds logical.

It is also completely wrong.

Nobody remembers a person because they managed a department.

People remember personalities.

They remember habits.

They remember the things that made somebody uniquely themselves.

That was especially true inside Sportify.

The further the year progressed, the more obvious it became that every team had developed its own identity. Meetings often felt less like organizational discussions and more like gatherings of different tribes that had somehow agreed to coexist peacefully.

Most of the time.

The growth of Sportify HER was one of the best examples.

When the initiative first began taking shape, nobody knew exactly how large it could become. The intention was simple enough. We wanted more women to participate, more women to feel comfortable joining activities, and more women to see the society as a place where they genuinely belonged.

The idea sounded straightforward.

The execution was considerably more complicated.

Fortunately, people like Jahanvi and Pratishta existed.

One thing I noticed very early was that both of them possessed a level of patience that would have been extremely useful in international diplomacy. While the rest of us often approached problems with enthusiasm, urgency, and occasional chaos, they approached people.

There is a difference.

Building systems is difficult.

Building trust is harder.

Many of the conversations they handled never appeared in reports or presentations. There were concerns, suggestions, questions, hesitations, and discussions that happened quietly behind the scenes. Most people never saw those efforts.

The results, however, were impossible to miss.

Slowly, participation began increasing.

More people joined.

More conversations started happening.

More students became comfortable showing up.

The momentum built gradually, then all at once.

At the same time, the design team was operating inside its own version of reality.

I remain convinced that Deepak had a different understanding of deadlines than the rest of humanity.

A normal person sees a deadline and calculates how much time remains.

Deepak seemed to see a deadline and immediately calculate how much could still be accomplished before it arrived.

This was both impressive and slightly terrifying.

Whenever a new event emerged, posters appeared.

Whenever a campaign was proposed, graphics appeared.

Whenever somebody casually suggested a promotional video, there was a reasonable chance one would materialize before anyone had fully discussed the idea.

Of course, Deepak was never working alone.

Saurabh and Ashwin were equally responsible for ensuring that every new initiative somehow acquired a visual identity before the rest of us had finished planning it.

The design discussions themselves were often entertaining.

What started as a simple request would somehow evolve into a detailed conversation involving colours, layouts, fonts, themes, audience engagement, visual consistency, and concepts nobody else had even considered.

The funny thing was that these discussions almost always ended with a better result than the original idea.

The process looked chaotic.

The outcome rarely was.

Looking across the society, similar patterns appeared everywhere.

Different people approached challenges differently.

Some preferred planning.

Some preferred execution.

Some preferred communication.

Some preferred solving problems nobody else had noticed yet.

Yet despite all those differences, the society somehow continued moving in the same direction.

That still surprises me when I think about it.

Most groups struggle because people are different.

Sportify often succeeded because people were different.

Each person compensated for someone else's weakness.

Each department solved problems another department couldn't.

The system was imperfect.

The people certainly were.

Yet together they managed to create something much larger than any individual contribution.

At the time, however, nobody was thinking in those terms.

Nobody was imagining future books.

Nobody was imagining future memories.

We were simply living inside the present, convinced that there would always be another meeting, another discussion, another opportunity to talk tomorrow.

That illusion would survive for several more months.

Like most illusions, it felt permanent while it lasted.

One of the reasons those months felt so enjoyable was that nobody was treating them like history.

That sounds obvious, but it matters.

People behave differently when they know a moment is important. They pay more attention. They become more careful. They try to remember things while they are happening.

We didn't do any of that.

To us, these were simply ordinary days.

The meetings felt ordinary.

The conversations felt ordinary.

The endless notifications felt ordinary.

Even the growing workload felt ordinary.

Nobody wakes up one morning and announces that they are currently living through the chapter they will miss years later.

Life is rarely generous enough to provide that kind of warning.

One evening, after a particularly long discussion about future plans, I found myself scrolling through one of our group chats. The original purpose had been to find a specific message. Somewhere along the way, however, I became distracted by the conversation itself.

The chat looked less like an organizational group and more like a collection of people who had accidentally become friends while trying to organize events.

Ideas appeared without context.

Memes appeared without explanation.

Serious discussions were interrupted by completely unrelated jokes.

A planning conversation could suddenly become a debate about food, movies, travel, or some random observation that nobody would remember the next day.

Then, somehow, the discussion would return to work as if nothing had happened.

Looking at the messages, I realized something interesting.

The strongest parts of Sportify had very little to do with sports.

They had everything to do with people.

The events mattered.

The competitions mattered.

The initiatives mattered.

But the reason people stayed wasn't hidden inside a registration form or an event report.

It was hidden inside these conversations.

Inside the friendships.

Inside the familiarity that had quietly developed over time.

That familiarity showed itself in countless small ways.

People interrupted each other without apologizing because nobody took offense.

Arguments ended with jokes.

Ideas were challenged directly without damaging relationships.

Someone could disappear for a few days and immediately return to a conversation as though they had never left.

The group had developed its own language, its own rhythm, and its own collection of inside jokes.

To an outsider, much of it would have looked confusing.

To us, it simply felt normal.

The best example was probably Aman.

By this point, I had spoken to him so often that I could usually predict the direction of a conversation within the first few messages.

If he began discussing a problem, he was already thinking about a solution.

If he began discussing a solution, he was already thinking about expansion.

If he began discussing expansion, there was a very real possibility that additional work was about to appear in everybody's lives.

The pattern repeated often enough that it became predictable.

Not that anyone complained.

Most of us had developed similar habits.

The society was full of people who had become slightly too comfortable turning ideas into responsibilities.

Looking back, that tendency explains a great deal about what happened over the following months.

Nobody was waiting for permission to contribute.

People simply started.

An idea appeared.

Someone volunteered.

A discussion began.

A plan emerged.

The process wasn't always elegant, but it was remarkably effective.

The result was a culture where initiative spread quickly.

When one person cared deeply about something, others often followed.

When one team attempted something ambitious, other teams started thinking bigger as well.

Momentum has a strange way of multiplying.

By the beginning of the year, that momentum was becoming impossible to ignore.

New initiatives were appearing.

Existing projects were expanding.

Conversations about the future were becoming more frequent.

The society felt larger than it had a few months earlier, not necessarily in numbers, but in confidence.

People were beginning to believe that bigger things were possible.

At the time, nobody knew exactly where that confidence would lead.

We certainly didn't know it would eventually lead to Paradox.

Not in the way we would experience it.

For now, Paradox was simply another event sitting somewhere on a distant horizon.

Important, certainly.

Exciting, definitely.

But still far enough away to feel theoretical.

The real focus remained the present.

The next meeting.

The next discussion.

The next idea.

The next task.

And, as always, the next spreadsheet.

Because no matter what else changed inside Sportify, the spreadsheets somehow continued multiplying.

I suspect that if somebody had left a blank Google Sheet unattended for long enough, it would eventually have developed additional tabs on its own.

At the time, however, nobody viewed that as a warning sign.

We viewed it as progress.

In many ways, that perfectly captured the mindset of the entire society.

We were ambitious enough to create problems for our future selves and optimistic enough to assume our future selves would figure them out.

Most of the time, they did.

The rest of the time, we scheduled another meeting and tried again.

If someone had asked me at that point what the most important event of the year would be, I probably would have answered without much hesitation.

Paradox.

The name appeared often enough in conversations that it felt permanently present, even when nobody was actively discussing it. Sometimes it appeared in planning meetings. Sometimes it appeared in casual conversations. Sometimes it appeared inside spreadsheets that seemed to gain new tabs every time they were opened.

Yet despite its growing presence, Paradox still felt distant.

The event existed in the future.

The problems belonged to the future.

The responsibilities belonged to the future.

As far as we were concerned, there was plenty of time.

That assumption would later prove spectacularly inaccurate.

One evening, during a discussion that had originally been about something completely unrelated, the topic shifted toward Paradox once again. Nobody remembered exactly how it happened. Conversations inside Sportify had a habit of changing direction without warning.

One moment people were discussing outreach.

The next moment someone was estimating registrations.

A few minutes later somebody was debating venue capacities.

Then sponsorships entered the discussion.

Then volunteers.

Then event formats.

Then operational requirements.

Before long, half the conversation revolved around an event that was still months away.

What made the discussion interesting wasn't the planning itself.

It was the confidence.

The people involved were talking about possibilities as though they were inevitable.

Not because they were arrogant.

Because they were excited.

There is a specific kind of optimism that exists in student communities. It appears when people become convinced that something ambitious might actually be achievable. Once that belief takes hold, discussions begin changing. Ideas become larger. Targets become higher. Possibilities become more interesting.

I could see that shift happening in real time.

Nobody wanted to settle for ordinary.

Nobody wanted to do the minimum.

People were beginning to imagine what Sportify could become if everything worked.

The fascinating part was that almost nobody knew exactly how to make everything work.

That detail never seemed particularly important.

The confidence came first.

The solutions usually arrived later.

Looking back, that mindset explains a great deal about the months that followed.

Most of us were learning while building.

Improvising while planning.

Experimenting while pretending to know what we were doing.

The process should probably have failed more often than it did.

Yet somehow it continued moving forward.

Perhaps because uncertainty was shared.

Nobody felt alone in it.

Everyone was figuring things out together.

That made a difference.

Around the same time, the rhythm of daily life continued unchanged. Classes happened. Assignments accumulated. Exams approached. People dealt with their own responsibilities outside the society. Yet no matter how busy things became, Sportify somehow remained present.

A discussion here.

A meeting there.

A late-night call.

A new idea.

A new problem.

A new plan.

The cycle repeated often enough that it became part of normal life.

Months later, when Paradox finally arrived, many people would describe it as though it appeared suddenly.

That was never true.

Paradox didn't arrive suddenly.

It arrived gradually.

One conversation at a time.

One meeting at a time.

One spreadsheet at a time.

Long before participants registered.

Long before venues were booked.

Long before posters appeared.

Paradox had already begun taking shape inside the minds of the people who were building it.

We simply didn't realize it yet.

At the time, we were focused on the next task, the next discussion, and the next meeting. The future still felt comfortably distant. There was no urgency. There was no countdown. There was only the reassuring belief that June existed somewhere far away on the horizon.

That belief made everything feel manageable.

It also made us completely unprepared for how quickly the months would disappear.

The summer that would eventually become this book was already moving toward us.

None of us noticed.

We were too busy living inside the days that came before it.

Chapter 2

Bas Ek Last Kaam

If someone had examined our conversations during the first few months of 2026, they would probably have reached one of two conclusions.

Either we were extraordinarily dedicated.

Or we had collectively forgotten how to stop working.

The truth was somewhere in between.

The phrase appeared so frequently that nobody noticed it at first. Like many things inside close-knit groups, it entered the culture gradually. One person said it. Another repeated it. A few weeks later, everybody was using it.

"Bas ek last kaam."

Just one last task.

The problem was that there was never just one last task.

There was always another spreadsheet to review, another poster to approve, another discussion to finish, another idea to explore, another update to check, another message that seemed too important to leave unanswered until morning.

The phrase should have come with a warning label.

One particular evening captured the problem perfectly.

The original plan had been simple. Aman and I needed to review a document, discuss a few updates, and finalize some decisions regarding an upcoming initiative. Neither of us expected the discussion to last very long.

At least that was what we claimed beforehand.

The call began around nine in the evening.

For the first thirty minutes, everything proceeded normally. We reviewed pending items, clarified a few details, and worked through the topics that had originally been scheduled. The conversation was productive, efficient, and surprisingly organized.

Then somebody had an idea.

To this day, I no longer remember who it was.

What I do remember is the chain reaction that followed.

An idea led to a discussion.

The discussion led to a possibility.

The possibility led to a document.

The document led to a plan.

The plan created additional questions.

The questions required additional discussions.

Before long, the original agenda had disappeared entirely.

By eleven o'clock, we were no longer discussing what we had started discussing.

By midnight, we were planning things that had not existed when the call began.

By one o'clock, common sense had left the conversation completely.

At some point, Ansh joined.

The timing was unfortunate.

Or fortunate.

Depending on your perspective.

Ansh possessed a unique talent. While the rest of us often focused on possibilities, he had a remarkable ability to identify practical consequences. Every group needs somebody willing to ask uncomfortable questions before reality asks them instead.

Naturally, his arrival immediately complicated matters.

"What exactly are you people doing?"

The question was entirely reasonable.

Nobody answered it.

Partly because the answer was complicated.

Partly because none of us were entirely sure anymore.

Instead, Aman began explaining the latest version of the idea.

Ansh listened patiently.

Then he pointed out three problems.

Aman proposed four solutions.

Ansh identified two additional problems.

I opened another document.

The cycle continued.

Somewhere around one thirty in the morning, somebody finally suggested ending the discussion.

Everyone agreed immediately.

For approximately thirty seconds.

Then Aman said the words.

"Bas ek last kaam."

Nobody objected.

That was the mistake.

Because "one last task" quickly became another discussion. The discussion became another idea. The idea became another document. The document became another plan.

By the time we finally finished, it was closer to three in the morning than two.

The funniest part was that nobody seemed surprised.

The next day, the same people appeared again.

The same conversations continued.

The same enthusiasm returned.

Looking back, I think that was one of the defining characteristics of that period. The workload was real. The responsibilities were real. The exhaustion was certainly real.

Yet so was the excitement.

People genuinely wanted to be there.

Nobody was counting hours.

Nobody was calculating effort.

Nobody was asking whether the contribution would appear on a résumé.

People were contributing because they cared about what we were building.

That difference changes everything.

A few days later, I was reviewing messages when I noticed something amusing. The phrase had begun spreading. Different people were using it

in different groups. It appeared during meetings. It appeared during calls. It appeared during discussions that had clearly already exceeded their intended duration.

"Bas ek last kaam."

Every time somebody said it, everyone immediately understood what it actually meant.

The work was nowhere near finished.

In fact, there was a reasonable chance it had only just begun.

The phrase became so common that people eventually stopped questioning it.

That was probably the greatest danger.

If someone new joined a discussion and heard "bas ek last kaam," they might assume the conversation was approaching its conclusion. The veterans knew better. For them, the phrase was not an ending. It was usually the beginning of another hour.

The funniest part was that Aman wasn't the only person responsible anymore.

The habit had spread.

Cultural traits inside organizations often behave like that. A single person's behaviour gets copied enough times that eventually nobody remembers where it started. What was once an individual quirk becomes part of the group's identity.

One evening, I watched that transformation happen in real time.

A discussion involving the design team had already exceeded its expected duration. The original topic had been straightforward. Some promotional material needed review, a few design decisions required approval, and everyone wanted to ensure things were moving in the right direction.

Nothing particularly complicated.

Or at least that was the theory.

Deepak shared one version.

Saurabh suggested improvements.

Ashwin noticed something else.

Then another possibility appeared.

Then another.

The conversation kept evolving, each version becoming slightly better than the previous one.

After nearly an hour, somebody finally suggested wrapping things up.

Everyone agreed.

The discussion appeared finished.

Then Deepak said it.

"Bas ek last change."

I remember laughing immediately.

Not because the suggestion was unreasonable.

Because everyone in the meeting understood exactly what had just happened.

The phrase had changed slightly.

The meaning had not.

The call continued for another forty-five minutes.

Nobody seemed surprised.

The same pattern appeared everywhere.

A technical discussion with Methesh and Nikhil would begin with a simple question and somehow end with three possible improvements, two future plans, and a completely different understanding of the original problem. Both of them had a tendency to see opportunities where other people saw limitations. That quality was incredibly valuable and occasionally very dangerous.

One solution often created five additional possibilities.

Those possibilities created more discussions.

The discussions created more work.

Then somebody inevitably said that a few more things should be completed while everyone was already present.

The cycle continued.

At one point, I became convinced that Sportify's most renewable resource was unfinished work.

No matter how much progress happened, there always seemed to be another idea waiting nearby.

The surprising thing was that this never felt burdensome.

At least not most of the time.

The reason was simple.

The conversations themselves were enjoyable.

People often imagine student leadership as a collection of meetings, reports, and responsibilities. Those things certainly existed. What they don't see are the friendships that develop in between.

The jokes.

The arguments.

The random discussions that have nothing to do with the original topic.

The moments where people stop being teammates and become friends.

That was where the real story lived.

I remember one discussion that began as an event planning session and somehow became a debate about which fictional characters would be capable of organizing a sports tournament.

Nobody remembers how the topic appeared.

Nobody remembers how it ended.

Yet people remembered the conversation.

Not because it was important.

Because it was fun.

Those moments accumulated over time.

Individually they seemed insignificant.

Together they became culture.

That culture was the reason people continued showing up.

A meeting was never just a meeting.

A call was never just a call.

Even the longest discussions carried a sense of familiarity that made the effort worthwhile.

Looking back, I think that was one of the most valuable things Sportify gave us.

The work taught us skills.

The people taught us everything else.

By the middle of the semester, the phrase "bas ek last kaam" had evolved into something larger than a joke. It had become a symbol of a mindset shared by almost everyone around us.

People cared enough to do one more thing.

Then one more after that.

Then one more after that.

Not because they were forced to.

Because they wanted the final result to be better than the version that existed yesterday.

That mindset would eventually help us achieve things we hadn't thought possible.

It would also create several disasters.

At the time, however, those disasters still belonged to the future.

For now, all we knew was that another meeting was approaching, another discussion was waiting, and somebody, somewhere, was almost certainly about to suggest one last task.

Experience had taught us what would happen next.

The task would not be the last one.

It never was.

The funny thing about close friendships is that they rarely announce themselves.

Nobody schedules a meeting and decides that two people are about to become important in each other's lives.

There is no ceremony.

No formal beginning.

No exact moment you can point toward years later and say, "That was when it happened."

Instead, the process is so gradual that you barely notice it while it is happening.

One conversation becomes ten.

Ten become a hundred.

A hundred become normal.

At some point during the first half of 2026, speaking to Aman had become part of my daily routine in exactly that way.

Neither of us ever discussed it.

Neither of us needed to.

The evidence was everywhere.

If something good happened, he usually knew about it.

If something frustrating happened, he usually heard about it.

If a meeting went well, we talked about it.

If a meeting went badly, we definitely talked about it.

Some friendships are built around common interests.

Others are built around shared experiences.

Ours was built around shared responsibility.

When people spend enough time trying to solve the same problems, they eventually stop feeling like colleagues.

Something else develops.

Trust.

Not the dramatic kind.

The practical kind.

The kind that forms when somebody consistently shows up.

One night, after a particularly exhausting week, I remember staring at my laptop long after I should have stopped working.

The room was quiet.

Most sensible people were asleep.

I had convinced myself that a few more tasks needed to be completed before the day could officially end.

The logic was deeply flawed.

At around one in the morning, my phone buzzed.

The message was from Aman.

"Still awake?"

The question was ridiculous.

He already knew the answer.

I sent a photograph of my screen.

Several documents.

Two spreadsheets.

Far too many tabs.

His reply arrived immediately.

"Pagal."

I laughed.

Then another message appeared.

"Go sleep."

I informed him that this advice would be significantly more convincing if he were not also awake.

His response arrived a few seconds later.

"Different situation."

"It is literally the same situation."

"It isn't."

"It is."

"It isn't."

The argument continued for several minutes.

Neither side made any meaningful progress.

Eventually I asked the obvious question.

"If you're awake, what are you doing?"

A screenshot appeared.

His screen looked almost identical to mine.

Documents.

Spreadsheets.

Messages.

Tasks.

More tasks.

Even more tasks.

The hypocrisy was extraordinary.

I pointed this out immediately.

Aman ignored the accusation and changed the topic.

That was another habit.

Whenever he was losing an argument, the conversation mysteriously evolved into a different conversation.

The technique was surprisingly effective.

The discussion continued for another half hour before either of us admitted defeat and finally decided to sleep.

The next morning, both of us were tired.

Neither of us learned anything.

A few days later, the same situation happened again.

Then again.

Then again.

Looking back, what strikes me most is how ordinary those interactions felt.

Nobody was trying to create memories.

Nobody was trying to strengthen a friendship.

Nobody was trying to write a story.

We were simply living our lives.

Yet those small conversations accumulated over time.

A message here.

A phone call there.

A joke.

An argument.

A discussion about something completely unrelated to work.

Individually they seemed insignificant.

Together they built something much larger.

At the time, however, neither of us spent much time thinking about that.

We were too busy focusing on the next discussion, the next meeting, and the next task that absolutely had to be completed before the day ended.

Or at least before the day ended according to our completely unreasonable definition of time.

The phrase "bas ek last kaam" continued appearing everywhere.

The joke survived.

The work survived.

The friendships grew.

And without realizing it, all of us were slowly becoming part of a story much larger than any event we were planning.

One consequence of this culture was that nobody inside Sportify possessed a healthy relationship with time.

We understood time academically.

We could read clocks.

We could calculate deadlines.

We could identify dates on calendars.

The practical application, however, was considerably less impressive.

A meeting scheduled for one hour regularly occupied two.

A quick discussion routinely lasted half an evening.

Tasks that were supposed to be completed tomorrow somehow started today and finished next week.

Nobody appeared particularly concerned.

The system should have collapsed under its own inefficiency.

Instead, it survived through a combination of enthusiasm, improvisation, and what can only be described as collective optimism.

One afternoon, I found myself discussing this exact issue with Ansh.

The conversation had begun after another meeting exceeded its expected duration by a margin that would have been considered unacceptable in most professional environments.

Ansh looked genuinely concerned.

Not angry.

Concerned.

The distinction is important.

"I think you people have forgotten how time works."

I disagreed immediately.

"We understand time."

"No."

"We do."

"No."

"We absolutely do."

Ansh stared at me.

Then he opened the meeting schedule.

Then he opened the actual meeting history.

The evidence was not in my favour.

Unfortunately, that had never stopped me before.

I attempted a defense anyway.

Ansh listened patiently.

Then he dismantled the argument piece by piece.

The trial lasted several minutes.

The verdict was predictable.

Apparently, starting a discussion at nine in the evening and finishing at one in the morning was not considered normal behaviour.

I argued that the discussion had been productive.

Ansh argued that sleep was also productive.

The debate ended without a winner.

Mostly because nobody wanted to admit he was right.

The truth, however, was obvious.

Sportify had become one of the largest consumers of time in our lives.

Not because anybody demanded it.

Because everybody cared.

That distinction mattered.

When people are forced to work, they count hours.

When people care about the outcome, they count progress.

The difference is subtle.

The consequences are not.

Around the same period, another interesting pattern began emerging.

The phrase "bas ek last kaam" had become so common that people started using it ironically.

Someone would say it.

Everyone would laugh.

Then everyone would continue working anyway.

The joke worked because it was true.

The funniest example happened during one particularly long planning session.

By then, several people were visibly tired.

The discussion had reached the point where ideas were becoming increasingly ambitious and increasingly questionable at the same time.

That combination is usually a warning sign.

Aman finally announced that only one final task remained.

The reaction was immediate.

Nobody believed him.

Not one person.

Methelesh started laughing before Aman had even finished the sentence.

Deepak shook his head.

Someone else muted their microphone, presumably to hide a similar reaction.

The collective lack of confidence was remarkable.

Aman noticed.

"I don't understand why nobody trusts me."

That statement only made the situation worse.

By this point, people were no longer laughing at the task.

They were laughing at the confidence.

The discussion continued for another hour.

Exactly as everyone had predicted.

The remarkable thing is that nobody seemed frustrated afterward.

The meeting ended the same way most of them did.

People said goodnight.

A few final jokes appeared.

Someone remembered another pending task.

Someone else promised to handle it tomorrow.

The group slowly dispersed.

Life continued.

Looking back, I think those evenings reveal something important about that period of our lives.

Most of us were balancing academics, personal responsibilities, internships, examinations, family expectations, and countless other commitments at the same time.

By every logical measure, we should have been overwhelmed.

Occasionally we were.

Yet the memories that survived were rarely the stressful ones.

What remained were the conversations.

The friendships.

The laughter.

The feeling of building something alongside people you genuinely enjoyed being around.

That was the secret hidden beneath all the spreadsheets, meetings, and late-night discussions.

The work mattered.

The people mattered more.

At the time, however, none of us were thinking that far ahead.

We were still focused on the next idea, the next discussion, and the next task that absolutely had to be completed before the day ended.

Or, more accurately, before somebody suggested one last task and extended the day a little longer.

The strange thing about habits is that they eventually become invisible.

Nobody notices them anymore.

They stop feeling unusual.

They stop feeling temporary.

They simply become part of everyday life.

That was exactly what had happened to us.

The late-night calls no longer felt late.

The constant discussions no longer felt constant.

The growing responsibilities no longer felt overwhelming.

Everything had become normal.

At least normal according to our increasingly questionable standards.

One evening, while scrolling through old messages in search of something specific, I accidentally found conversations from several months earlier. The difference was immediately obvious.

The groups were quieter.

The discussions were shorter.

The plans were smaller.

Most importantly, the people felt unfamiliar.

Not because they had changed completely.

Because they had grown.

The versions of ourselves that existed at the beginning of the journey knew far less than the versions sitting inside those conversations now.

We had learned new skills.

Made new mistakes.

Taken on larger responsibilities.

Developed stronger friendships.

And somehow managed to survive all of it.

What fascinated me most was that none of those changes had happened suddenly.

Growth rarely announces itself.

Nobody wakes up one morning transformed.

Instead, change accumulates quietly.

A conversation here.

A challenge there.

A late-night discussion.

A difficult decision.

A successful event.

A failed idea.

A friendship that becomes stronger than expected.

Months later, you look back and realize you are not quite the same person who started.

Sportify was experiencing a similar transformation.

At first, it had been a society. Then it became a team. Somewhere along the way, it started becoming something else.

A community.

People often underestimate the difference.

Teams work together.

Communities grow together.

The distinction seems small until you experience it.

A team focuses on outcomes.

A community remembers people.

That realization explains why so many memories from that period have nothing to do with sports.

When I think about those months, I don't immediately remember registrations.

I don't immediately remember documents.

I don't immediately remember meeting agendas.

I remember conversations.

I remember laughter.

I remember people staying long after a meeting had officially ended because nobody wanted the discussion to stop.

I remember friendships forming in the spaces between responsibilities.

Without realizing it, we had started building something much larger than the events themselves.

The events gave people a reason to gather.

The people gave them a reason to stay.

At the time, however, none of us viewed it that way.

We were too close to the story.

We were still living inside it.

The future remained comfortably distant.

Paradox remained an event sitting somewhere on the horizon.

The biggest challenge still appeared to be finishing the next task.

Or the next meeting.

Or the next spreadsheet.

The irony, of course, was that the real story had already begun.

Not the story of Paradox.

Not yet.

The story of the people who would eventually experience it together.

Months later, when thousands of participants would arrive, events would fill the campus, and chaos would become a permanent companion, many people would assume that everything started there.

They would be wrong. The story started here.

In ordinary conversations.

In late-night calls.

In unfinished documents.

In friendships that nobody realized would matter so much.

And in a student society that was slowly becoming an island of its own.

An island with its own language, its own traditions, its own jokes, and its own collection of people who had absolutely no idea what they were doing.

Fortunately, neither did anyone else.

That made it much easier to keep going.

Chapter 3

The Island Called Sportify

Every community eventually develops its own geography.

Not the kind marked on maps.

The kind people carry in their heads.

There are places where conversations happen. Places where decisions are made. Places where jokes are born, arguments begin, friendships grow, and memories quietly accumulate without anybody realizing it.

Sportify had its own geography.

There were WhatsApp groups that somehow never slept. There were Google Meet links that remained active far longer than intended. There were spreadsheets that functioned like public infrastructure. There were departments with their own cultures, their own running jokes, and their own ways of doing things.

And somewhere along the way, all of it started feeling like its own world.

I first noticed it during a conversation that had absolutely nothing to do with sports.

That detail is important.

Because many of my favourite memories from Sportify have surprisingly little to do with sports.

One evening, a discussion that had begun around an upcoming initiative gradually drifted into unrelated territory. Nobody could identify the exact moment it happened. Conversations inside the society had a tendency to wander.

The original topic disappeared.

The people remained.

Soon everyone was discussing things that would never appear in an official report.

Favourite films.

Travel stories.

Terrible food experiences.

College memories.

Ridiculous hypothetical situations.

Somebody proposed a completely impossible scenario.

Somebody else took it seriously.

A third person expanded it.

Within minutes, half the group was debating an imaginary problem that did not exist and would never exist.

The enthusiasm was extraordinary.

The logic was questionable.

The entertainment value was exceptional.

What fascinated me wasn't the discussion itself.

It was the participation.

People who had joined the conversation for work stayed for everything else.

Nobody seemed eager to leave.

Nobody appeared to be counting minutes.

The society had quietly become more than a collection of responsibilities.

People enjoyed being there.

That changes everything.

Many organizations can create activity.

Far fewer create belonging.

Sportify was beginning to create belonging.

The evidence appeared everywhere.

Members from different departments knew each other.

People regularly helped outside their assigned responsibilities.

Conversations crossed organizational boundaries without effort.

A design discussion could involve somebody from outreach. A technical discussion could suddenly include people from events. A planning conversation might somehow become a community conversation halfway through.

The structure existed.

The walls did not.

That freedom made the society feel alive.

Around the same period, Sportify HER was growing in ways that were impossible to ignore.

When the initiative first started, nobody could accurately predict what it would become. The intention had always been clear. We wanted more women to participate, more women to engage with the community, and more women to feel represented inside a space that had historically seen lower participation from them.

The goal sounded simple when written down.

Human beings rarely are.

Building participation requires trust.

Building trust requires people.

Fortunately, the initiative had exactly the right people.

Jahanvi and Pratishta approached community building very differently from the way many of us approached operations. While the rest of us often became obsessed with systems, schedules, registrations, and execution, they spent their energy understanding people.

Questions were answered.

Concerns were addressed.

Conversations happened.

Relationships formed.

The work was often invisible.

The results were not.

Week by week, participation improved.

New faces appeared.

New conversations started.

A growing number of students began seeing Sportify as a place where they belonged.

Looking back, I think that achievement mattered far more than any registration number.

Statistics can tell you how many people arrived.

They cannot explain why they stayed.

That answer almost always involves people.

The same pattern existed inside every department.

Deepak, Saurabh, and Ashwin were not simply creating content. They were shaping how the society presented itself to the outside world. Methesh and Nikhil were not merely solving technical problems. They were building systems that allowed ideas to scale. Aman was not just leading meetings. He was creating momentum. Ansh was not merely offering suggestions. He was preventing ambitious plans from accidentally becoming disasters.

Everyone was contributing something different.

That diversity should have made coordination more difficult.

Instead, it made the society stronger.

The best communities are rarely built from similarity.

They are built from complementary differences.

Nobody understood everything.

Nobody needed to.

The collective knowledge was larger than any individual contribution.

At the time, however, we were not thinking about community theory, leadership principles, or organizational culture.

We were simply living inside it.

The island was forming around us while we remained too busy to notice.

And the strange thing about islands is that people often realize they are on one only after they have already stopped wanting to leave.

The clearest evidence that Spotify had become its own world arrived through a realization that should have been obvious much earlier.

One day, while discussing an upcoming activity, I noticed that many of the people involved had never actually met each other in person.

At first, that sounded ridiculous.

Then I thought about it for a moment and realized it was completely true.

We knew each other's habits.

We knew each other's schedules.

We knew who replied instantly and who disappeared for six hours before responding with a perfectly reasonable explanation.

We knew who preferred calls over messages.

We knew who could somehow transform a five-minute discussion into a forty-minute discussion.

We knew who was likely to volunteer for additional work and who needed to be protected from volunteering for additional work.

Yet despite all of that familiarity, many of us existed only as names on screens.

The community felt real.

The geography was digital.

That contradiction fascinated me.

One evening, the topic came up during a discussion.

Someone casually mentioned that it would be strange meeting everyone in person one day.

The statement immediately captured everybody's attention.

Within minutes, people were imagining different scenarios.

Someone predicted nobody would recognize each other.

Someone else argued that everybody would be exactly the same as expected.

A third person suggested that half the community would spend the first hour trying to remember names.

The predictions became increasingly creative.

The confidence became increasingly questionable.

The entertainment value increased accordingly.

What started as a casual observation gradually evolved into a larger conversation about the community itself.

People began sharing stories.

The first event they participated in.

The first meeting they attended.

The first conversation that made them feel comfortable.

The first friendship they built.

As the discussion continued, a pattern started emerging.

Everybody's story was different.

Yet the emotional destination was surprisingly similar.

Most people had arrived expecting activities.

Many stayed because of people.

That distinction appeared again and again.

Some joined because they loved sports.

Some joined because they wanted experience.

Some joined because they were curious.

Very few expected the community to become meaningful.

That part happened accidentally.

The best things often do.

I remember listening to the conversation and realizing how unusual the entire situation actually was.

Most online communities struggle to maintain engagement.

Many disappear entirely after the initial excitement fades.

Sportify seemed to be moving in the opposite direction.

The longer people stayed, the more connected they became.

The relationships were strengthening instead of weakening.

The conversations were becoming richer instead of repetitive.

The culture was becoming stronger instead of fading.

That kind of growth rarely happens by accident.

It happens because people invest in each other.

The same principle could be seen inside Sportify HER.

The initiative had started as an effort to improve participation.

It was becoming something much larger.

Game nights that were originally expected to attract a handful of participants started attracting more.

Conversations expanded.

New friendships appeared.

Students who had initially remained quiet became active contributors.

People who had joined hesitantly began inviting others.

Momentum was building.

Not through marketing.

Not through pressure.

Through belonging.

Belonging is one of the most powerful forces in any community.

Once people feel it, they begin creating more of it for others.

The effect multiplies.

Looking back, I think that was what made Sportify different.

The society was never operating purely as an organizer of events.

It was creating spaces where people wanted to return.

The events provided opportunities.

The community provided reasons.

By the middle of the year, that distinction was becoming impossible to ignore.

A volleyball event might end.

A quiz might conclude.

A competition might finish.

The conversations continued.

The friendships continued.

The community remained.

That persistence created a strange sensation.

Sportify no longer felt like something people participated in.

It felt like a place they belonged to.

The island had become populated.

Its traditions were forming.

Its culture was developing.

Its stories were multiplying.

Most importantly, people were beginning to care about each other in ways that extended far beyond the original purpose of the society.

At the time, none of us considered that remarkable.

It simply felt normal.

Only much later would I realize how rare that feeling actually was.

Communities are easy to start.

Movements are much harder.

And somewhere during those months, without any announcement or grand plan, Sportify had quietly started becoming the second.

The moment that truly convinced me Sportify had become something special arrived during a completely ordinary evening.

Nobody had planned it.

Nobody had advertised it.

Nobody would have included it in a report.

That was precisely why it mattered.

A community interaction was taking place online. The original objective was simple enough. People were supposed to join, spend some time together, play a few games, talk, laugh, and leave.

A perfectly normal activity.

At least on paper.

What actually happened was very different.

The event started normally. People joined gradually. Conversations began cautiously. A few familiar names appeared. Some new participants entered the call. Others arrived late and immediately started asking questions that had already been answered several times.

The usual chaos.

For a while, everything remained predictable.

Then people became comfortable.

That was when the atmosphere changed.

The formal structure disappeared.

The call stopped feeling like an event and started feeling like a gathering of friends.

People started teasing each other.

Old jokes resurfaced.

New jokes were created.

Someone accidentally said something ridiculous and spent the next twenty minutes regretting it because nobody allowed the comment to die peacefully.

The entire discussion developed a life of its own.

I remember sitting there and simply watching.

Not because I had nothing to say.

Because I was fascinated.

Many of the people talking had never met each other physically.

Some lived in different cities.

Some lived in different states.

Some had joined the community only recently.

Yet the conversation felt effortless.

The comfort felt genuine.

Nobody appeared to be performing.

Nobody appeared to be pretending.

People were simply enjoying each other's company.

That realization stayed with me.

Student communities often spend enormous amounts of energy trying to increase participation.

Participation is important.

But participation alone is not enough.

The real goal is connection.

Connection is what makes people return.

Connection is what transforms attendance into belonging.

And that evening was full of it.

At one point, the discussion drifted toward first impressions.

That was a mistake.

Not because the topic was inappropriate.

Because the honesty was dangerous.

People started revealing what they had initially thought about each other.

Some of the answers were surprisingly accurate.

Many were hilariously wrong.

One person admitted they had assumed somebody else was intimidating.

Another confessed they thought a certain team member was much older than they actually were.

Several participants discovered that the personalities they had imagined from messages were completely different from reality.

The reactions were immediate.

Defenses were attempted.

Evidence was demanded.

Nobody escaped.

For nearly an hour, the conversation revolved around misunderstandings, assumptions, and stories from earlier months.

The laughter was constant.

What struck me most was that nobody seemed eager for the evening to end.

The activity itself had stopped being the focus long ago.

People remained because they enjoyed the people.

That distinction is important.

Events create opportunities.

Relationships create memories.

One can be scheduled.

The other cannot.

As the evening continued, I noticed something else.

The same phenomenon was happening across the society.

Not just in one group.

Not just in one initiative.

Everywhere.

The design team had developed its own culture.

The outreach team had developed its own culture.

Sportify HER had developed its own culture.

The events team had developed its own culture.

Yet somehow all of those smaller cultures remained connected to a larger one.

People moved between them naturally.

Ideas moved between them naturally.

Friendships moved between them naturally.

The society was beginning to feel less like a collection of departments and more like a living ecosystem.

Nobody designed it that way.

It emerged naturally.

Perhaps that is why it worked.

The strongest communities are rarely manufactured.

They grow.

Slowly.

Organically.

One conversation at a time.

That night eventually ended the same way most memorable nights do.

Not with a grand conclusion.

Not with a significant announcement.

People simply left one by one.

Someone said goodnight.

Someone else remembered an unfinished discussion and promised to continue it later.

A few final jokes appeared.

The participant count gradually decreased.

Then the call ended.

The screen went dark.

The evening was over.

And yet the feeling remained.

I sat there for several minutes afterward thinking about how unusual the entire thing was.

Nobody had joined that community expecting it to matter this much.

Most people had arrived looking for activities.

Many had found friendships.

Without realizing it, Sportify had become a place where people belonged.

The island was no longer under construction.

People were building homes on it.

As the months passed, I began noticing a pattern that seemed almost impossible at first.

The people who cared the most were rarely the people who received the most attention.

That sounds unfair.

It probably is.

Yet it is true in almost every community.

Most participants see the final product.

They see the event.

They see the poster.

They see the announcement.

They see the results.

What they rarely see are the dozens of conversations, decisions, revisions, and small acts of effort that make those things possible.

Sportify was full of those invisible contributions.

The more time I spent inside the society, the more obvious they became.

A designer staying awake to finish a graphic before a deadline.

A volunteer answering questions long after an event had ended.

A department member helping another team despite having no obligation to do so.

Someone noticing a problem before it became visible to everyone else.

Someone else quietly fixing it.

Most of these moments never became stories.

That was the point.

They happened because people cared about the outcome, not because they expected recognition.

Communities are built from those moments.

Not the dramatic ones.

The ordinary ones.

I remember realizing this during a discussion about future plans.

The conversation itself was fairly normal. Several people were sharing ideas, discussing possibilities, and debating what Sportify could become over the next few months.

What interested me wasn't the discussion.

It was the assumption underneath it.

Nobody was asking whether the society would grow.

The discussion had already moved beyond that question.

People were talking about how it would grow.

The shift was subtle.

The significance was not.

At some point, confidence had replaced uncertainty.

Not arrogance.

Confidence.

There is a difference.

Arrogance assumes success is guaranteed.

Confidence believes success is possible.

The people around me belonged firmly in the second category.

They were optimistic enough to dream and realistic enough to work for it.

That combination is surprisingly powerful.

Perhaps that is why the island kept expanding.

New people arrived.

New friendships formed.

New initiatives appeared.

The community grew larger without losing the familiarity that had made it special in the first place.

That balance is difficult to maintain.

Most organizations eventually become either efficient or personal.

Very few manage to remain both.

Sportify somehow continued doing it.

Looking back, I think the reason was simple.

The society never became the center of attention.

The people remained the center.

Every event existed because somebody cared.

Every initiative existed because somebody believed it was worth trying.

Every success belonged to a group rather than an individual.

That culture created a sense of ownership that spread naturally throughout the community.

People didn't feel like participants.

They felt like builders.

And builders behave differently.

They invest.

They contribute.

They stay.

The strange thing is that none of us spent much time discussing these ideas directly.

Nobody sat down and announced that a movement was being created.

Nobody delivered speeches about culture.

Nobody wrote mission statements explaining what made the community special.

The culture emerged naturally through actions.

A hundred small decisions.

A thousand ordinary interactions.

Countless conversations that seemed insignificant at the time.

That is how most meaningful things are built.

Slowly enough that nobody notices until the structure already exists.

By the time spring began giving way to summer, the island no longer felt temporary.

It felt permanent.

The friendships felt permanent.

The routines felt permanent.

The conversations felt permanent.

The future seemed comfortably predictable.

That illusion would not survive the year.

Life rarely allows such comforts to last forever.

But at the time, we did not know that.

We were still living inside the beginning of the story.

Paradox remained somewhere ahead of us.

The chaos remained somewhere ahead of us.

The memories remained somewhere ahead of us.

For now, all we knew was that the community was growing, the dreams were becoming larger, and the spreadsheets were multiplying at a rate that should probably have alarmed somebody.

Nobody seemed alarmed.

In fact, many of us were excited.

Because every new spreadsheet represented a possibility.

Every new possibility represented a conversation.

And every conversation represented another step toward a future that was beginning to feel bigger than any of us had imagined.

That future, as it turned out, was already closer than we thought.

And its first signs appeared exactly where all dangerous ideas seem to begin.

Inside a Google Sheet.

Chapter 4

Dreams Written in Google Sheets

Every large project has a birthplace.

Some begin inside conference rooms.

Some begin inside classrooms.

Some begin during carefully planned strategy sessions attended by people who know exactly what they are doing.

Paradox began inside a spreadsheet.

That statement sounds like a joke.

Unfortunately, it is true.

By the beginning of 2026, spreadsheets had become the unofficial language of Sportify. Whenever somebody had an idea, a spreadsheet appeared. Whenever a discussion became serious, another spreadsheet appeared. Whenever a spreadsheet became too large, somebody created a second spreadsheet to manage the first one.

Nobody questioned this process anymore.

The spreadsheets simply existed.

Like weather.

Or gravity.

Or deadlines.

One evening, while reviewing updates from various departments, I opened a document that would eventually become far more important than any of us realized at the time.

At first glance, it looked ordinary.

Rows.

Columns.

Names.

Dates.

Tasks.

The usual ingredients.

Then I noticed a tab.

The tab was labelled:

Paradox.

I clicked on it.

The contents were surprisingly small.

That was the first thing I remember.

Looking back now, knowing what Paradox would eventually become, the simplicity feels almost funny.

A handful of ideas.

Some rough plans.

A few notes.

Several possibilities.

Nothing about the document suggested that it would eventually influence thousands of participants across multiple events.

Nothing about it suggested chaos.

Nothing about it suggested memories.

It was simply a collection of ideas waiting for somebody to believe in them.

The strange thing about ambitious projects is that they always look manageable in the beginning.

That is one of the reasons people agree to them.

If the future revealed itself honestly from the start, most sensible people would immediately run away.

Instead, large projects introduce themselves gradually.

First comes excitement.

Then optimism.

Then planning.

Only later do complications arrive.

At that stage, we were still living in the optimistic section of the story.

The discussions surrounding Paradox were growing more frequent every week. Event ideas were beginning to take shape. Potential formats were being discussed. Departments were slowly identifying responsibilities. Possibilities that had once sounded hypothetical were becoming actual plans.

Nobody seemed intimidated.

That should have been a warning sign.

I remember one discussion where registration projections became the central topic.

The conversation started innocently enough.

Someone asked how many participants we expected.

A perfectly reasonable question.

The answers, however, became increasingly ambitious.

One estimate became another.

Then another.

Then another.

Every new prediction was slightly larger than the previous one.

At some point, the discussion stopped sounding like forecasting and started sounding like collective optimism.

The fascinating part was that nobody appeared interested in reducing expectations.

People were not looking for reasons something would fail.

They were looking for ways it could succeed.

That mindset was everywhere.

Aman possessed it.

Varad possessed it.

Methelesh possessed it.

So did countless others.

The society had become filled with people who treated limitations as temporary obstacles rather than permanent realities.

Sometimes that approach worked beautifully.

Sometimes it created additional work.

Most of the time it did both.

The registration discussion continued for nearly an hour.

Scenarios were examined.

Ideas were proposed.

Concerns were raised.

Solutions appeared.

The numbers continued growing.

Eventually somebody pointed out that achieving those targets would require significantly more planning than we currently possessed.

The observation was entirely accurate.

Nobody seemed discouraged.

Instead, the conversation immediately shifted toward how that planning could be created.

That was the culture Sportify had developed.

Problems rarely ended discussions.

They started new ones.

As the weeks passed, the Paradox tab continued expanding.

New events appeared.

Existing ideas became more detailed.

Responsibilities became clearer.

Departments became busier.

Every update made the project feel slightly more real.

The future was beginning to acquire shape.

Most of us were too busy contributing to notice how quickly things were changing.

We were focused on the next update.

The next discussion.

The next task.

The next version.

The spreadsheet was growing.

So were the dreams written inside it.

The moment Paradox stopped feeling like a future event and started feeling like a challenge arrived during a planning discussion that should have been routine.

Instead, it became one of those conversations that quietly changes the direction of a year.

The agenda was simple enough. Various departments were sharing updates, discussing progress, and identifying areas that needed attention. Nobody expected the meeting to become memorable.

Those are usually the meetings that become memorable.

At some point, the discussion returned to registrations.

Again.

By then, registrations had become one of the favourite topics inside Sportify. Everyone wanted growth. Everyone wanted participation. Everyone wanted to create experiences that attracted people from across the community.

The question was never whether people would register.

The question was how many.

That difference matters.

Months earlier, the conversation had been about possibility.

Now it was about scale.

I remember watching the discussion unfold and realizing how different the atmosphere felt compared to the beginning of the year.

Back then, many of the ideas lived comfortably inside the category of "maybe."

Maybe this event would work.

Maybe people would participate.

Maybe the community would respond positively.

Now the assumptions had changed.

The events were happening.

The planning was happening.

The execution was happening.

The only uncertainty that remained was how large everything might become.

Someone suggested a target.

Another person suggested a larger one.

A third person argued that both numbers were too conservative.

The debate intensified.

What made the discussion entertaining was that every estimate sounded slightly unreasonable when compared to the previous one.

Yet nobody seemed willing to stop.

Every ambitious prediction inspired an even more ambitious prediction.

Every concern inspired a solution.

Every solution inspired another possibility.

At one point, Ansh attempted to restore order by asking practical questions.

This was one of his recurring responsibilities.

Whenever optimism reached dangerous levels, Ansh arrived carrying reality.

The interaction followed a familiar pattern.

Someone proposed a large target.

Ansh pointed out a logistical challenge.

Someone else proposed a solution.

Ansh identified another challenge.

Aman proposed two additional solutions.

The cycle continued.

Looking back, it resembled a tennis match between ambition and practicality.

Neither side ever truly won.

Fortunately, both sides were necessary.

Ambition without practicality becomes fantasy.

Practicality without ambition becomes limitation.

The reason Spotify continued growing was that people representing both perspectives remained in the room.

The dreamers kept pushing forward.

The planners prevented everyone from driving directly off a cliff.

Together they somehow produced progress.

That meeting continued for much longer than originally intended.

Nobody appeared eager to leave.

Ideas were flowing too quickly.

Possibilities were expanding too rapidly.

The future felt too exciting.

At one point, I opened the Paradox spreadsheet while the discussion continued.

The document looked different now.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

A few months earlier, it had contained ideas.

Now it contained commitments.

A few months earlier, it had contained possibilities.

Now it contained responsibilities.

The transformation had happened gradually enough that nobody noticed it in real time.

Only now, staring at the growing collection of plans, timelines, departments, and event concepts, did I realize how much had changed.

The dream was becoming tangible.

That realization brought a strange mixture of excitement and pressure.

Excitement because the vision was finally taking shape.

Pressure because visions eventually demand execution.

Dreams are easy.

Reality requires work.

A great deal of work.

The strange thing was that nobody appeared intimidated by that reality.

If anything, people seemed energized by it.

Every challenge made discussions more interesting.

Every obstacle inspired creativity.

Every new requirement became another problem to solve together.

That collective confidence was infectious.

The more time you spent around people who believed something was possible, the more possible it started feeling.

Perhaps that was the true power of those meetings.

Not the decisions.

Not the spreadsheets.

Not even the plans.

The belief.

The shared belief that something remarkable could be built if enough people cared enough to build it.

And by that stage, plenty of people cared.

The proof existed everywhere.

It existed inside the design team's endless stream of content.

It existed inside Sportify HER's growing community.

It existed inside the technical systems quietly being built behind the scenes.

It existed inside late-night discussions, impossible ideas, and conversations that refused to end.

Most of all, it existed inside the Paradox tab itself.

Because every row in that spreadsheet represented somebody choosing to believe that the future could be larger than the present.

That is how most meaningful projects begin.

Not with certainty.

With belief.

And by the middle of the year, belief was becoming one resource Sportify possessed in unlimited supply.

The spreadsheet changed dramatically over the following weeks.

At first, it had contained possibilities.

Now it was beginning to contain commitments.

Every few days, a new discussion would produce another update. A blank section would gain details. A rough concept would become an actual event. A possibility would slowly transform into a responsibility assigned to a real person.

The process was surprisingly addictive.

Every update made the future feel slightly more tangible.

Every completed section made the project feel slightly more real.

I remember opening the Paradox tab one evening and realizing that the list of planned events had grown far larger than I expected.

The names themselves were exciting.

Kampus Run.

IPL Auction Showdown.

Paradox Champions League.

Paradox Premier League.

VolleyVibes.

Paradox Badminton League.

Echo // Prometheus.

Several others.

Each event represented a separate challenge.

A separate team.

A separate set of problems waiting patiently in the future.

At the time, however, those problems still looked exciting.

Reality had not arrived yet.

Only imagination.

That stage is always enjoyable.

The event discussions developed personalities of their own.

Kampus Run conversations felt ambitious. Every discussion somehow expanded beyond the original idea. People talked about routes, experiences, participation, partnerships, visibility, and possibilities that seemed increasingly ambitious every time they were mentioned.

The football events carried a different energy entirely. Conversations around Paradox Champions League and Paradox Premier League often felt competitive long before a single match had been played. People discussed formats, teams, participation structures, and logistics with the seriousness normally reserved for international diplomacy.

VolleyVibes generated its own excitement.

The discussions surrounding it were particularly satisfying because people genuinely believed the event could become something memorable. There was enthusiasm attached to the idea from the very beginning.

The same pattern repeated elsewhere.

Every event attracted people who believed in it.

That belief mattered.

Projects rarely succeed because of plans alone.

They succeed because somebody cares enough to keep pushing when the plans stop working.

And plans always stop working eventually.

What fascinated me most was the scale of the collective imagination.

Every department seemed to be dreaming simultaneously.

The design team was imagining campaigns.

The technical team was imagining systems.

The outreach team was imagining participation.

The events team was imagining experiences.

Everyone appeared to be building a different piece of the same future.

At some point during one discussion, I zoomed out and looked at the entire spreadsheet.

Not one section.

All of it.

For a few seconds, I simply stared.

The document was enormous.

Pages of ideas.

Pages of responsibilities.

Pages of plans.

Rows connected to other rows.

Tasks connected to other tasks.

Discussions connected to future discussions.

The spreadsheet looked less like a planning document and more like the blueprint of a city that had not been built yet.

The realization made me smile.

A few months earlier, most of these ideas had existed only as conversations.

Now they occupied real space.

The future was becoming visible.

I remember sending a screenshot to Aman.

His response arrived almost immediately.

"Looks good."

That was all.

No dramatic reaction.

No speech.

No celebration.

Just two words.

I stared at the message for several seconds.

The response felt absurdly calm considering what I had just sent him.

The spreadsheet looked like the planning infrastructure of a medium-sized civilization.

"That's all you have to say?" I replied.

His answer arrived a few moments later.

"Still a lot left."

That response captured Aman perfectly.

No matter how much progress happened, his attention immediately shifted toward what remained.

The achievement existed.

The next challenge was already waiting.

Looking back, I think many of us shared that mindset.

Nobody spent much time admiring what had been completed.

There was always another discussion.

Another update.

Another task.

Another improvement.

The future remained unfinished.

That constant forward motion became one of the defining characteristics of the months before Paradox.

People were not standing still long enough to become comfortable.

The dream kept growing.

The spreadsheet kept growing.

The responsibilities kept growing.

Strangely enough, so did the excitement.

Perhaps because everybody could feel the same thing.

The machine was beginning to move.

Slowly at first.

Almost invisibly.

But it was moving.

And once momentum starts building inside a group of ambitious twenty-year-olds, it becomes surprisingly difficult to stop.

None of us wanted to stop anyway.

For the first time, Paradox no longer felt like an event somebody else was organizing.

It felt like something we were building ourselves.

That difference changed everything.

The dream no longer belonged inside a spreadsheet.

It had started becoming reality.

The first indication that we might have a problem arrived quietly.

Nobody panicked.

Nobody called an emergency meeting.

Nobody dramatically announced that the situation was becoming complicated.

Instead, the realization appeared the way most important realizations do.

One calendar entry at a time.

One deadline at a time.

One conversation at a time.

I was reviewing a planning document one evening when I noticed something unsettling.

The number of tasks was growing.

The number of people was growing.

The number of ideas was growing.

The number of available days was absolutely not growing.

That final detail seemed particularly inconvenient.

At first, I assumed I was overthinking things.

Then I opened another document.

The problem remained.

Then another.

The problem became worse.

Then another.

By the fourth spreadsheet, the situation was becoming difficult to ignore.

Everything was moving forward.

The issue was that everything was moving forward simultaneously.

Kampus Run required attention.

The football events required attention.

Badminton required attention.

Promotions required attention.

Outreach required attention.

Technical systems required attention.

Volunteer planning required attention.

Community engagement required attention.

Every department was making progress.

Every department also required support.

For the first time, the scale of what we were attempting became visible.

Not intimidating.

Not yet.

Just visible.

That distinction is important.

Fear usually appears later.

The first stage is awareness.

I remember bringing the topic up during a discussion.

Not as a complaint.

More as an observation.

Something along the lines of:

"Does anyone else feel like we have an unreasonable number of things happening at the same time?"

The reaction was immediate.

Not because people disagreed.

Because everybody had already noticed.

The conversation that followed was fascinating.

Nobody suggested reducing ambition.

Nobody suggested cutting plans.

Nobody suggested lowering expectations.

The entire discussion revolved around a different question.

How do we make it work?

Looking back, that response explains a great deal about the people involved.

Most groups encountering a larger workload immediately begin discussing limitations.

This group immediately began discussing solutions.

Varad started talking about operational structures.

Methelesh began discussing systems.

Others started identifying responsibilities.

Ideas appeared from every direction.

Within minutes, the conversation had transformed from a recognition of the problem into a search for answers.

The optimism remained intact.

Reality had simply joined the meeting.

That balance was becoming increasingly important.

Dreams are useful.

Execution is essential.

The months leading into Paradox required both.

As planning intensified, another interesting change began taking place.

People started behaving like adults. Or at least pretending to.

The distinction was sometimes difficult to identify.

Many of us were still students trying to survive assignments, examinations, internships, deadlines, and the occasional reminder that real life existed outside Sportify.

Yet inside meetings, people discussed budgets.

Timelines.

Logistics.

Operations.

Risk management.

Resource allocation.

Contingency planning.

The conversations sounded remarkably professional.

Then somebody would accidentally share a meme in the wrong group and destroy the illusion completely.

That combination became one of my favourite things about that period.

Nobody was pretending to be something they weren't.

We were simply growing into responsibilities faster than expected.

The process was occasionally awkward.

Frequently chaotic.

Surprisingly effective.

One evening, after a particularly long planning discussion, I closed my laptop and sat quietly for a few minutes.

The room was silent.

The documents were closed.

The notifications had finally stopped.

For the first time in weeks, there was no immediate task demanding attention.

That silence gave me enough space to think.

The realization that arrived was both exciting and slightly terrifying.

The dream was no longer hypothetical.

Success was possible.

Failure was also possible.

For months, Paradox had existed primarily as an idea.

Ideas are comfortable.

Ideas cannot disappoint you.

Reality is different.

Reality eventually demands results.

And for the first time, results were approaching.

The countdown had started whether we acknowledged it or not.

June was no longer sitting comfortably on the horizon.

It was moving toward us.

Every completed task brought it closer.

Every meeting brought it closer.

Every spreadsheet brought it closer.

The future we had spent months discussing was beginning to arrive.

Most of us still believed we had plenty of time.

Experience would soon prove otherwise.

But for now, the optimism remained stronger than the concern.

The machine was growing.

The plans were expanding.

The people were stepping up.

And somewhere inside a growing collection of spreadsheets, documents, meetings, and conversations, a group of students was slowly convincing itself that it might actually pull this off.

That belief would carry us a long way.

It would also be tested much sooner than anyone expected.

Chapter 5

Everyone Pretended To Be Adults

One of the strangest parts of student leadership is the moment you realize nobody is coming to take over.

As children, most of us grow up believing that important things are handled by important people. There is always an adult somewhere in the background. A teacher. A parent. A manager. A supervisor. Someone with more experience than us making sure everything stays under control.

Then one day you find yourself sitting inside a meeting discussing budgets, logistics, deadlines, risk assessments, venue requirements, participant experiences, volunteer structures, and operational plans.

And slowly, almost reluctantly, you realize something unsettling.

The adults are you.

The realization is particularly uncomfortable when you are twenty years old.

By that stage, Paradox was no longer a collection of exciting ideas inside a spreadsheet. The event was approaching. Conversations were becoming more serious. Decisions were becoming more consequential. Mistakes no longer existed in theory.

Mistakes now had names, dates, and deadlines attached to them.

The transition happened gradually.

Nobody announced it.

Nobody declared that the planning phase was ending and the execution phase was beginning.

The atmosphere simply changed.

Discussions became sharper.

Follow-ups became faster.

Timelines became more important.

Questions that had once seemed distant suddenly required answers.

One evening, I found myself sitting in a meeting where multiple departments were reviewing progress simultaneously. Looking around, I had a brief moment of amusement.

The conversation sounded remarkably professional.

People were discussing resource allocation.

Operational dependencies.

Communication timelines.

Participant engagement.

Risk mitigation.

The vocabulary alone was impressive.

If someone had joined the meeting without context, they might have assumed they were listening to experienced professionals managing a major project.

What they would not have seen was what happened five minutes earlier.

Five minutes earlier, half the people in the meeting had been arguing about something completely ridiculous.

That contrast never stopped being funny.

The transformation from student to organizer happened instantly whenever responsibility appeared.

Then disappeared immediately afterward.

The duality was fascinating.

I remember one discussion where a genuine operational challenge emerged. The details are not important. What mattered was the reaction.

Nobody panicked.

Nobody blamed anyone.

Nobody waited for somebody else to solve it.

The conversation immediately shifted toward solutions.

Questions were asked.

Responsibilities were identified.

Options were discussed.

People volunteered.

The issue gradually became manageable.

Watching that process unfold felt strangely satisfying.

Not because the problem existed.

Because of how people responded to it.

A few months earlier, many of us would have approached the same situation very differently.

Experience changes groups.

Shared responsibility changes them even faster.

The people sitting inside those meetings were not the same people who had started the year.

They were more confident.

More capable.

More comfortable making decisions.

Most importantly, they trusted each other.

Trust reduces hesitation.

When people trust the individuals around them, they become willing to attempt larger things.

That willingness was becoming visible everywhere.

The design team was handling increasing demands without losing momentum.

The technical team was building systems that continued expanding behind the scenes.

Outreach efforts were becoming more sophisticated.

Community engagement was becoming stronger.

The event structures were becoming clearer.

Every department appeared to be maturing at the same time.

The society itself felt older than it had a few months earlier.

Not older in age.

Older in experience.

The growth was impossible to miss.

At the center of all this activity was a strange contradiction.

Nobody actually felt like an expert.

That was the secret.

People looked confident because confidence was necessary.

Most of us were still figuring things out as we went.

Every meeting contained decisions nobody had made before.

Every challenge contained situations nobody had previously encountered.

Every success created new expectations.

The learning never stopped.

Yet despite that uncertainty, progress continued.

Looking back, I think that was one of the most impressive things about the entire journey.

Nobody waited until they felt ready.

If we had waited for that moment, nothing would have happened.

People stepped forward first.

Confidence arrived later.

That pattern repeated throughout the year.

Someone accepted responsibility.

Someone learned.

Someone improved.

Then the cycle began again.

The process was imperfect.

The results often weren't.

At some point during those months, I stopped seeing Sportify as a student society and started seeing it as a collection of people growing in real time.

The events mattered.

The registrations mattered.

The achievements mattered.

But the most interesting story was happening underneath all of it.

People were changing.

And most of them did not even realize it.

The future was approaching quickly now.

The spreadsheets were no longer predictions.

The plans were no longer theoretical.

The responsibilities were becoming real.

June was getting closer.

And for the first time, everyone could feel it.

The moment that finally made everything feel real arrived during a discussion that was supposed to be completely routine.

I know that description sounds suspicious.

Most memorable moments in this story begin exactly the same way.

The meeting itself was focused on progress updates. Different teams were sharing what had been completed, what remained unfinished, and what needed attention over the coming weeks. By then, everyone had settled comfortably into their responsibilities. The conversations were productive. The planning was organized. The atmosphere was optimistic.

Then somebody asked a question.

The question itself was simple.

"How many weeks do we have left?"

For a few seconds, nobody answered.

Not because the answer was difficult.

Because nobody had actually stopped to think about it.

Eventually someone checked the calendar.

The number that followed was not alarming.

It should have been.

What surprised me wasn't the number itself.

It was the reaction.

The room became quieter.

Not dramatically.

Just enough for people to start doing calculations inside their heads.

Everyone was suddenly looking at the same timeline from a different perspective.

Until that moment, most discussions had focused on work remaining.

Now people were comparing work remaining against time remaining.

That is a completely different exercise.

The realization spread gradually across the conversation.

Not panic.

Awareness.

A design deadline suddenly felt closer.

A technical milestone suddenly felt closer.

An operational requirement suddenly felt closer.

Everything was still achievable.

The margin for error was becoming smaller.

I remember opening one of the planning documents while the discussion continued.

The list of pending items was not particularly frightening.

The speed at which time was moving was.

For months, we had been talking about June as though it existed in another universe.

A distant destination.

A future problem.

A future responsibility.

A future adventure.

Now June was becoming a date.

Dates have a way of making things real.

The conversation that followed was one of the most mature discussions I had seen all year.

Not because everybody suddenly became experts.

Because people accepted reality without losing optimism.

That balance is difficult.

Many groups respond to pressure by becoming pessimistic.

Others respond by pretending pressure does not exist.

The people around me chose a third option.

They acknowledged the challenge and continued moving forward.

Responsibilities were reorganized.

Priorities were clarified.

Tasks were redistributed.

People volunteered for additional work despite already having more than enough.

The meeting became a problem-solving session.

Watching it unfold, I found myself thinking about how different the group felt compared to the beginning of the year.

The same people were sitting in front of their screens.

The same names appeared beside the same profile pictures.

Yet they were not the same individuals.

Experience had changed them.

Responsibility had changed them.

Months of working together had changed them.

Nobody was pretending anymore.

Or perhaps we were all pretending slightly less.

The distinction hardly mattered.

The results were visible.

The confidence was earned now.

Not borrowed.

Not imagined.

Earned.

By the time the discussion ended, the atmosphere had changed.

The optimism remained.

The excitement remained.

The ambition remained.

But something new had joined them.

Urgency.

Not unhealthy urgency.

Not panic.

The healthy kind.

The kind that appears when people realize something important is approaching and decide they want to be ready.

That feeling followed us into the following weeks.

The conversations became sharper.

The planning became faster.

The follow-ups became more immediate.

The machine that had spent months being assembled was beginning to accelerate.

And once momentum reached a certain point, there was no realistic way to slow it down.

Not that anyone wanted to.

The truth was that we had all been waiting for this phase.

The spreadsheets were useful.

The planning was necessary.

The dreaming was enjoyable.

But eventually every project reaches a moment where preparation must give way to action.

That moment was approaching.

Fast.

For months, Paradox had existed as an idea we were building toward.

Now it was becoming an event that was building toward us.

The difference felt subtle.

It wasn't.

And somewhere inside that realization, for the first time all year, I caught myself thinking the same thing everyone else was probably thinking.

Maybe we weren't as ready as we believed.

The surprising part was that nobody considered that a reason to stop.

If anything, it became another reason to keep going.

That stubborn optimism would carry us through many things over the coming months.

Chaos.

Stress.

Exhaustion.

Success.

Failure.

Memories.

At the time, however, all of that still belonged to the future.

June remained ahead of us.

Close enough to see.

Far enough to underestimate.

And that was exactly what made it dangerous.

The funny thing is that if you had asked any of us during those weeks whether we were ready for June, most of us would probably have answered yes.

Not because we were overconfident.

Because we genuinely believed we had time.

That belief appeared everywhere.

It appeared in postponed discussions.

It appeared in unfinished documents.

It appeared in tasks that could "easily be completed next week."

It appeared in conversations that ended with some variation of, "We'll figure it out later."

Later is one of the most dangerous words in project management.

At twenty years old, however, it sounds perfectly reasonable.

The problem with later is that it eventually becomes now.

And by the time people realize the transition has happened, the calendar has usually moved much faster than expected.

I remember a particular evening when I was reviewing updates from different teams. The work itself was progressing well. Most departments were moving forward. Tasks were being completed. New ideas were still appearing with impressive regularity.

From the outside, everything looked encouraging.

Then I looked at the date.

For a few seconds, I genuinely thought I had misread it.

Not because the date was surprising.

Because time had moved without asking for permission.

The previous months seemed close enough to touch.

January felt recent.

February felt recent.

March felt recent.

Yet somehow they were already behind us.

The realization was strange.

Not frightening.

Not yet.

Just strange.

I think many people experienced something similar during that period.

The work was happening so consistently that nobody noticed how quickly the weeks were disappearing.

Every day contained meetings.

Every week contained plans.

Every month contained progress.

The individual days felt long.

The months felt short.

That contradiction has never made much sense to me.

Yet it appears repeatedly in life.

Looking back, I think that was one of the reasons those months felt special.

Nobody was waiting for them to become memories.

We were too busy living inside them.

Nobody was trying to preserve the moment.

Nobody was documenting every conversation.

Nobody was taking photographs after every meeting.

Life was simply happening.

The friendships were growing naturally.

The responsibilities were growing naturally.

The story was growing naturally.

And because everything felt normal, nobody realized how quickly it was all moving.

Years later, when people remember an important period of their lives, they often imagine that they knew it was important while it was happening.

That is rarely true.

Most meaningful chapters disguise themselves as ordinary days.

A late-night discussion.

A random phone call.

A meeting that runs longer than expected.

A joke that becomes part of the culture.

A friendship that quietly becomes important.

None of those moments announce themselves.

They simply happen.

Only later do they acquire significance.

That thought stayed with me for a long time.

Partly because it was true.

Partly because I was beginning to sense that something unusual was approaching.

Not a specific event.

Not a specific challenge.

Just a feeling.

The feeling that the pace was changing.

The machine was moving faster now.

The conversations were becoming more focused.

The planning was becoming more urgent.

The future was getting closer.

Everyone could feel it.

Nobody said it out loud.

Perhaps because saying it would have made it real.

And despite all the evidence sitting in front of us, a part of me still believed there was plenty of time left.

After all, June was still far away.

At least that was the story we kept telling ourselves.

The calendar disagreed.

Reality disagreed.

The growing stack of responsibilities certainly disagreed.

But optimism has a remarkable ability to ignore inconvenient information.

For months, that optimism had served us well.

It had helped us dream bigger. Build faster.

Attempt things we might otherwise have avoided.

Now it was preparing to face its first real test.

Because the months of planning were ending.

The months of preparation were ending.

The months of imagining what Paradox could become were ending.

Very soon, people would stop discussing the event.

They would start living it.

And none of us - not Aman, not me, not Varad, not Methesh, not Deepak, not Jahanvi, not anyone else - had any idea how much those few weeks would eventually mean.

For now, however, all of that remained hidden somewhere in the future.

The beaches.

The hostels.

The friendships.

The chaos.

The victories.

The mistakes.

The memories.

Everything still belonged to a version of the story that had not happened yet.

We were standing on the edge of it without realizing it.

Convinced we still had more time.

Convinced the biggest moments were still distant.

Convinced June was still far away.

It wasn't.

Chapter 6

June Was Still Far Away

The strange thing about countdowns is that they only feel real when the number becomes small.

Until then, the future exists as an abstract concept.

You know it is approaching.

You acknowledge its existence.

You discuss it regularly.

Yet emotionally, it remains distant.

That was exactly how June felt.

Everyone knew it was coming.

Nobody truly believed it had arrived.

By the final weeks of preparation, the calendar had become a source of constant contradiction. On paper, time was disappearing rapidly. Entire months seemed to vanish between one meeting and the next. Deadlines were arriving faster than expected. Discussions that once belonged to the future had become discussions about the present.

Yet emotionally, many of us still felt as though we were preparing for something far away.

Human beings are remarkably bad at understanding the speed of time.

Especially when they are busy.

The days themselves felt long.

Meetings continued.

Discussions continued.

Tasks continued.

Life continued.

Every morning brought something new to solve.

Every evening ended with something else waiting for tomorrow.

The routine became so familiar that it was easy to forget what all of it was leading toward.

I remember one evening when I was reviewing updates after a particularly long day. My laptop screen was filled with the usual collection of documents, spreadsheets, messages, and notifications. Somewhere between one update and another, I paused and opened the calendar.

The reaction was immediate.

Not dramatic.

Not emotional.

Just confusion.

For a moment, I genuinely struggled to understand where the previous months had gone.

January felt recent.

The first planning discussions felt recent.

The early spreadsheets felt recent.

The late-night calls that had once seemed like the beginning of something felt recent.

Yet the calendar insisted otherwise.

The calendar had evidence.

The calendar always wins.

That realization stayed with me longer than expected.

Because it wasn't only the timeline that had changed.

The people had changed too.

Looking around the society, I could see the difference everywhere.

The confidence was different.

The conversations were different.

The expectations were different.

Months of shared work had transformed the group in subtle ways.

People trusted each other more.

Departments understood each other better.

Ideas moved faster.

Decisions happened faster.

Problems were solved faster.

The machine had become more efficient without anyone consciously deciding it should.

Experience had done the work for us.

That growth was one of the most rewarding parts of the journey.

Not because it happened perfectly.

Because it happened naturally.

Nobody attended a workshop and emerged transformed.

Nobody woke up one morning possessing new skills.

The improvement came through repetition.

Meeting after meeting.

Discussion after discussion.

Challenge after challenge.

The people who would eventually help run Paradox had spent months unknowingly preparing for it.

At the time, however, nobody was focused on personal growth.

People were focused on the next task.

The next update.

The next responsibility.

The future remained the priority.

That future was now close enough to see.

The signs were appearing everywhere.

Accommodation discussions became more frequent.

Operational planning became more detailed.

Department coordination became more important.

The conversations felt different now.

Not heavier.

More real.

The transition from preparation to reality had quietly begun.

Nobody announced it.

Nobody needed to.

Everyone could feel it.

One evening, during a discussion that had drifted far beyond its original purpose, somebody casually asked a question.

"What do you think it's actually going to be like?"

The room became unusually thoughtful.

The question sounded simple.

It wasn't.

For months, everyone had been planning the event.

Very few people had stopped to imagine experiencing it.

The responses varied.

Some people talked about registrations.

Others talked about venues.

Some talked about competitions.

Some talked about volunteers.

Most answers focused on logistics.

The interesting thing was that nobody predicted the things that would eventually matter most.

Nobody mentioned friendships.

Nobody mentioned beach walks.

Nobody mentioned late-night conversations inside hostels.

Nobody mentioned memories.

Nobody mentioned the people who would become impossible to forget.

At that stage, everyone still believed the story was about the event.

None of us realized the story was actually about the people.

Looking back, that misunderstanding feels strangely beautiful.

Perhaps life works that way on purpose.

If we knew exactly which moments would matter, we would spend too much time trying to preserve them and not enough time living them.

Fortunately, we did not know.

We were still standing before the beginning.

Still looking toward the future.

Still imagining what June might bring.

The irony was that June had already begun moving toward us.

Every completed task brought it closer.

Every meeting brought it closer.

Every conversation brought it closer.

Every goodbye before sleeping brought it closer.

The distance was shrinking whether we noticed it or not.

And then, one day, preparation stopped being the dominant emotion.

Travel plans appeared.

Accommodation details arrived.

People started packing.

Tickets were booked.

The abstract future finally acquired dates, times, and locations.

For months, Paradox had existed inside documents.

Now it was beginning to exist inside reality.

The transition felt almost unbelievable.

Not because it happened suddenly.

Because it had been happening slowly for so long.

The future we had spent months discussing was finally arriving.

None of us knew exactly what awaited us in Chennai.

None of us knew how the following weeks would unfold.

None of us knew that many of the memories defining this book had not happened yet.

We only knew one thing.

The waiting was almost over.

The planning was almost over.

The dreaming was almost over.

Reality was about to begin.

And somewhere beyond the train stations, airports, suitcases, schedules, and anticipation, Krishna Hostel was waiting.

For the first time all year, June was no longer far away.

It was here.

PART II

ARRIVALS

Every journey begins twice.

Once when you leave home.

*And once when you finally realize you've
arrived.*

The summer had begun.

Chapter 7

Krishna Hostel

Every event has two beginnings.

The official beginning is the one printed on posters, schedules and websites. It comes with dates, inauguration ceremonies and welcome speeches. Everyone knows when it is supposed to happen.

The real beginning is quieter.

It starts when the first suitcase is dragged across a hostel corridor, when the first familiar face appears after months of talking through screens, or when an empty room begins to look less like temporary accommodation and more like home.

For me, Paradox began on the afternoon of 7 June 2026, outside Room 367 of Krishna Hostel.

The journey to Chennai had been uneventful, which is usually the best kind of journey. Months of preparation had made reaching IIT Madras feel less like travelling somewhere new and more like finally arriving at a place I had already been visiting in my head for weeks. Every planning meeting, every spreadsheet and every late-night discussion had pointed toward this campus. The only difference was that this time I was actually standing inside it.

The June heat announced itself immediately.

Chennai never believed in gentle introductions. The air itself seemed warmer than expected, and within a few minutes I understood why people who studied there had mastered the art of walking from one patch of shade to another. Even before reaching the hostel, I had already accepted that surviving the week would require equal amounts of water, patience and functioning ceiling fans.

Krishna Hostel stood exactly as I had imagined it from the photographs I had seen over the past few months. There was nothing dramatic about it.

It was simply another student hostel on a large university campus. At least, that was how it looked on the first day.

By the time the week ended, I would find it impossible to think of it as just a building.

The registration process took only a few minutes. I collected my room details, picked up my luggage and started walking through the corridor searching for Room 367. The hostel was still relatively quiet. Doors were open here and there, a few students were unpacking their bags, and the occasional trolley rolled across the floor carrying enough luggage to suggest its owner had mistaken a week-long event for permanent relocation.

I stopped outside the room, looked once at the number on the door and pushed it open.

My roommate had already arrived.

Anshul Sati looked up from the bed as I walked in, and within a few minutes the room had already begun to feel occupied rather than assigned. Anshul was one of Sportify's coordinators and the Event Head for VolleyVibes. More importantly, he was one of those people every team quietly depends on. He never needed to be the loudest person in the room. His strength was consistency. Whenever something needed to be handled properly, Anshul was usually somewhere nearby making sure it happened.

Our first conversation was exactly what every roommate conversation at the beginning of an event tends to be.

How was the journey?

When did you reach?

Who else has arrived?

What all have you brought?

Do you think we're missing anything?

Nothing about that discussion felt extraordinary. Looking back, that is precisely what makes it memorable. At the time, we were not trying to create memories. We were simply two students settling into a hostel room before what we assumed would be a busy week.

Outside, the corridor remained unusually quiet.

That silence felt strange.

For months, Sportify had existed as a constant presence in my daily life. Every morning began with messages. Every evening ended with meetings. There was always another discussion waiting, another document to review, another event to refine. Yet after finally reaching the campus where all those plans would come to life, almost nobody from Sportify was actually there.

On 7 June, our entire society was represented by exactly three people.

Aman.

Anshul.

And me.

That was it.

The contrast was almost amusing. Online, Sportify felt enormous. In person, it could comfortably fit inside a single hostel room.

After unpacking whatever seemed immediately necessary and convincing ourselves that the rest could be organized later, we stepped out to find Aman. That turned out to be significantly easier than expected. Aman had an unusual relationship with work. If there was planning happening anywhere on campus, there was a very good chance he was already there or on his way to it.

We found him after a short walk, and within minutes the three of us were talking exactly as if we had never left our online meetings. The medium had changed. The conversations had not.

We spoke about registrations, departments, arrivals, pending tasks and everything that still remained before Paradox officially began. Somewhere during that conversation, I realized something that had escaped me while travelling.

For the first time in months, the people behind the spreadsheets had become real again.

No profile pictures.

No microphones.

No unstable internet connections.

Just three friends standing on a campus that, in a few days, would become one of the busiest places any of us had ever experienced.

Eventually, hunger interrupted the discussion.

Student leadership can survive delays, confusion and impossible deadlines.

It has never successfully survived skipping lunch.

The three of us walked towards Ishtara inside Himalaya Mess, where lunch that afternoon happened to be veg biryani. There are meals that become memorable because the food is exceptional.

This was not one of them.

I remember that lunch because of the conversation around it.

We talked about what the coming week might look like, which events would attract the biggest crowds, who was still travelling, and how strange it felt that after months of preparing for Paradox, the campus still looked perfectly ordinary.

Looking around, there was very little to suggest that one of the institute's biggest festivals was only days away. Students walked past us carrying notebooks instead of sports equipment. The roads remained peaceful. The hostels still felt half empty.

Everything appeared normal.

That normality would disappear very soon.

We finished lunch, returned our plates and stepped back into the afternoon heat. Aman checked the time before looking in my direction.

"We should leave."

I nodded.

Our destination was the Electronic Sciences Block.

Room 127.

At that moment, I thought we were simply going to attend another meeting.

I had absolutely no idea that the rest of the evening would become one of my favourite stories from the entire trip.

The walk from Himalaya Mess to the Electronic Sciences Block was not particularly long, but it was long enough for the three of us to notice how different the campus still felt from the version we had imagined over the past few months.

Whenever we had spoken about Paradox during online meetings, the festival had existed in our minds as something enormous. We pictured crowded walkways, volunteers running between venues, participants filling every available space and announcements echoing across the campus.

Instead, the roads were almost peaceful.

Students cycled past us without the slightest indication that one of the institute's biggest festivals was only a few days away. A few groups sat beneath the trees talking. Institute buses continued following their usual routes. The campus seemed completely unaware that hundreds of people would soon arrive and temporarily transform its rhythm.

Looking back, I am grateful we saw IIT Madras in that state first.

If our first memory had been the chaos, we would never have appreciated the calm.

The Electronic Sciences Block slowly came into view as we crossed another stretch of road. During the coming week, I would visit that building so many times that I would eventually stop noticing the walk altogether.

On that first afternoon, however, everything still felt new.

We climbed the stairs, reached Room 127 and quietly stepped inside.

The meeting was already underway.

Representatives from almost every department involved in Paradox occupied different rows of the classroom. Some were presenting updates while others listened, occasionally interrupting with questions or suggestions. Laptops remained open across the room, notebooks filled steadily with points to remember, and every few minutes someone would stand up to explain how preparations were progressing within their department.

At the front sat Kothai Ma'am, listening with the kind of patience that only comes from having seen many student teams before ours.

Aman glanced around the room before pointing towards the last bench in the centre row.

"Perfect."

I laughed.

"Why is the last bench always perfect?"

"Because nobody looks back."

It was difficult to argue with that logic.

We settled into our seats and immediately became the least productive members of an otherwise very productive meeting.

To be fair, we were listening.

Mostly.

One of the unexpected pleasures of sitting at the back of a room is that you get to observe everything. Every department had its own personality. Some speakers presented with complete confidence. Others carefully checked their notes after every second sentence. A few seemed to know every possible detail about their work, while a few others possessed remarkable confidence despite appearing to improvise half their presentation.

Watching all of them reminded me how enormous Paradox actually was.

Inside Sportify, it was easy to believe that sports formed the centre of the festival because that was the world we lived in every day. Sitting inside Room 127 quietly corrected that illusion. Hospitality was solving its own challenges. Marketing was managing an entirely different set of responsibilities. Logistics, sponsorships, media, volunteer management, finance and technical teams were all building different pieces of the same event.

Each department looked busy enough to believe their work was the most important.

Perhaps that was exactly how it should have been.

At some point during one of the presentations, Aman leaned slightly towards me and whispered something about the speaker's confidence that immediately made me laugh.

I tried not to.

I failed.

The person sitting in front of us turned around for a brief moment.

We both looked down at our notebooks with the kind of exaggerated seriousness that convinces absolutely nobody.

The meeting continued.

Every few minutes one of us would quietly make an observation, predict how long the next presentation might last or invent completely unnecessary commentary about some minor detail that only seemed funny because we had already spent months attending meetings together.

It became our own unofficial running commentary track.

The amusing part was that despite all the jokes, we genuinely enjoyed listening.

Every presentation revealed another piece of the machine we had spent so long helping build from a distance.

For the first time, Paradox no longer felt like a collection of spreadsheets.

It felt like an event.

Real people were standing in front of us discussing real venues, real schedules and real responsibilities.

The work was no longer theoretical.

Within a few days, everything being discussed inside that classroom would have to function exactly as planned.

Or at least close enough.

Student events rarely achieve perfection.

They survive through teamwork, improvisation and optimism in almost equal measure.

As the afternoon slowly turned into evening, presentations continued one after another. Time passed almost unnoticed.

None of us realized that the most memorable part of the day would only begin after the meeting ended.

Eventually, the final presentation came to an end.

One by one, laptops disappeared into backpacks. Notebooks closed with the familiar sound that marks the end of every long meeting. Conversations that had remained formal for the past several hours immediately became informal again as people gathered around their own departments to discuss pending work, exchange quick updates or simply catch up with friends they had not seen in person for months.

The atmosphere inside Room 127 changed almost instantly.

A classroom that had been filled with presentations only moments earlier became a room full of conversations.

Groups slowly drifted toward the door.

Someone laughed loudly at the back.

A volunteer hurried out after suddenly remembering another task.

A coordinator called someone across the room before disappearing into the corridor.

Within a few minutes, most of the class had emptied.

Aman stretched his arms and looked towards me.

"So?"

"So?"

"Leaving?"

I looked towards the front of the room.

Kothai Ma'am was still speaking with someone.

"We'll wait."

He nodded.

It seemed like the obvious decision.

We wanted to speak with her for a few minutes regarding a couple of things before leaving for the evening. There was no urgency. No reason to rush. After spending months attending online meetings where everyone disappeared the second the host ended the call, simply waiting outside a classroom felt surprisingly natural.

We stepped into the corridor.

Outside, the building had become much quieter than it had been earlier that afternoon.

Most departments had already started leaving. Small groups walked towards different parts of the campus while continuing conversations that had clearly begun inside the meeting itself. The sunlight had softened noticeably, and the long corridor outside Room 127 had acquired that familiar evening calm which university buildings often develop once the day's lectures have ended.

Neither of us minded waiting.

In fact, after so many months of constant planning, the absence of urgency almost felt unusual.

We stood near one of the windows, occasionally talking about the meeting we had just attended. The discussion naturally returned to the departments we had watched present throughout the afternoon.

"I still think Operations is underestimating the number of volunteers they'll need," I said.

Aman nodded almost immediately.

"They'll realise on Day One."

"And then?"

"They'll ask everyone else for volunteers."

I laughed.

"Probably."

That prediction, as it turned out, would prove remarkably accurate.

For a few minutes, the conversation drifted between planning, observations and completely unrelated topics, exactly the way most conversations between us usually did. Neither of us was watching the clock. There didn't seem to be any reason to.

Eventually, we noticed that Kothai Ma'am was still occupied.

"Looks like it'll take a little longer," Aman said.

I shrugged.

"We've waited months for Paradox."

"A few more minutes won't hurt."

Neither of us had the slightest idea how wonderfully inaccurate that statement was about to become.

At that moment, we genuinely believed we were waiting for an ordinary conversation.

Instead, we were about to witness one of the strangest evenings of the entire week.

That story deserves a chapter of its own.

Chapter 8

Kothai Ma'am and Nandhini Sweets

We had expected to wait for five minutes.

That estimate turned out to be spectacularly wrong.

By the time most departments had left Room 127, Aman and I were still standing outside the classroom, waiting for Kothai Ma'am to become free. From where we stood, we could see her speaking with a student who appeared genuinely upset. We didn't pay much attention to the conversation at first. University campuses are full of discussions that deserve privacy, and this clearly looked like one of them.

So we waited.

Neither of us minded.

After spending months working towards Paradox, five extra minutes at the end of a meeting hardly seemed worth worrying about. The corridor outside the classroom was quiet now. Every few minutes another volunteer walked past carrying a backpack, waved at someone they recognised and disappeared down the staircase. The building was slowly emptying, and the evening sun had begun casting long shadows through the open windows.

For a while, Aman and I entertained ourselves by discussing the meeting we had just attended.

"I still think Operations is underestimating the crowd," I said.

"They'll realise it on the first day," Aman replied.

"And then?"

"They'll borrow volunteers from everyone else."

I laughed.

"That's your prediction?"

"No," he said, smiling. "That's experience."

We continued talking about different departments, guessing which events would attract the biggest participation and quietly placing imaginary bets on which team would face the first unexpected crisis. Looking back, it was amusing how confident we sounded. We believed we understood exactly how the coming week would unfold.

Paradox had other plans.

A few more minutes passed.

The conversation at the other end of the corridor was still going on.

Neither of us thought much of it.

Eventually, however, something unusual became noticeable.

The discussion wasn't ending.

If anything, it seemed to be growing longer.

Students who had left after the meeting were now completely gone. The corridor that had been full of people only fifteen minutes earlier had become almost empty. Even the sounds inside the building had changed. The noise of dozens of conversations had slowly given way to silence, broken only occasionally by footsteps echoing somewhere along the staircase.

Aman looked towards the classroom.

"This is taking longer than I expected."

I nodded.

"Maybe it's something serious."

It certainly appeared that way.

At least in the beginning.

From where we stood, we could only catch fragments of the discussion. It wasn't our place to listen, nor were we trying to. We simply happened to be standing close enough to realise that the conversation had started as a formal complaint involving someone connected with the Paradox team.

Kothai Ma'am listened with remarkable patience.

She never interrupted.

She never appeared hurried.

She allowed the student to explain everything at her own pace.

That, in itself, wasn't unusual.

What happened next was.

At first, the conversation unfolded exactly as we had expected.

The student spoke.

Kothai Ma'am listened.

Occasionally she asked a question, waited for the answer and then listened again. Whatever the issue was, she was giving it the time and seriousness it deserved.

Neither Aman nor I had any intention of interrupting.

So we remained where we were.

A few more people walked out of the building, waved goodbye to friends and disappeared down the staircase. Within twenty minutes, the corridor that had been crowded after the meeting was almost empty. The only people still left on that floor were those who genuinely had a reason to be there.

Apparently, we did.

"I think we'll be here for a while," Aman said, leaning against the wall.

"It looks like it."

We had no complaints.

Waiting was a surprisingly familiar part of organizing student events. You waited for meetings to begin, waited for venues to open, waited for deliveries, waited for volunteers, waited for registrations and, occasionally, waited for people who insisted they were "just two minutes away."

Compared to all of that, waiting outside Room 127 felt perfectly normal.

The interesting part was how the conversation slowly began changing.

We could not hear every word, nor were we trying to. We respected the student's privacy. But when you spend nearly two hours standing in the same corridor, it becomes impossible not to notice the overall direction of a conversation.

It no longer seemed to be only about the original complaint.

The discussion drifted.

One topic became another.

Then another.

From a distance, it felt as though every time the conversation approached its conclusion, a completely new subject appeared.

I looked at Aman.

"What are they talking about now?"

He shrugged.

"I've stopped guessing."

That seemed like the safest approach.

Time passed in a strange way.

Normally, when you're waiting for something, every minute feels longer than it really is. Here, the opposite happened. We spent most of our time talking among ourselves, occasionally watching people pass through the corridor and sometimes simply standing in silence, enjoying the unusually peaceful evening.

The campus outside had begun changing colour.

The bright afternoon sunlight had softened into the warm light that always makes university campuses look strangely beautiful. Through the windows we could see students walking back toward their hostels, some carrying badminton rackets, others balancing laptops under one arm, completely unaware that two people were still waiting outside a classroom because a five-minute conversation had somehow turned into an evening-long affair.

Then came the moment that completely changed our understanding of what was happening.

The student, who had initially appeared deeply upset, suddenly began asking Kothai Ma'am about recommendation letters.

I looked at Aman.

He looked back at me.

Neither of us spoke for a moment.

Had we misunderstood the conversation from the beginning?

Or had the conversation genuinely travelled from a formal complaint to future academic recommendations?

Before either of us could answer that question, another topic appeared.

Contact details.

Then another.

Career advice.

Then another.

The discussion had developed a remarkable ability to keep discovering new directions.

At one point, Aman quietly said, "I think this conversation has more chapters than our meeting."

I almost laughed out loud.

Almost.

The remarkable part, however, was not the student.

It was Kothai Ma'am.

Not once did she appear impatient. She never looked at the time, never tried to hurry the conversation and never gave the impression that she had somewhere more important to be. She answered every question with the same attention she had shown at the beginning.

Watching that quietly changed something for me.

Until then, I had mostly known her through meetings, planning discussions and official interactions. Standing in that corridor, I saw something different. Leadership was not only about making decisions or running meetings. Sometimes it was simply about giving another person your full attention, even when it cost you two hours of your own evening.

That lesson stayed with me long after I forgot the details of the complaint itself.

Eventually, almost two hours after the meeting had officially ended, the conversation finally came to a close.

The student thanked Kothai Ma'am and walked away.

The corridor became silent again.

Aman looked at me and smiled.

"So..."

"So."

"I think it's our turn now."

I nodded.

"For once."

We walked toward Kothai Ma'am, who greeted us with the same calm smile she had worn throughout the evening, as though the previous two hours had not been exhausting in the slightest.

I smiled back and said the first thing that came to mind.

"Ma'am... dinner from my side?"

She looked at both of us for a moment, smiled, and replied without any hesitation.

"Done."

Neither Aman nor I knew it then, but that one word had just begun one of the warmest evenings of the entire week.

For the first time that evening, there was nowhere any of us urgently needed to be.

The meeting had ended.

The endless conversation outside Room 127 had finally concluded.

The pending questions we wanted to ask had been answered in a matter of minutes, proving that we could probably have finished our own discussion long before the waiting had.

Now the only decision left was where to have dinner.

Aman immediately began suggesting places.

I added a couple of options of my own, though none of them came with much confidence. Neither of us knew the campus or the surrounding area well enough to claim expertise.

Kothai Ma'am listened patiently before smiling.

"Let's go to Nandhini Sweets."

The discussion ended there.

When someone who has lived in the city much longer than you recommends a restaurant, arguing rarely improves the outcome.

We started walking towards Velachery Gate.

The distance was a little over two kilometres, but none of us seemed particularly interested in reaching quickly. For the first time since arriving in Chennai, nobody in our small group was carrying an agenda. There were no presentations left to attend, no volunteers waiting for instructions and no documents that needed immediate attention.

It was simply an evening walk.

The kind people rarely appreciate while they are living it.

The conversation drifted naturally.

Sometimes we spoke about Paradox. Sometimes we didn't.

Aman asked Kothai Ma'am about previous editions of the festival and the challenges they had faced. She responded with stories rather than answers, and I quickly realised that every large event develops its own collection of legends. Some involved volunteers solving impossible problems with remarkable creativity. Others involved mistakes that seemed disastrous in the moment but eventually became stories everyone laughed about.

Listening to those stories was strangely reassuring.

For months, our team had been worrying about making everything perfect.

Kothai Ma'am spoke as someone who already knew perfection was never the objective.

Adaptation was.

That idea stayed with me.

The campus looked different in the evening than it had during the afternoon. The roads had become quieter, and the sunlight filtering through the trees gave everything a softer appearance. Students passed us in small groups, some returning to their hostels after classes, others heading out for dinner. A few recognised Kothai Ma'am and greeted her as they walked by. She responded to each of them with the same warmth we had seen throughout the evening.

It was a small detail.

But I noticed it.

Leadership often reveals itself in the smallest interactions.

Somewhere along the walk, the conversation wandered completely away from Paradox.

We spoke about student life, campus traditions and the strange ability every university has to convince students that walking three kilometres for food is somehow a perfectly reasonable decision.

"I don't think I've ever walked this much just for dinner," I admitted.

Kothai Ma'am laughed.

"Give IIT Madras a week."

Aman nodded immediately.

"You'll stop measuring distance."

"You'll start measuring food."

That became the running joke for the rest of the walk.

Every time someone estimated how much farther we had to go, the answer somehow became related to idlis instead of kilometres.

Before long, the lights near Velachery Gate appeared ahead of us.

The sounds of traffic slowly replaced the quieter atmosphere of the campus, and sitting just beyond the gate was the place that had ended our restaurant discussion before it had really begun.

Nandhini Sweets.

From the outside, it looked like any other busy restaurant in Chennai.

Families occupied several tables.

Students filled most of the remaining seats.

Orders moved constantly between the kitchen and the dining area.

Nothing about the place suggested that years later, it would still occupy a chapter in a book.

Perhaps that is how memories usually work.

They choose ordinary places without asking permission.

We found a table, settled into our seats and finally allowed ourselves to stop walking.

The menu was passed around.

Naturally, deciding what to order took longer than anyone expected.

Some traditions exist everywhere.

Eventually, after a discussion that was far more detailed than the situation required, we settled on podi idli.

Looking back, I cannot honestly tell you whether it was the best podi idli I have ever eaten.

What I can tell you is that it became the most memorable.

Not because of the food.

Because of the people sitting around the table.

The podi idli arrived surprisingly quickly.

After spending almost two hours waiting outside Room 127, it felt oddly satisfying that at least dinner had decided not to test our patience as well.

The plates were placed in the middle of the table, and for a few moments the conversation paused. Hunger has a remarkable ability to silence even the most talkative groups.

It never lasts very long.

Within minutes, the discussion had started again.

Unlike the meeting earlier that afternoon, nobody was trying to solve problems anymore. There were no presentations, no action points and no responsibilities waiting at the end of the conversation. We were simply talking.

That difference changed everything.

It is strange how easily formal relationships disappear once people leave formal spaces.

Only a few hours earlier, Kothai Ma'am had been sitting at the front of a classroom, listening to departmental updates while everyone else carefully presented their work. Around that table in Nandhini Sweets, she was simply sharing stories over dinner.

Some of those stories were about previous editions of Paradox.

Some were about students she had worked with over the years.

Others had nothing to do with festivals at all.

Each story carried the same quiet humour that only comes from looking back at situations that must have been considerably more stressful while they were happening.

Every now and then Aman would interrupt with a question.

"What happened after that?"

"Did they actually manage to fix it?"

"You're telling me nobody noticed?"

Kothai Ma'am would smile before continuing, usually revealing that the ending was even more unexpected than the beginning.

I found myself listening far more than speaking.

Not because I had nothing to say, but because the evening had become unexpectedly comfortable.

There was no pressure to impress anyone.

No expectation that every conversation had to lead somewhere.

For months, almost every interaction connected to Sportify had revolved around work. Even casual calls somehow found their way back to registrations, event plans or spreadsheets.

This was different.

Nobody mentioned spreadsheets.

That alone made the evening memorable.

At one point, Aman looked around the table and laughed.

"You know, if someone had seen us during the meeting this afternoon and then saw us now, they probably wouldn't believe it was the same group."

Kothai Ma'am smiled.

"That's because meetings only show one version of people."

I remember thinking about that sentence for a moment.

She was right.

Student leadership often hides the people behind the positions. Secretaries become organisers. Coordinators become problem-solvers. Faculty become authority figures. Everyone spends so much time doing their jobs that they forget to simply be themselves.

Dinner quietly corrected that.

For the next hour, nobody around the table represented a designation.

We were just people sharing a meal after a long day.

The restaurant gradually became busier as more families arrived for dinner. Orders moved constantly between the kitchen and the tables, waiters crossed the room carrying steel plates with astonishing speed, and conversations from dozens of different tables blended into the familiar background noise that somehow makes restaurants feel welcoming rather than loud.

Time slipped away unnoticed.

No one checked a watch.

No one looked at a phone except to reply to the occasional message.

There was nowhere else we urgently needed to be.

Eventually the plates were empty, and the conversation slowed naturally.

For a brief moment, nobody said anything.

Not because there was an awkward silence.

Because it was one of those comfortable silences that only appear when everyone has genuinely enjoyed being together.

As we stood up to leave, I realised that what I would remember years later would not be the podi idli.

It would be the feeling of the evening itself.

Some memories survive because they are extraordinary.

Others survive because, for a little while, everything simply felt right.

This was one of those evenings.

As we stepped back onto the road outside Nandhini Sweets, the Chennai sky had turned completely dark.

The walk back to campus was still waiting for us.

None of us minded.

In fact, I think we were all secretly happy that the evening wasn't over yet.

The return journey somehow felt shorter.

Perhaps it was because nobody was paying attention to the distance anymore.

When you are walking with people whose company you enjoy, roads have a strange habit of shrinking. Conversations replace kilometres, and before you realise it, you have crossed half the campus without ever thinking about the walk itself.

The traffic outside Velachery Gate gradually disappeared behind us as we entered the campus once again. The roads looked different at night. During the afternoon they belonged to students rushing between classes, meetings and hostels. At night, they belonged to conversations.

Groups of friends sat on benches beneath the trees, some discussing assignments while others laughed loudly enough for the entire road to hear them. A few students cycled past us, their headlights briefly illuminating the path before disappearing into the darkness. Somewhere in the distance, a dog barked, and from another direction came the faint sound of a cricket match still being played under floodlights.

The institute had become quieter, but it was far from asleep.

I had always imagined IIT Madras as an academic institution.

That evening, it felt more like a small town.

The conversation continued without any effort.

One topic naturally led to another.

Sometimes we spoke about Paradox.

Sometimes about college life.

Sometimes about completely random things that made perfect sense only because of the people involved in the conversation.

Nobody seemed interested in forcing the discussion back towards work.

For the first time since arriving in Chennai, it genuinely felt as though we had left our responsibilities behind for a few hours.

Looking back, I think evenings like this quietly shaped the entire week.

When people remember festivals, they usually remember competitions, concerts, victories and photographs. Those are the memories that appear on social media.

The memories that stay with you are often much smaller.

A long walk after dinner.

A conversation that had no purpose.

A joke that nobody outside the group would understand.

A night when nobody was in a hurry to reach anywhere.

Those moments never receive certificates.

Yet they are often the ones that survive the longest.

By the time we reached the area near Himalaya Mess, all three of us had started slowing down without even realising it.

Nobody wanted to end the evening just yet.

Almost at the same moment, Kothai Ma'am looked towards the food court and smiled.

"Juices?"

Neither Aman nor I needed convincing.

A few minutes later, we were sitting once again, this time with fresh fruit juices replacing plates of podi idli.

It was a simple ending to an unexpectedly memorable day.

The conversation no longer had any particular direction.

Somebody would remember something from the afternoon meeting.

Someone else would respond with another story.

Every now and then, silence settled over the table for a few seconds before another topic naturally appeared.

There was something comforting about not needing to keep a conversation alive.

It simply existed.

The juices disappeared far more quickly than the hours we had spent together.

Eventually, reality reminded us that another day was waiting.

Paradox had still not officially begun, but the days leading up to it were already becoming busier with every passing hour. Tomorrow would bring new people to the campus, new responsibilities and another long list of things that needed attention.

For now, however, none of that seemed important.

We stepped out of the food court and stood there for a moment before saying our goodbyes.

"Good night, Ma'am."

"Good night," she replied with the same warmth she had carried throughout the evening. "Get some rest. You'll need it."

She was absolutely right.

At the time, though, I don't think any of us truly understood what was waiting for us over the next few days.

Aman and I started walking back towards Krishna Hostel.

The roads were almost empty now, and the campus had settled into the peaceful rhythm that only exists after midnight. We spoke very little during the walk back. Not because there was nothing left to say, but because it felt unnecessary.

Some days ask to be discussed.

Others ask simply to be remembered.

This was one of those days.

When I finally reached Room 367, I placed my bag on the chair, lay down on the bed and replayed the day in my head.

Only twenty-four hours had passed since I had arrived on campus.

It already felt as though I had been there much longer.

Outside, Krishna Hostel had grown completely quiet.

Inside, I fell asleep almost immediately, unaware that the following day would be the last truly peaceful day before Paradox transformed the campus into a world of its own.

Chapter 9

Snow Zone

There is a strange period before every major event when nobody quite knows what to do with themselves.

The planning is almost over.

The execution has not yet begun.

Responsibilities exist, but they have not yet become urgent.

You know that the coming week will leave you exhausted, yet for one final day, exhaustion still belongs to the future.

That was 8 June.

When I think about Paradox today, my mind usually jumps to packed venues, walkie-talkies, registration desks and people running across the campus trying to solve problems that had not existed five minutes earlier.

Almost none of that had happened yet.

The campus still felt peaceful.

Krishna Hostel still echoed when someone walked through the corridor.

Most of Sportify was still travelling towards Chennai.

For one final morning, the institute belonged to those of us who had arrived early.

Aman and I eventually made our way to Ishtara for breakfast.

By this point, the food court was beginning to feel familiar. We had been there often enough that the route no longer required thought. It simply became part of the rhythm of the day.

Breakfast was masala dosa.

Nothing extraordinary.

Just two students eating breakfast before a week that neither of them fully understood.

"You know," Aman said while looking around the nearly empty food court, "this place won't look like this tomorrow."

I looked around.

He was right.

There were empty tables everywhere.

People ate without rushing.

Nobody seemed particularly stressed.

It was difficult to imagine that within another day, many of these same tables would be occupied by volunteers discussing event schedules over hurried meals.

"It feels too peaceful," I said.

Aman smiled.

"Enjoy it while it lasts."

Neither of us realised how accurate that advice would become.

Breakfast ended without anybody checking the time.

That itself felt unusual.

For months, every meal had been interrupted by meetings, calls or reminders.

This one wasn't.

For perhaps the first time in a very long while, we had nowhere we urgently needed to be.

The day was ours.

Somewhere during the walk back towards Krishna Hostel, somebody suggested going to Phoenix Mall later in the evening.

The proposal was accepted almost immediately.

Not because we had carefully planned it.

Because nobody wanted to spend the last peaceful day sitting inside a hostel room.

Sometimes the best decisions are the ones that require the least discussion.

The decision had been made so casually that nobody bothered discussing it again.

By late afternoon, we were already on our way to Phoenix Marketcity.

Looking back, I think what excited us wasn't the mall itself. It was the opportunity to spend a few hours doing absolutely nothing related to Paradox.

For months, every conversation had eventually found its way back to registrations, spreadsheets, meetings or responsibilities. Even casual phone calls somehow ended with someone saying, "By the way, one more thing.."

That afternoon, there was no "one more thing."

There was just a group of friends leaving campus for a few hours.

The drive itself felt strangely relaxing.

As the institute slowly disappeared behind us, the conversations became lighter. Nobody was discussing event plans anymore. Instead, we argued about completely meaningless things, interrupted each other constantly and laughed at jokes that probably wouldn't have made sense to anyone sitting nearby.

It felt less like a group of organizers and more like a group of college students.

Perhaps that was exactly what we needed.

Phoenix Marketcity was busy in the way large malls always are. Families walked from one store to another carrying shopping bags that somehow kept multiplying. Children ran ahead of their parents with the confidence that they would eventually be found. Groups of college students occupied the food court, each convinced they had discovered the perfect place to spend an evening.

For a little while, we blended into that crowd.

Nobody knew we were organizing one of IIT Madras' biggest festivals.

Nobody cared.

It was surprisingly refreshing.

The original plan was simple.

Watch a movie.

Walk around for a while.

Have something to eat.

Return to campus.

The kind of evening thousands of college students have every weekend.

We bought tickets for *Hai Jawani Toh Isbq Hona Hai* and found our seats just as the advertisements began playing on the screen.

The auditorium slowly grew darker.

People settled into their seats.

The conversations around us faded.

Finally, the movie began.

For the first half an hour, everything went exactly as expected.

We watched.

Occasionally laughed.

Made the sort of quiet comments that friends make to each other during films, convinced they are whispering much more softly than they actually are.

Nothing unusual happened.

Then the previous few months finally caught up with us.

It is difficult to explain just how exhausting continuous event planning can become.

The work itself is enjoyable.

The meetings are enjoyable.

The people certainly make it worthwhile.

But after months of balancing studies, society work and daily life, exhaustion has a habit of waiting patiently until you finally stop moving.

The theatre happened to provide exactly the environment it needed.

Comfortable seats.

Air conditioning.

Darkness.

Silence.

It was the perfect trap.

I don't remember the exact moment I fell asleep.

One moment I was watching the film.

The next moment I was waking up, slightly confused, trying to understand why the story on the screen suddenly seemed completely unfamiliar.

For a few seconds, I genuinely wondered whether the movie had become unexpectedly complicated.

Then I realised the far more obvious explanation.

I had slept through a significant part of it.

Embarrassed, I looked towards Aman.

His eyes were closed.

I looked in the opposite direction.

Another familiar face.

Also asleep.

A smile slowly appeared on my face.

Apparently, I wasn't the only victim.

One by one, everyone started waking up.

Each person looked around with exactly the same expression, silently trying to calculate how much of the movie they had missed.

The answers varied.

None of them were encouraging.

"So..." Aman said, rubbing his eyes.

"So."

"What exactly happened?"

"I was hoping you'd tell me."

He laughed.

"I think I slept."

"I know."

"How?"

I looked around the row.

"I think we all did."

That observation triggered a wave of laughter.

The movie was still playing.

The audience around us remained completely invested in the story.

Meanwhile, our group had collectively managed to transform a cinema hall into a perfectly air-conditioned nap room.

It was, in its own strange way, an impressive achievement.

When the interval finally arrived, nobody even pretended to be interested in returning for the second half.

Someone asked the obvious question.

"Should we just leave?"

Not a single person objected.

Within two minutes, we were walking out of the auditorium, having watched just enough of the film to know its title and not nearly enough to understand its story.

To this day, I have no idea how that movie ended.

I hope it was good.

None of us stayed long enough to find out.

As we stepped back into the brightly lit corridors of the mall, somebody pointed towards another attraction on the floor below.

Snow Zone.

Unlike the movie, this suggestion managed to keep everyone awake.

The journey from the cinema to Snow Zone lasted only a few minutes, but the atmosphere around us had changed completely.

Nobody looked sleepy anymore.

The disappointment of abandoning the movie disappeared almost instantly, replaced by the kind of excitement that only very simple things can create.

Artificial snow.

Sometimes adulthood is remarkably easy to forget.

After collecting the jackets and gloves provided at the entrance, we stepped through the doors together.

The change in temperature was immediate.

Only a few moments earlier, we had been walking through a Chennai shopping mall in June.

Now our breath was visible in the air.

Every person entering the room reacted in almost exactly the same way. Some instinctively folded their arms, others laughed at the sudden cold, and a few stood completely still for a moment, trying to convince themselves that this dramatic change in weather had actually happened.

"It feels illegal," Aman said, looking around.

"What?"

"Experiencing winter in Chennai."

I laughed.

"I don't think geography approves."

Within a few minutes, everyone had stopped worrying about the cold.

Instead, another universal law of human behaviour took over.

If there is snow, people will throw it.

Nobody announced the beginning of the snowball fight.

Nobody needed to.

One person picked up a handful of snow.

Another responded.

Within seconds, every trace of maturity had disappeared.

Snowballs flew in every direction without any strategy whatsoever. Nobody kept score. Nobody cared who started it. The objective changed every few seconds depending on who happened to be standing nearby.

For a little while, we stopped being organizers altogether.

We were simply a group of twenty-year-olds laughing like children.

Looking back, I think moments like these quietly became the foundation of our friendships.

Meetings build teams.

Shared responsibilities build trust.

But completely unnecessary moments of laughter build memories.

At some point during the chaos, I spotted Aman standing a short distance away.

He was completely unaware of what I was planning.

I bent down, gathered a generous handful of snow and quietly started moving towards him.

The plan was beautifully simple.

Sneak closer.

Hit Aman.

Run.

Claim victory.

It was, in theory, an excellent strategy.

Unfortunately, reality had prepared a different ending.

Just as I was about to launch my attack, I lost my balance.

To this day, I maintain that the floor deserves at least part of the blame.

History, however, has been less sympathetic.

Instead of hitting Aman with the snowball, I managed to throw myself at the ground with considerably greater accuracy.

It wasn't a graceful fall.

It wasn't even an ordinary fall.

It was one of those spectacular collapses that seem to happen in slow motion while everyone nearby watches the inevitable unfold.

The snow left my hand.

My feet left the ground.

Aman remained completely untouched.

A second later, I was lying face-first in the snow.

For perhaps half a second, nobody reacted.

People were trying to decide whether they should rush over or burst into laughter.

Fortunately for everyone involved, including me, I stood up almost immediately.

That settled the debate.

The laughter began.

Not polite laughter.

Not the kind people offer out of courtesy.

The genuine, uncontrollable kind that spreads through an entire group within seconds.

Even I couldn't stop laughing.

The entire mission had failed so completely that there was nothing else to do.

Aman looked at me, still holding the snowball that had never reached him, and simply said,

"You had one job."

"I know."

"You somehow attacked yourself."

"I know."

"I don't even know how that's possible."

"Neither do I."

That conversation followed me for the rest of the evening.

Every few minutes, someone would look in my direction, remember what had happened and start laughing all over again.

My reputation as a tactical genius had suffered irreversible damage.

The snowball fight continued for a long time after that.

Photographs were taken.

Videos were recorded.

More snow changed owners than anyone could reasonably calculate.

Eventually, however, we all reached the same conclusion.

Our hands had become too cold.

No amount of enthusiasm could successfully negotiate with the temperature forever.

Reluctantly, we returned the jackets, stepped back into the warmth of the mall and immediately realised just how cold Snow Zone had actually been.

The Chennai heat greeted us once again, as though determined to restore the natural order of the universe.

For a few moments, we simply stood there outside the entrance, smiling at each other.

The movie had been forgettable.

The snowball fight certainly wasn't.

Some evenings become memorable because everything goes according to plan.

This one became memorable because almost nothing did.

As we started walking towards the exit of the mall, none of us were in any hurry to return to the hostel.

Somehow, the day still felt unfinished.

And as it turned out, it was.

The funniest incident of the night was still waiting for us back on campus.

By the time we returned to campus, the excitement of Snow Zone had begun giving way to exhaustion.

The laughter, however, hadn't.

Every few minutes someone would look in my direction, remember the spectacular failure of my attempted snowball attack and smile all over again.

Apparently, embarrassing yourself in front of your friends has remarkable replay value.

We walked towards Ishtara for dinner, still carrying fragments of conversations from the mall.

Someone wondered whether we should have stayed for the second half of the movie.

"No," Aman answered immediately.

"What if it got better?"

"It had forty minutes."

"Fair."

That ended the debate.

Dinner was simple.

After the excitement of the evening, nobody seemed interested in discussing anything serious. The conversation wandered from one

completely unrelated topic to another, interrupted every few minutes by somebody remembering another funny moment from Snow Zone.

Looking back, I realise something interesting.

Not once during dinner did anyone talk about work.

No registrations.

No schedules.

No venues.

No pending responsibilities.

For one evening, Sportify had stopped existing.

Friends had taken its place.

When dinner ended, returning to the hostel would have been the sensible decision.

Naturally, we did something else.

"Let's go to ESB for a while," someone suggested.

Nobody objected.

The Electronic Sciences Block had quietly become one of our favourite places on campus. During the day it belonged to meetings, department discussions and planning sessions. Late at night, however, it transformed into something entirely different.

It became a place where people simply gathered.

No agenda.

No presentations.

No deadlines.

Just conversations.

By the time we reached Room 127, a few familiar faces had already arrived.

Nikhil was there.

One of Aman's closest friends and the Secretary of Nallamala House, Nikhil possessed the rare ability to make almost any conversation entertaining without ever appearing to try. Give him enough time, a few friends and absolutely no agenda, and somehow the evening would become memorable.

A little later, Shreyansh Bhaiya joined us as well.

If there was one thing everyone learned quickly about him, it was this:

Never leave your phone unattended.

Especially if Aman happened to be sitting nearby.

At that point in the week, everyone in our small circle knew something Aman would never openly admit.

He had a crush on Neha, the Secretary of Bandipur House.

Naturally, this information was treated with exactly the level of maturity you would expect from a group of twenty-year-olds.

Which is to say...

Absolutely none.

The teasing had become almost routine by then.

Mention Neha's name, and someone would immediately look towards Aman.

Mention Bandipur House, and someone would smile.

Poor Aman had stopped denying it.

Mostly because denial wasn't helping.

That night, however, Shreyansh Bhaiya decided ordinary teasing wasn't enough.

He had a much better idea.

Or, depending on whom you ask...

A much worse one.

Nobody noticed the moment Shreyansh Bhaiya picked up Aman's phone.

That, in hindsight, was probably the biggest mistake any of us made that night.

The phone had been lying casually on the desk while everyone was busy talking. Aman was in the middle of another conversation, completely unaware that his greatest weakness had just become accessible to the most mischievous person in the room.

Shreyansh Bhaiya unlocked the screen with the ease of someone who had absolutely no good intentions.

At first, I assumed he was simply trying to irritate Aman.

That happened often enough.

Then I saw the name on the screen.

Neha.

I looked at him.

He looked back at me with the expression of someone who had already committed to an idea and had no intention of turning back.

Without saying a word, he started typing.

"Where are you?"

A few seconds later.

"Come to ESB."

Then another message.

"Should I come and pick you up?"

I stared at the phone.

"You're actually sending them?"

He simply smiled.

That smile answered every question.

Meanwhile, Aman continued talking, blissfully unaware that his reputation was quietly collapsing a few feet away.

By the time he finally noticed that his phone was missing, the damage had already been done.

"Where's my phone?"

Nobody answered immediately.

He looked around the room.

Then towards Shreyansh Bhaiya.

Then back at the empty table.

A look of genuine panic slowly appeared on his face.

"What did you do?"

Shreyansh Bhaiya calmly handed him the phone.

"Nothing."

That single word was enough for all of us to start laughing.

Aman unlocked the screen.

The colour disappeared from his face almost instantly.

"You sent these?"

"No."

"You literally sent these!"

"I don't remember doing that."

"Shreyansh Bhaiya!"

The room exploded.

Aman, who had spent months handling registrations, volunteers and department meetings with complete confidence, suddenly looked like someone who wished the floor would quietly open beneath him.

"This is not funny," he insisted.

Unfortunately for him, it was extremely funny.

Before he could decide whether to apologise, explain or simply disappear, another piece of the plan quietly unfolded.

Earlier that evening, we had also called Himanshu, the Web Admin of Bandipur House, asking him to come over to ESB.

At the time, Aman assumed we simply wanted to meet him.

Now the real reason became obvious.

A few minutes later, footsteps echoed through the corridor.

Someone looked towards the door.

"They're here."

Aman froze.

"No."

"Yes."

"No."

"Yes."

Neha walked into the room.

For perhaps the first and only time since I had known Aman, I genuinely had no idea what was going through his mind.

He looked at us.

Then at Neha.

Then back at us.

It was as though his brain had temporarily stopped processing information in the correct order.

The rest of us, meanwhile, were trying very hard to behave like mature adults.

We failed almost immediately.

The conversation that followed was perfectly normal.

That was the funniest part.

Neha had no dramatic reaction.

Nobody confronted anyone.

Nothing awkward actually happened.

Except Aman himself.

He suddenly became quieter than usual, answered questions with noticeably shorter sentences and avoided making eye contact with the rest of us for longer than necessary.

The more he tried to behave naturally, the more obvious it became that he was trying to behave naturally.

That only encouraged everyone else.

Nobody needed to tease him anymore.

His expressions were doing all the work for us.

Poor Aman never really recovered from that evening.

For the next several days, mentioning Bandipur House anywhere near him was enough to restart the laughter.

Eventually, Neha and Himanshu left, completely unaware that they had just become permanent characters in one of our favourite stories from Paradox.

The rest of us remained in Room 127 long after they had gone.

The conversations continued.

Somebody found another topic.

Someone else started another story.

Time quietly disappeared, exactly as it always does when you're surrounded by people you genuinely enjoy being with.

When I finally checked my phone, it was almost three in the morning.

None of us could quite believe it.

Outside, the Electronic Sciences Block had become completely silent.

Inside, we were still laughing.

Eventually, exhaustion won.

One by one, we got up, stretched, collected our bags and started walking back towards Krishna Hostel.

The campus looked completely different at that hour.

The roads were empty.

The streetlights reflected softly against the trees.

Even the air felt calmer.

As Aman and I walked back together, I looked at him and smiled.

"You'll never hear the end of this."

He sighed.

"I already know."

He was right.

Some stories become part of a group's history the moment they happen.

This was one of them.

When we finally reached Room 367, sleep arrived almost instantly.

Tomorrow would be different.

Tomorrow, the campus would begin filling with familiar faces.

Tomorrow, Sportify would finally arrive.

The quiet days were over.

Day Zero was waiting.

Chapter 10

Day Zero

There are certain mornings that refuse to feel ordinary, even before anything has happened.

The morning of 9 June was one of them.

My alarm rang at five.

For a brief moment, I stared at the ceiling of Room 367, wondering why anyone would voluntarily wake up at such an unreasonable hour.

Then I remembered.

Day Zero.

The day we had spent months preparing for had finally arrived.

Outside, Krishna Hostel was unusually quiet. Most people were still asleep, while those who were awake moved through the corridors with the familiar silence shared by people who know everyone else is trying to squeeze in a few more minutes of sleep.

Aman was already ready by the time I stepped outside.

"You actually woke up on time?" I asked.

"I surprised myself too."

We both laughed.

There was a different kind of excitement in the air that morning.

Not nervousness.

Not pressure.

Anticipation.

For months, Paradox had existed inside Google Meet windows, WhatsApp groups, Excel sheets and planning documents.

Today, it finally had a date.

We started walking towards the Central Lecture Theatre.

Even at that hour, groups of volunteers and organizers could already be seen making their way across the campus, most of them wearing expressions that perfectly balanced excitement with sleep deprivation.

It felt as though the institute itself had woken up earlier than usual.

When we reached CLT, a long line had already formed outside.

Some people had arrived before us.

Others continued joining behind us.

Everyone was waiting for the same thing.

Wristbands.

Merchandise.

The official beginning.

Standing in that queue felt strangely satisfying.

For months, Paradox had been a project.

That morning, it finally became an event.

As the line slowly moved forward, volunteers handed out pre-booked merchandise one by one.

Then came something I had quietly been looking forward to.

Our POR merchandise.

I unfolded the T-shirt almost immediately.

Across it was my name.

And beneath it,

Deputy Secretary — Sportify.

I stood there looking at it for a few seconds longer than I probably should have.

A designation is only a few printed words.

Yet I knew exactly how much work those words represented.

Hundreds of meetings.

Countless phone calls.

Late-night planning sessions.

Problems solved before anyone else even knew they existed.

The shirt wasn't important because of what it said.

It was important because of everything it represented.

"Looks good," Aman said, holding up his own.

"It does."

Neither of us said anything after that.

We didn't need to.

Some moments don't require celebration.

They simply ask you to pause.

We collected the rest of our merchandise, stepped aside from the queue and found a place to sit outside the building while waiting for the remaining formalities to finish.

The campus was slowly coming alive around us.

Groups of volunteers crossed the pathways carrying backpacks, event kits and enough enthusiasm to compensate for the lack of sleep.

Every few minutes another familiar face appeared.

The festival had officially begun.

Then I heard someone call my name.

I turned around.

Deepak.

Beside him stood Ansh Yadav.

They had reached the campus late the previous night and had come directly to CLT that morning to collect their own registrations and merchandise.

After weeks of seeing each other only through screens, meeting in person felt strangely natural.

No formal introductions.

No awkwardness.

Just the simple comfort of finally seeing teammates in the same place.

"When did you reach?" I asked.

"Past midnight," Deepak replied.

"And you're already awake?"

"I don't think I ever actually slept."

We laughed.

That answer would become surprisingly common over the next few days.

The four of us found a place to sit together just outside CLT.

For the next fifteen or twenty minutes, we did what people always do after finally meeting in person.

We exchanged travel stories.

Asked about everyone who was still on the way.

Wondered who would arrive next.

Tried to predict how chaotic the coming week would become.

Every prediction turned out to be far too optimistic.

Eventually, Deepak and Ansh left for breakfast.

Aman and I started walking back towards Krishna Hostel.

Neither of us realised that the phone call waiting for me would quietly change the rest of the day.

My phone rang just as Aman and I were about to enter Krishna Hostel.

The name on the screen was enough to tell me that the morning had officially begun.

Ratnesh.

If Ratnesh was calling this early, it usually meant only one thing.

Something needed to be done.

I answered almost immediately.

"Krish, where are you?"

"Near Krishna Hostel."

"Good. Come to ESB. The inventory has arrived. We have to distribute everything."

"I'm coming."

The call lasted less than a minute.

That was typical of Ratnesh.

He never wasted words when there was work waiting.

I slipped my phone back into my pocket and looked at Aman.

"Change of plans?"

I nodded.

"Inventory."

He smiled.

"So, Day Zero has officially started."

That single phone call changed the pace of the day.

Until then, the morning had still carried traces of the relaxed atmosphere from the previous two days. We had collected our wristbands, met a few friends and spent time talking outside CLT.

Now the festival had finally started asking something from us.

We changed direction and started walking towards the Electronic Sciences Block.

The route already felt familiar.

During the previous two days, ESB had quietly become the centre of our little world. Meetings happened there. Conversations happened there.

Somehow, no matter where the day began, it usually ended with someone saying,

"Let's go to ESB."

That morning, however, the building looked completely different.

The corridors were noticeably busier than before.

Volunteers carrying cartons moved from one room to another. Organizers walked past with printed lists in their hands. Every classroom seemed to have acquired a purpose overnight.

The peaceful academic building we had known on 7 June had transformed into an operations centre.

We reached Room 129 and immediately understood why Ratnesh had sounded so busy.

The room was filled with cartons.

Sports equipment.

Registration material.

Event supplies.

Identity cards.

Banners.

Stationery.

It looked less like a classroom and more like the backstage area of a festival that was about to begin.

Ratnesh stood in the middle of it all, somehow keeping track of everything at once.

The moment he saw us, he pointed towards a stack of boxes.

"Perfect. You're here."

No greeting.

No small talk.

Straight to work.

Exactly what I expected.

Within a few minutes, people from different events had gathered inside the room. Every team needed something different, which meant every carton had to be opened, checked and sorted before disappearing somewhere else on campus.

The room was noisy.

Not because people were shouting.

Because everyone was speaking at once.

Someone was counting ID cards.

Someone else was checking participant lists.

Another volunteer was trying to find a marker that had somehow disappeared less than a minute after the box had been opened.

It was wonderfully chaotic.

The kind of chaos that only exists before an event begins.

Somewhere in the middle of all that activity, another familiar voice called my name.

I turned around.

"Finally."

Methelesh.

He had just reached the campus.

For months, we had planned together through screens, discussed ideas over calls and solved problems from different cities.

Now, for the first time during Paradox, we were standing in the same room.

We shook hands.

That lasted less than a second.

The handshake immediately turned into a hug.

"Welcome to IIT Madras," I said.

He smiled.

"Feels good to finally be here."

"It gets crazier from here."

"I expected nothing less."

There wasn't much time for a longer conversation.

Ratnesh had already found another task for all of us.

Boxes still needed sorting.

Inventory still needed distributing.

And Day Zero had only just begun.

For the next hour or so, Room 129 barely resembled a classroom.

Every available table had disappeared beneath stacks of cartons, bundles of printed material and sports equipment waiting to be claimed. Volunteers moved constantly between the entrance and the room, carrying boxes that somehow never seemed to become any lighter.

The scene looked chaotic to anyone walking past.

Inside, however, there was an invisible rhythm.

Ratnesh called out the name of an event.

Someone identified the correct carton.

Another person checked the inventory list.

A fourth volunteer carried everything away before the next set of instructions had even finished.

Nobody stood still for very long.

We quickly found ourselves doing whatever was needed.

Opening cartons.

Checking quantities.

Separating equipment according to events.

Counting identity cards.

Making sure nothing was accidentally left behind.

It wasn't glamorous work.

In fact, if someone had photographed that room without any context, it would have looked like a group of students helping shift storage boxes from one classroom to another.

Yet all of us understood what those boxes represented.

Inside them were the little things people never notice during an event unless they are missing.

Volunteer ID cards.

Stationery.

Sports equipment.

Event materials.

The kind of details that quietly keep an entire festival functioning.

It reminded me of something I had learned during my time in Sportify.

People usually remember the winners.

Organizers remember the logistics.

Eventually, the items for our events had been separated from the rest.

"Take these to Krishna Hostel," Ratnesh said, pointing towards a growing pile beside the wall.

"We'll sort them there."

It sounded simple.

It wasn't.

The pile looked surprisingly manageable while it was sitting on the floor.

The moment we tried carrying it, the laws of physics suddenly became much more enthusiastic.

Boxes that had appeared reasonably light now demanded two people.

Banners refused to stay folded.

Packets slid from one carton to another at exactly the wrong moment.

Someone almost walked away carrying the wrong event material before another volunteer caught the mistake just in time.

The entire process was wonderfully inefficient.

Naturally, everyone found it hilarious.

By the time we finally left the building, we looked less like organizers and more like students returning from an unusually successful shopping trip.

Only instead of clothes or books, we were carrying the infrastructure of an entire sports department.

The walk back to Krishna Hostel felt considerably longer than I remembered.

Not because the distance had changed.

Because every few minutes someone needed to adjust their grip, shift a box to the other hand or stop altogether before continuing.

Nobody complained.

There was too much laughter for that.

Room 270 had already become the temporary collection point for sports inventory.

One after another, boxes were placed on the floor until the room slowly disappeared beneath event materials.

For the next several minutes, the room transformed into something between a warehouse and a planning room.

Lists were opened again.

Every event claimed its own materials.

Identity cards were sorted into neat piles.

Stationery found new owners.

Someone checked every carton one final time to ensure nothing had been forgotten.

The process was surprisingly satisfying.

After months of seeing our events as names inside spreadsheets, they had finally become physical.

There were actual bibs waiting for Kampus Run.

Actual paddles waiting for IPL Auction Showdown.

Actual materials that, within another day, would be in the hands of participants instead of stacked inside cardboard boxes.

One by one, the different event teams collected their share and started leaving.

Soon, only our own materials remained.

I picked up the final stack.

"Room 367?" Aman asked.

"Room 367."

For reasons that nobody had officially decided, my room had quietly become Sportify's unofficial storage room.

Every organiser knows that somewhere during an event, one room inevitably stops belonging to its occupants.

It starts belonging to everyone.

Apparently, Room 367 had been chosen.

By the time we finished arranging everything inside, the room looked noticeably different from the one I had entered two days earlier.

It was still my hostel room.

But now it also contained bibs, stationery, identity cards, event material and enough supplies to convince anyone walking in that they had accidentally entered the Sports Department instead.

Aman looked around the room and laughed.

"I don't think this is your room anymore."

I looked at the stacks lining one side of the wall.

"I think you're right."

Without either of us realizing it, Room 367 had quietly become Sportify Headquarters.

By the time we finished arranging everything inside Room 367, the morning had quietly slipped into the afternoon.

The room finally looked organized.

At least by student standards.

The cartons had been pushed neatly against one wall, identity cards were stacked together, event material had been separated and, most importantly, we could once again see the floor.

For the moment, that counted as success.

"We've earned breakfast," Aman declared.

I looked at my watch.

"I think we've missed breakfast."

He checked his own phone and laughed.

"Then we've earned an early lunch."

That sounded far more accurate.

We left Krishna Hostel and made our way towards Ishtara once again.

By now, walking to Himalaya Mess had become almost automatic. Without discussing it, all of us somehow ended up following the same familiar route. The campus, however, no longer looked the way it had on the previous two mornings.

There were more people now.

Much more.

Every road seemed busier.

Volunteers wearing Paradox T-shirts crossed the campus carrying event kits and backpacks. Small groups stood outside academic buildings discussing schedules, while others dragged suitcases towards their hostels after arriving only a few hours earlier.

The transformation had begun.

Paradox was no longer approaching.

It had arrived.

By the time we entered Ishtara, several familiar faces had already occupied different tables. Every few minutes another volunteer walked in, greeted someone they recognised and immediately joined an existing conversation.

The food almost became secondary.

Breakfast—if it could still be called breakfast—was filled with stories from overnight journeys.

"When did you reach?"

"Five in the morning."

"I've slept for barely two hours."

"Our train was delayed."

"My flight landed at midnight."

The same conversation repeated itself across almost every table.

Nobody complained.

If anything, everyone seemed strangely proud of how little sleep they had managed.

Student festivals have a curious way of convincing people that exhaustion is a badge of honour.

We were halfway through our meal when my phone vibrated again.

This time, the message was much shorter.

Methelesh has reached campus.

I looked up at Aman.

"He's here."

Without another word, we finished eating as quickly as possible and headed back towards the Electronic Sciences Block.

When we reached ESB, Methesh was already there.

He stood near the entrance talking to a couple of volunteers, looking exactly the way someone does after finally reaching the place they have spent months preparing for.

The moment he noticed us, a smile spread across his face.

"There you are."

"There you are," I replied.

It was funny how quickly online friendships returned to normal once people met in person.

There was no awkwardness.

No formal introductions.

No moment of trying to remember what to say.

It simply felt as though yesterday's Google Meet had somehow continued inside the corridors of the Electronic Sciences Block.

Sarthak had arrived as well.

Within a few minutes, the four of us were sitting together outside Room 127, talking about everything except the work waiting for us.

The conversation wandered effortlessly between travel stories, expectations for the coming week and predictions about which event would create the biggest chaos.

Every prediction sounded reasonable.

Almost every prediction turned out to be wrong.

Looking around the corridor, I realised something had quietly changed.

Two days earlier, Aman and I had walked through these same corridors knowing almost nobody.

Now, every few minutes another familiar face appeared.

Someone stopped to say hello.

Another person waved while walking past.

A volunteer joined the conversation for five minutes before disappearing again to finish another task.

The campus no longer felt unfamiliar.

It was slowly beginning to feel like home.

After sitting there for a while, someone suggested walking over to the Classroom Complex.

House meets had begun.

All twelve houses were gathering their members for the first time before the festival officially started.

It sounded interesting enough.

So we got up and started walking.

The Classroom Complex was buzzing with a completely different kind of energy.

Unlike the Electronic Sciences Block, where most conversations revolved around departments and logistics, the atmosphere here felt far more personal. Every house had gathered its members in different classrooms, and the corridors were filled with students trying to find their respective rooms, greeting old friends, introducing themselves to new faces and figuring out what the next few days were going to look like.

For the first time since arriving on campus, Paradox no longer felt like an organizing committee.

It felt like a festival.

We first walked into the Sundarbans House meeting.

The room was already half full, and more people continued arriving every few minutes. Introductions were taking place in one corner while another group discussed house events with an enthusiasm that only college festivals seem capable of producing.

We stayed for a while, listening more than speaking.

There was something enjoyable about simply observing people who were just as excited for the week ahead as we were.

Eventually curiosity got the better of us.

"What about the other houses?" someone asked.

It sounded like a reasonable suggestion.

For the next half an hour, we wandered from one classroom to another, peeking into different house meetings, greeting familiar faces whenever we spotted them and quietly comparing how every house had its own personality.

Some meetings looked highly organised.

Others looked as though they had collectively decided to improvise everything.

Neither approach seemed particularly surprising.

After visiting a few rooms, however, we reached the same conclusion.

"We're getting bored."

Nobody disagreed.

House meetings were interesting.

For about thirty minutes.

Beyond that, we all found ourselves wanting to return to the people we had actually come to campus with.

So we quietly left the Classroom Complex and started walking back towards the Electronic Sciences Block.

The route between CRC and ESB was beginning to feel strangely familiar.

It was becoming one of those paths that we would walk so often over the next week that, by the end of Paradox, none of us would even remember consciously taking it.

Back at ESB, we settled outside Room 127 once again.

There was no meeting this time.

No presentations.

No agenda.

People simply came and went, sat for a few minutes, shared a conversation and then disappeared to finish another task somewhere else on campus.

Room 127 had quietly become the common room for organizers.

If you didn't know where someone was, there was a surprisingly good chance they were somewhere near ESB.

We had barely been sitting there for ten minutes when someone reminded us that the volleyball trials were about to begin.

That was enough motivation to get everyone moving again.

The volleyball courts looked very different from the quiet academic buildings we had been sitting in all morning.

Players had already started warming up.

Volunteers moved around arranging equipment.

House members gathered along the sidelines, cheering for teammates before a single point had even been played.

There was a sense of excitement that hadn't existed anywhere else on campus so far.

For the first time, competition had entered the picture.

A little later, Varad joined us.

Like almost everyone else arriving that day, he carried the unmistakable expression of someone who had travelled, unpacked and immediately started working without giving himself much time to rest.

"You've started already?" he asked.

"We're trying to," Aman replied.

Varad laughed.

"We haven't even reached Day One yet."

"Exactly," I said. "Imagine Day Three."

None of us knew just how accurate that prediction would become.

While we were still talking, my phone rang.

The name on the screen made me smile.

Jahanvi.

She had finally reached campus.

"I've just arrived," she said.

"Where are you?"

"We're at the volleyball courts," I replied. "Come straight here."

"Okay, give me five minutes."

I looked up at the others.

"Jahanvi's here."

For a few moments, all of us instinctively looked towards the pathway leading to the courts.

Five minutes later, she appeared, suitcase nowhere in sight, looking exactly the way every volunteer looked that day—slightly tired from travelling, slightly overwhelmed by the campus and genuinely excited to finally be there.

That was the first time we met in person.

Until then, every conversation had happened through calls and meetings.

Seeing someone in real life after months of working together online is always a strange experience.

You already know the person.

You simply haven't shared the same space before.

We spent the next fifteen or twenty minutes talking.

Mostly about the journey.

The campus.

The events waiting ahead.

The conversation was easy, as though we had simply continued the discussions that had started months earlier over Google Meet.

After travelling, however, it was obvious that she needed a break.

"You should go to ESB," I said.

She looked slightly confused.

"Why?"

"Room 127."

"There'll be AC."

"And," Aman added with a grin, "there's a good chance half the organizing committee will be there anyway."

She laughed.

"That actually sounds like a good plan."

So she headed towards ESB, while the rest of us remained at the volleyball courts for a little longer, watching the trials continue.

None of us realised it then, but by the end of the evening, almost the entire Sportify family would finally be under one roof.

As the afternoon slowly drifted into evening, the campus continued changing almost by the hour.

Every time we looked around, another familiar face had appeared.

Someone who had been on a train that morning was now walking across the volleyball court carrying a backpack. Another person who had spent

the previous night travelling was already discussing event plans as though they had been on campus for days.

The arrivals never seemed to stop.

And with every arrival, Sportify became a little more complete.

By early evening, the volleyball trials had wrapped up and people gradually started dispersing towards their hostels.

Some needed rest.

Some needed food.

Some simply wanted to unpack their bags after travelling halfway across the country.

Before everyone disappeared, I stopped a few of them.

"Come to Room 367 in a while."

"For what?"

"You'll see."

That answer seemed to satisfy everyone.

One by one, people started arriving.

The first few squeezed themselves onto the beds.

Others claimed the chairs.

Someone sat cross-legged on the floor without waiting for permission.

Within a matter of minutes, Room 367 had completely forgotten that it was designed for only two people.

Luggage occupied one corner.

Sports material occupied another.

The remaining space somehow managed to accommodate an entire team.

I looked around the room and smiled.

Two days earlier, it had felt almost empty.

Now it was impossible to move without asking someone to shift a little.

Exactly the way it should have been.

The original reason for gathering was perfectly practical.

We needed to prepare the paddles for the IPL Auction Showdown.

Sheets were opened.

Names were checked.

Markers appeared from somebody's backpack.

One by one, the paddles slowly began taking shape.

Like most student work sessions, however, productivity lasted only a few minutes before conversations completely took over.

Someone started telling a story from their journey to Chennai.

Another person interrupted halfway through with an even better one.

Someone else insisted that their train experience had been considerably worse.

Within moments, the room had transformed from a workplace into a storytelling session.

Every now and then, someone would remember the paddles waiting to be completed.

"Guys..."

"We should probably finish these."

"Yes."

Nobody moved.

Five minutes later, exactly the same conversation happened again.

Eventually, enough work happened between the conversations for the paddles to be completed.

Looking back, I honestly don't remember who finished making which paddle.

I remember the laughter.

That room contained people from different cities, different colleges and completely different backgrounds.

Only a few months earlier, many of us hadn't even known each other existed.

Yet somehow, sitting inside Room 367 that evening, it felt as though we had been friends for much longer.

There was something wonderfully uncomplicated about it.

Nobody was trying to impress anyone.

Nobody was thinking about positions or responsibilities.

Secretary.

Deputy Secretary.

Coordinator.

Department Head.

For a little while, all those designations disappeared.

We were simply a group of twenty-year-olds sitting inside an overcrowded hostel room, making event paddles and laughing far more than the situation probably justified.

I think that was the first moment when Sportify truly felt like a family.

Not because of any official meeting.

Not because of a successful event.

Not because someone gave a motivational speech.

It happened because everyone was finally together.

At some point, someone looked at the time.

"Dinner?"

That suggestion received immediate approval.

The paddles were stacked carefully on one side of the room.

Someone switched off the lights.

Someone else made sure the door was locked.

Then, like a noisy procession that had outgrown its headquarters, the entire group started walking towards Ishtara together.

The campus looked completely different from the one Aman and I had first seen on 7 June.

The roads were alive now.

Every few steps, we crossed another group of participants discussing competitions, carrying luggage or searching for their hostels.

Music drifted from somewhere in the distance.

Volunteers hurried past wearing Paradox T-shirts.

For the first time since arriving in Chennai, the institute truly looked like a festival.

And walking through the middle of it, surrounded by the people who had made the last eight months unforgettable, I realised something that hadn't occurred to me before.

The waiting was finally over.

Paradox had begun.

Dinner that night felt different from the previous evenings.

Two days earlier, Ishtara had been quiet enough that finding a table required almost no effort.

Now, every corner of the food court seemed alive.

Volunteers wearing Paradox T-shirts filled the tables. House members discussed strategies for competitions beginning the next morning. Somewhere behind us, a group was enthusiastically debating which house would eventually top the leaderboard, while another argued over schedules that nobody seemed to have fully understood yet.

The festival had finally arrived.

Finding enough chairs for our group turned into a challenge of its own.

Eventually, after borrowing a chair from one table, squeezing another between two others and convincing someone that five people could comfortably fit into a space designed for four, we managed.

Nobody complained.

In fact, the slightly crowded arrangement somehow made the dinner more enjoyable.

Conversations bounced from one end of the table to the other.

Someone discussed volleyball trials.

Someone else talked about the journey to Chennai.

The IPL Auction paddles we had prepared an hour earlier somehow became the subject of an entirely unnecessary debate over whose handwriting looked the worst.

Predictably, nobody accepted responsibility.

The food arrived gradually, never quite reaching everyone at the same time. That hardly mattered. People stole bites from each other's plates, exchanged dishes without asking and continued conversations exactly where they had left them before the waiters interrupted.

Looking around the table, I realised something that hadn't been true even that morning.

There wasn't a single empty chair.

Sportify was finally complete.

For months we had worked together through laptop screens and phone calls, imagining what this week would look like once everyone reached the same campus.

Now we no longer had to imagine it.

We were living it.

Dinner eventually came to an end, though nobody appeared particularly eager to leave.

Some groups walked back towards their hostels.

Others disappeared towards different parts of the campus, still carrying on conversations that had clearly started over dinner.

Aman and I began making our way back towards Krishna Hostel at an unhurried pace.

The campus looked completely different from the one we had first entered on 7 June.

The roads that had once been almost empty were now filled with students.

Music drifted faintly from somewhere in the distance.

The occasional institute bus rolled past carrying another group of participants who had only just arrived.

Everywhere we looked, Paradox had begun writing its own stories.

It was close to one in the morning when we reached the area near the food trucks opposite the bus stand, not far from Cauvery Hostel.

Just as we were about to continue walking, someone called out my name.

"Krish!"

I turned around.

Jahanvi stood near one of the food trucks, waving in our direction.

Beside her was someone I had been waiting to meet for the first time.

Pratishtha.

She had reached the campus only a little while earlier and, like almost everyone else arriving that day, her first instinct had apparently been to find something to eat before worrying about anything else.

We walked over.

"So you finally made it," I said.

She smiled.

"Finally."

There is something strangely familiar about meeting people you have already known for months.

Technically, it is the first meeting.

Emotionally, it isn't.

By then, we had already spent countless hours working together online. We knew each other's voices, habits and working styles. The only thing missing had been the chance to stand in the same place and have an ordinary conversation.

For the next twenty minutes, the four of us stood there talking beside the food truck.

The conversation wandered naturally from travel stories to the campus, from upcoming events to the excitement of finally having everyone together.

There was nothing particularly extraordinary about that conversation.

No major decisions were made.

No life-changing advice was exchanged.

It was simply four friends talking at one in the morning after months of preparing for the same week.

Looking back, that simplicity is exactly what made it memorable.

Eventually, fatigue began winning its inevitable battle.

The journeys, the preparations and the excitement of Day Zero had finally caught up with all of us.

"We should probably sleep," Aman said.

For once, nobody argued.

We wished Jahanvi and Pratishta good night before beginning the short walk back to Krishna Hostel.

The campus had finally grown quiet again.

Tomorrow morning, it would wake up to football trials, packed venues and the first real test of everything we had spent months preparing.

As I unlocked the door to Room 367 and looked once more at the stacks of event material waiting patiently against the wall, one thought crossed my mind before I finally switched off the lights.

Tomorrow, the work would truly begin.

PART III
THE WEEK THE
WORLD SHRANK

The days became longer.

Sleep became shorter.

*Somewhere between whistles, scoreboards, muddy shoes, walkie-talkies and
thousands of footsteps, we forgot what day it was.*

We only remembered that we were exactly where we wanted to be.

Chapter 11

The First Morning

The first morning of Paradox did not begin with an announcement.

It did not begin with music echoing across the campus or crowds gathering outside event venues. There was no grand opening ceremony waiting to welcome everyone into the festival. Instead, it began the way most student festivals actually do—with alarms ringing long before sunrise, organisers forcing themselves out of bed after far too little sleep, and a campus that looked as though it was quietly preparing for something much larger than itself.

At five o'clock, my phone vibrated on the table beside my bed.

For a brief moment, I considered ignoring it.

The room was still dark, and the previous day's exhaustion had not disappeared just because a new day had begun. Every muscle in my body reminded me that we had slept well past one in the morning after walking across half the campus, carrying inventory, organising our room, meeting almost the entire Sportify team and ending the night beside a food truck near Cauvery Hostel.

Another hour of sleep sounded wonderfully reasonable.

Paradox had different plans.

I reached over, switched off the alarm and sat quietly on the edge of the bed, giving myself a minute to fully wake up. The room was silent except for the steady hum of the ceiling fan. Against one wall, the neatly arranged stacks of bibs, identity cards and event material waited exactly where we had left them the previous night.

Room 367 no longer looked like a hostel room.

It looked like a control room.

I smiled without really thinking about it.

Only three days earlier, I had walked into this room carrying nothing more than a suitcase and a backpack. Now it contained enough material to convince anyone walking in that the Sports Department had unofficially occupied Krishna Hostel.

There was something strangely satisfying about that transformation.

A knock on the door interrupted my thoughts.

"You awake?" Aman's voice came from outside.

"Barely."

"Good."

"That's your standard?"

"For today, yes."

I opened the door to find him already wearing his Paradox T-shirt, looking considerably more awake than I felt.

"I was hoping you'd message saying football trials had been cancelled," I said as we started walking down the corridor.

"You've organised enough events to know that's never happening."

"I know."

"And besides," he added, smiling, "today is Day One."

That sentence carried a different weight now.

Until yesterday, everyone had spoken about Day One as though it existed somewhere in the future.

Now it had arrived.

The festival had finally stopped being something we were preparing for.

We were living it.

The corridors of Krishna Hostel were unusually quiet as we stepped outside. A handful of organisers were already walking towards different venues, recognisable even from a distance by their Paradox T-shirts and the slightly hurried pace that seemed to unite every volunteer on campus.

The sky had only just begun to brighten.

Streetlights still illuminated long stretches of the roads, casting soft pools of light beneath the trees that lined almost every pathway inside IIT Madras. The air carried a welcome coolness that would disappear within the next couple of hours, replaced by the familiar June heat we had already begun respecting.

For now, though, the morning belonged to those who were awake early enough to witness it.

Neither Aman nor I spoke very much during the walk.

Not because there was nothing to say.

Because mornings before sunrise have their own language.

The silence never feels awkward.

It feels shared.

As we crossed one of the roads leading towards the sports grounds, we began noticing more volunteers emerging from different hostels. Some carried footballs tucked beneath an arm. Others balanced clipboards, water bottles or bags filled with event material. A few greeted us as they passed, exchanging the sort of sleepy smiles that said, *Yes, we're all tired, but we're here.*

The campus itself seemed to be waking up with us.

Somewhere in the distance, we heard the first sharp whistle cut through the morning air.

It was faint.

Almost carried away by the breeze.

Yet it instantly changed something inside both of us.

I looked towards Aman.

He looked back at me.

Neither of us needed to say it aloud.

The week we had spent months planning had officially begun.

The football ground came into view a few minutes later, already alive with movement despite the early hour.

Players from different houses jogged slow laps around the boundary to warm up. Small groups stretched near the touchline while others passed footballs between themselves, trying to settle the nervous energy that always appears before trials. Volunteers moved purposefully across the ground, checking cones, arranging equipment and making sure every small detail had been taken care of before participants assembled.

Only a few days earlier, this had been just another football field inside IIT Madras.

That morning, it had become the first stage on which Paradox would begin telling its story.

By the time we reached the sidelines, most of the participants had already reported for the trials.

The football ground carried a kind of energy that is difficult to recreate anywhere else. It wasn't loud—not yet—but there was an unmistakable tension in the air. Players stretched in silence, adjusted their boots, exchanged a few final words with teammates and occasionally glanced towards the volunteers waiting with clipboards.

Everyone knew the trials would only last a short while.

Everyone also knew that a short while was enough to change the rest of the week.

The Sports Department members were already moving from one task to another.

Attendance had to be verified.

House-wise groups had to be organised.

Participants who had somehow managed to report to the wrong ground needed to be redirected.

Someone was looking for an extra whistle.

Someone else had misplaced a marker cone that had been in their hand less than five minutes earlier.

Watching volunteers search for things they themselves had misplaced was a tradition that seemed common to every event.

"Did anyone see the attendance sheet?"

"It was with you."

"No, I gave it to him."

"He gave it back."

"When?"

"I don't know."

Eventually the sheet was found exactly where everyone should have checked first.

On the table.

Right beneath another file.

Nobody said anything.

Everyone simply continued working as though the previous three minutes had never happened.

That, I would later realise, was another unwritten rule of organising events.

If a problem gets solved, nobody wastes time discussing how it happened.

The players were soon divided into their respective groups.

House captains gathered everyone together and explained the trial format one final time. Some participants listened carefully. Others nodded confidently despite clearly not hearing half the instructions.

Aman looked at me and smiled.

"Ten minutes."

"For what?"

"Someone's going to ask the exact question that was just answered."

I laughed.

"You underestimate people."

"No," he replied. "I've organised enough events."

He was right.

The explanation had barely ended before the first hand went up.

"Sir, which group am I supposed to join?"

The volunteer answered patiently.

Less than a minute later, another participant walked over.

"Excuse me... where do we report?"

I looked at Aman.

He didn't say a word.

He simply smiled with the quiet satisfaction of someone whose prediction had been proven almost immediately.

Despite the small moments of confusion, everything moved surprisingly smoothly.

Months of planning had made their presence felt.

Every volunteer knew where they were expected to stand.

Every responsibility had already been assigned.

People didn't need constant instructions because everyone understood their role before arriving at the ground.

That was perhaps the biggest difference between participating in an event and organising one.

Participants saw the football.

Organisers saw everything around it.

They noticed whether enough water bottles had been arranged.

They noticed whether the registration desk had enough pens.

They noticed whether players were entering from the correct side of the field.

Success wasn't measured only by what happened on the pitch.

It was measured by how little people noticed everything happening off it.

As the first whistle echoed across the ground, casual conversations disappeared almost instantly.

The players spread out across the field.

The volunteers stepped back.

The trials had officially begun.

For the next couple of hours, football took over the morning.

Some players immediately announced themselves with brilliant first touches and confident passing. Others needed a few minutes before the nervousness faded and they began playing the way they knew they could.

Every now and then, a particularly clever pass or a perfectly timed tackle drew applause from teammates waiting along the sidelines.

Competition has a remarkable way of bringing strangers together.

Within minutes, people who had met only that morning were cheering for one another as though they had played together for years.

Standing near the touchline, I realised something that had quietly changed over the past few days.

Until then, Paradox had mostly existed inside classrooms, meeting rooms and WhatsApp groups.

This was different.

This was exactly what we had been working towards.

The spreadsheets had become scoreboards.

The planning documents had become players.

The festival had finally become real.

The morning passed much faster than any of us expected.

When you're helping organise an event, time behaves differently. You begin the day believing you have hours ahead of you, only to glance at your watch and realise that an entire morning has quietly disappeared.

Football trials followed their own rhythm.

One group stepped onto the field.

Another waited patiently along the sidelines.

Volunteers called out names, recorded observations and directed players towards the next drill. Every now and then, a disputed decision sparked a brief discussion, but it rarely lasted long. Everyone understood that trials were never going to satisfy every participant.

That was simply the nature of sport.

What impressed me most wasn't the football itself.

It was the teamwork happening around it.

Volunteers who had met only a day or two earlier worked together as though they had organised events for years. Nobody waited to be told what to do. If someone noticed a problem, they solved it. If another volunteer looked overwhelmed, someone quietly stepped in to help.

That was the invisible side of Paradox.

Most participants would remember the goals.

The organisers would remember everything that happened before the first kick.

As the final trial came to an end, the atmosphere on the ground changed almost immediately.

The tension disappeared.

Players who had spent the last two hours competing against one another now stood together discussing memorable moments from the trials. Some confidently predicted they would make the final squad, while others replayed missed chances that would probably stay in their minds for the rest of the day.

Nearby, the Sports Department members finally allowed themselves to relax.

Someone sat down on the grass without saying a word.

Another volunteer finished an entire bottle of water in one go.

A few people simply looked at each other and smiled.

The first event of the festival had gone well.

That alone was enough to lift everyone's mood.

"Group photo?" someone shouted from the other side of the ground.

Nobody needed convincing.

Within moments, players, volunteers and organisers gathered near the centre of the field. As always, arranging a group photograph turned out to be considerably more difficult than taking one.

"Taller people at the back."

"No, not that far back."

"Everyone move closer."

"Closer."

"I said closer, not on top of each other."

The photographer continued giving instructions while everyone else tried their best to follow them, though laughter made the process considerably slower.

Eventually, after what felt like ten different attempts, the camera clicked.

Then another.

And another.

Nobody trusted the first photograph.

Looking at those pictures later, I realised they captured far more than a football trial.

They captured the first successful morning of Paradox.

The first proof that months of planning were finally turning into reality.

As people slowly began leaving the ground, Aman stretched his arms and looked towards me.

"Breakfast?"

"I thought you'd never ask."

Neither of us had realised how hungry we had become.

We started walking back towards Ishtara, following a steady stream of volunteers who had clearly arrived at exactly the same conclusion.

The roads were no longer quiet.

The peaceful campus we had walked through before sunrise had completely disappeared.

Participants wearing jerseys crossed paths with organisers carrying folders. House members discussed selections while volunteers hurried towards venues where the next events were already beginning.

The institute had transformed in just a few hours.

The festival was no longer waking up.

It was fully alive.

As Aman and I walked towards breakfast, neither of us knew that before the morning ended, I would meet someone I had been waiting months to see.

That meeting deserves a story of its own.

Chapter 12

Ansh

Breakfast after an event always tastes different.

Maybe it is because hunger feels more honest after spending hours on your feet. Maybe it is because the mind finally allows itself to slow down once the immediate responsibility is over. Whatever the reason, Aman and I reached Ishtara that morning feeling as though we had already lived an entire day before most of the campus had even finished waking up.

The food court looked nothing like it had a few hours earlier.

The quiet tables from dawn had disappeared beneath conversations. Volunteers from different departments occupied almost every corner, comparing stories from the first events of the morning while participants proudly analysed performances that had ended only minutes ago.

Paradox had settled into its rhythm.

We picked up our breakfast and found a table near one side of the hall.

For a little while, neither of us spoke very much.

The silence wasn't awkward.

It was simply the silence of two people who had spent an entire morning solving problems together.

Aman broke it first.

"I think football went well."

I nodded.

"Better than I expected."

"There'll be bigger challenges."

"There always are."

He smiled.

"But at least we know we're awake now."

"I wasn't sure about that at five in the morning."

"You looked like you wanted to negotiate with your alarm."

"I absolutely did."

We both laughed.

It was one of those ordinary conversations that disappear from memory almost immediately.

Except this one didn't.

Perhaps because it happened just before the moment that would define the rest of my day.

I had barely finished the last few bites of breakfast when my phone vibrated.

The message was short.

"I've reached. I'm standing outside Cauvery Hostel."

It was from Ansh.

For a second, I simply looked at the screen.

Months of planning together.

Months of phone calls.

Months of saying,

"See you in Chennai."

And now he was here.

I slipped the phone back into my pocket and looked at Aman.

"He's here."

Aman didn't need to ask who I meant.

He smiled immediately.

"Let's go."

The walk from Ishtara to Cauvery Hostel wasn't particularly long.

Yet I remember almost every part of it.

Perhaps anticipation has a way of making ordinary roads memorable.

The campus was fully alive now.

Participants hurried between venues carrying house flags over their shoulders. Volunteers crossed intersections with walkie-talkies clipped to their belts. Every few minutes another announcement echoed from somewhere in the distance before disappearing into the sounds of conversations, footsteps and whistles.

The festival had found its rhythm.

Meanwhile, my attention remained fixed on one thought.

Ansh had finally arrived.

It is a strange feeling to wait months to meet someone you already know so well.

Technically, it is an introduction.

Emotionally, it isn't.

We had spent countless hours working together, discussing Sportify, planning events and solving problems that seemed impossible until someone eventually found a solution.

Yet every conversation had happened through a screen.

There is always a small part of you that wonders whether meeting in person will feel different.

I would find out in just a few minutes.

As we turned the final corner near Cauvery Hostel, I spotted him almost immediately.

He was standing exactly where he had said he would be, backpack resting beside him, looking around the campus with the unmistakable expression of someone who had only recently arrived and was still trying to take everything in.

He saw us at almost the same moment.

Neither of us waved.

Neither of us needed to.

We simply started walking towards each other.

The distance disappeared quickly.

And before either of us said a single word, we hugged.

It wasn't a formal greeting.

It wasn't one of those awkward embraces people exchange because they think they should.

It was the kind of hug that quietly acknowledges months of shared work, countless late-night conversations and the simple relief of finally saying,

"We made it."

For a few seconds, nothing else mattered.

Not the schedule.

Not the events waiting for us.

Not the responsibilities that would soon pull all of us in different directions.

Paradox could wait.

My brother had arrived.

For the first few moments, neither of us said very much.

We simply stood there smiling, almost laughing at how strange it felt to finally meet in person after months of working together.

"So..." I finally said.

"So," Ansh replied.

"Welcome to IIT Madras."

He looked around the campus before shaking his head with a smile.

"I still can't believe we're actually here."

"I know exactly what you mean."

There are some conversations that don't need a beginning.

Ours was one of them.

It felt less like meeting someone for the first time and more like continuing a conversation that had briefly paused a few hundred kilometres away.

Aman stood beside us, watching the reunion with a grin on his face.

"I think I'll let you two have your emotional moment," he joked.

I laughed.

"You'll survive."

"I've survived worse."

That quickly broke whatever little awkwardness remained.

Within a few minutes, the conversation had become exactly what it always was whenever our group got together—completely unpredictable.

Ansh spoke about his journey to Chennai and the endless delays that seemed determined to become part of every long-distance train trip in India. We filled him in on everything that had happened since 7 June, beginning with our arrival at Krishna Hostel and somehow reaching the story of the Snow Zone without following any logical order in between.

"You slept during the movie?"

"I maintain that the movie slept first," I replied.

"And then Krish tried attacking Aman with a snowball," Aman added immediately.

Ansh looked at me.

"What happened?"

"I fell."

"You missed him?"

"I missed everything."

Aman couldn't resist.

"He successfully defeated himself."

The laughter started all over again.

Some stories never lose their entertainment value, no matter how many times they're told.

As we stood there talking, more familiar faces began appearing near Cauvery Hostel.

Methelesh walked over first, carrying the same backpack he seemed to have been living out of since reaching campus.

A few moments later, Sarthak joined us as well.

The circle grew naturally.

Nobody announced that a meeting had begun.

People simply arrived, pulled into the conversation one by one.

Before long, Jahanvi and Pratishtha also made their way over after finishing their own breakfast.

Seeing everyone together in one place felt oddly satisfying.

Only a week earlier, every one of these conversations would have required a Google Meet link, stable internet and the inevitable question of whether everyone's microphone was working.

Now we were all standing beneath the same Chennai sky, interrupting one another in real time instead of waiting for someone to finish speaking on a video call.

The difference was impossible to describe.

For almost half an hour, we talked about everything except work.

Someone complained about the Chennai weather.

Someone else defended it.

The debate lasted all of thirty seconds before everyone agreed that surviving June in Chennai was simply another unofficial Paradox event.

Travel stories followed.

Then hostel stories.

Then the inevitable discussion about who had managed to sleep the least since arriving on campus.

Nobody won that competition.

Everyone had a convincing argument.

At one point, I stepped back slightly and looked around the group.

It struck me how ordinary the scene appeared from a distance.

To anyone walking past, we were just a few students standing outside a hostel, laughing over conversations that probably sounded meaningless to everyone else.

Yet I knew I would remember that morning for years.

Not because anything extraordinary had happened.

Because moments like this are rare.

You spend months building friendships through calls, messages and shared responsibilities.

Then, for a brief period, everyone finally exists in the same place.

No screens.

No buffering.

No "You're on mute."

Just people.

Real conversations.

Real laughter.

Real memories.

Eventually, my phone vibrated again.

This time, the message carried a familiar urgency.

It wasn't another friend arriving on campus.

It was work.

The IPL Auction Showdown team had informed us that there had been a last-minute change.

The venue had been shifted from **Raman Block Room 203** to **Biotech Department, Room 207**.

I looked up from my phone.

"I think our break is over."

The smiles remained.

Everyone already knew what that meant.

Paradox had given us half an hour to be friends.

Now it was asking us to become organisers again.

Together, we started walking towards the Biotech Department, completely unaware that the first major crisis of the day was already waiting outside Room 207.

Chapter 13

IPL Auction Showdown

The walk from Cauvery Hostel to the Biotech Department was considerably louder than the walk that had brought us there.

The difference was easy to understand.

Half an hour earlier, most of us had been meeting each other after weeks or months apart. Now that everyone had settled in, the conversations became exactly what they had always been during online meetings—only this time nobody had to wait for someone else's microphone to unmute.

The group stretched across the pathway in the wonderfully disorganised manner that only college students seem capable of achieving. Someone walked ahead discussing player strategies for the auction. Another conversation drifted towards football trials. Every few minutes someone remembered another story from the previous night's Snow Zone adventure, and before long the entire group was laughing again.

For a brief while, it almost felt as though we were simply walking to another classroom.

The reality waiting ahead was very different.

The IPL Auction Showdown had originally been scheduled for **Room 203 in Raman Block**.

At the last moment, however, the venue had been shifted to **Room 207 in the Biotech Department**.

Venue changes are never ideal.

Venue changes on the morning of an event are considerably worse.

Still, everyone remained optimistic.

"The room should already be open," someone said.

"It has to be."

"We're already cutting it close."

We reached the building a few minutes later.

Volunteers had already begun gathering outside the classroom.

Some participants had also arrived, assuming preparations would already be underway.

Instead, everyone was standing in the corridor.

Waiting.

I looked towards the classroom door.

It was locked.

At first, nobody seemed particularly worried.

"Someone must have the keys."

"Probably."

"We'll start in five minutes."

Five minutes passed.

Nothing changed.

One volunteer went searching for the department staff.

Another called someone from the central organising team.

A third disappeared downstairs, convinced the keys had accidentally been left in another office.

The corridor slowly became busier.

Participants continued arriving, each asking the same question.

"Has the event started?"

"Not yet."

"Why?"

"We're waiting for the keys."

That answer became the most repeated sentence of the morning.

Inside our team, however, the atmosphere remained surprisingly calm.

There was no shouting.

No panic.

Just a quiet understanding that getting frustrated would not magically unlock the classroom.

So we waited.

People made phone calls.

Others checked alternative contacts.

Every few minutes someone returned with another update.

"No luck yet."

The minutes continued slipping away.

Looking back, I realise that this was my first real lesson in event management during Paradox.

Months of planning can be interrupted by something as simple as a locked door.

And when that happens, the only thing that matters is how calmly your team responds.

Eventually, footsteps echoed through the corridor.

One of the volunteers appeared at the end of the hallway holding something in his hand.

A small bunch of keys.

I have rarely seen ordinary metal keys receive such an enthusiastic welcome.

Someone clapped.

Another person laughed in relief.

"Finally!"

The classroom door opened.

Almost instantly, the corridor came alive.

Tables were rearranged.

Projectors were checked.

Registration desks were set up.

Auction materials were unpacked.

Within seconds, the room transformed from an ordinary classroom into the venue for one of Sportify's flagship events.

It was remarkable how quickly organised chaos replaced complete stillness.

The crisis had delayed us.

It hadn't defeated us.

I stood near the entrance for a moment, watching volunteers move confidently from one task to another.

Only a few minutes earlier, we had all been standing helplessly outside a locked classroom.

Now the event looked as though it had always been under control.

That is the illusion every good organising team tries to create.

Participants should never feel the panic organisers experienced just moments before they arrived.

The room slowly filled.

House representatives took their seats.

Auction paddles appeared on desks.

Excitement replaced uncertainty.

The countdown to the opening had begun.

I looked around the room one final time.

Then someone handed me the microphone.

"Krish," they said.

"I think it's your turn."

For a second, I simply looked at the microphone.

It is a strange object.

When it is lying on a table, it is nothing more than another piece of equipment. The moment someone places it in your hand, however, every pair of eyes in the room suddenly seems to belong to you.

The classroom had settled into silence.

Only a few minutes earlier, everyone had been standing outside a locked room, wondering whether the event would even begin on time. Now the projector was running, the auction tables were ready, house representatives sat with their paddles in front of them, and the room carried the familiar excitement that always exists before the first word is spoken.

I took a slow breath.

Not because I was nervous.

Because I wanted to take in the moment before it disappeared.

Months earlier, IPL Auction Showdown had been nothing more than an idea discussed during one of our online meetings. We had debated formats, scoring systems, budgets, player pools and house participation over countless calls. Every small decision had required another discussion, another spreadsheet or another revision.

Now all of that work had condensed into one classroom.

The event was no longer a plan.

It was waiting.

I stepped forward and welcomed everyone to the IPL Auction Showdown.

The introduction itself lasted only a few minutes. I spoke about the format, wished every house the very best for the competition and thanked everyone who had contributed towards bringing the event together.

The words themselves are difficult to remember today.

The feeling isn't.

Standing there, looking across a room filled with participants who had travelled from different parts of the country, I realised something that had quietly changed over the past year.

When I had first joined Sportify, speaking in front of a room like this would have felt intimidating.

Now it felt natural.

Not because I had suddenly become fearless.

Because leadership has a curious way of changing your relationship with responsibility. The more often you step forward when something needs to

be done, the less you think about yourself and the more you think about the people waiting for you to begin.

The applause that followed was brief but warm.

I smiled, thanked everyone once again and handed the microphone to the auction team.

From that point onward, the room belonged to them.

The transformation was almost immediate.

The quiet classroom disappeared beneath the excitement of bidding.

Auctioneers found their rhythm within minutes, calling out player names one after another while representatives from different houses quickly discussed strategies before raising their paddles. Every successful bid was followed by celebrations from one table and playful disappointment from another.

Within half an hour, the room had become wonderfully noisy.

House loyalties took over.

Friendly rivalries surfaced.

Carefully planned budgets began disappearing much faster than anyone had intended.

Some representatives remained remarkably calm, refusing to bid impulsively and patiently waiting for the right players. Others abandoned strategy altogether, raising their paddles with complete confidence before remembering they had already spent a significant portion of their virtual purse.

That, perhaps, was the beauty of the event.

It wasn't just about cricket knowledge.

It was about judgement, patience and occasionally surviving your own teammates' enthusiasm.

Aman and I moved quietly around the room throughout the event, helping wherever we were needed.

Sometimes that meant answering questions from participants.

Sometimes it meant solving small technical issues before anyone else noticed them.

Occasionally it simply meant standing back and watching everything unfold exactly the way we had hoped it would months earlier.

Those were my favourite moments.

Not because there was nothing to do.

Because there was very little left to fix.

Every organiser secretly dreams of reaching the point where an event begins running on its own.

That afternoon, IPL Auction Showdown reached that point.

The volunteers no longer needed constant instructions.

Participants had fully immersed themselves in the competition.

Laughter echoed across the room every few minutes as another unexpected bid changed the balance of power between the houses.

For the first time since the morning began, I allowed myself to relax.

I looked around the classroom and smiled.

The locked door, the missing keys and the uncertainty outside the venue already felt like a distant memory.

It struck me how quickly people forget the obstacles once an event comes alive.

Perhaps that is the greatest compliment organisers can receive.

When participants remember the experience instead of the problems, you know your team has done its job well.

Around five o'clock, I quietly checked the time.

Another responsibility was waiting.

One that could not be delayed.

Kampus Run.

The biggest event under my responsibility was less than twenty-four hours away, and hundreds of runners would soon begin collecting their bibs.

I walked over to Aman.

"I need to leave."

He nodded before I had even finished the sentence.

"I know."

Neither of us needed to explain why.

Some events ask you to stay until the very end.

Others ask you to trust your team enough to walk away while the work continues.

This was one of those moments.

I took one last look around the room before stepping into the corridor.

Behind me, the auction continued with the same energy it had found an hour earlier.

Ahead of me, another chapter of Paradox was already waiting.

Outside Raman Block, a pile of bibs, safety pins and one particularly mischievous monkey were about to create a story that none of us would ever forget.

Chapter 14

The Monkey's First Victory

If there is one thing every event organiser eventually learns, it is this:

The problem you spend weeks preparing for is rarely the one that actually happens.

You prepare for registration issues.

You prepare for technical failures.

You prepare for participants arriving late, volunteers missing their shifts or the weather refusing to cooperate.

Nobody prepares for monkeys.

I left the IPL Auction venue a little after five in the evening.

The event was running smoothly, and for the first time that day I felt comfortable walking away. The team had everything under control, participants were fully immersed in the auction, and my attention had already shifted towards the responsibility waiting for me on the other side of campus.

Kampus Run.

Out of everything Sportify was organising during Paradox, this was the event that occupied most of my thoughts. Months of planning had gone into it. Routes had been discussed repeatedly, volunteer positions mapped out, safety protocols reviewed, participant lists finalised and bibs printed after what felt like endless rounds of checking and rechecking.

Tomorrow morning, none of those preparations would matter unless every runner received the correct bib.

That evening was dedicated entirely to making sure they did.

The distribution point had been set up outside Raman Block, and by the time I reached the venue, several members of the Kampus Run team were already there.

Large cartons filled with bibs rested against one side of the building.

Safety pins had been separated into packets.

Participant lists were spread across a table while volunteers checked names and arranged the bibs in numerical order.

It looked exactly the way a pre-event distribution centre should look.

Busy.

Organised.

Efficient.

For the next couple of hours, runners arrived steadily.

Some came alone.

Others appeared in groups, immediately turning the collection process into another excuse to catch up with friends they had not seen since arriving on campus.

Every few minutes another participant walked over to the desk.

"Name?"

The volunteer checked the list.

The bib was handed over.

A quick explanation followed about reporting time the next morning, followed by a reminder not to forget the bib before arriving at the starting point.

The process repeated itself again and again.

Simple.

Predictable.

Exactly the kind of work organisers enjoy because everything is finally going according to plan.

Perhaps that was why none of us noticed our unexpected visitor at first.

He had been watching us for considerably longer than we had been watching him.

Perched comfortably on a nearby tree branch sat a monkey, observing the entire operation with what I can only describe as professional curiosity.

At first, nobody paid much attention.

After all, we were inside IIT Madras.

Seeing monkeys around the campus was hardly unusual.

They wandered through hostels, climbed across rooftops and occasionally appeared near food courts whenever they suspected someone had underestimated their appetite.

This one, however, seemed interested in something other than food.

He was watching the table.

More specifically...

He was watching our bibs.

None of us realised that the next few seconds would become one of the funniest stories Sportify would tell for years afterward.

Absolutely. One thing though - I want to keep the monkey behaving like a **real IIT Madras monkey**, not like a cartoon character. The humor should come from everyone's reaction, not from exaggerating the monkey itself.

For several minutes, the monkey remained exactly where he was.

He didn't make a sound.

He didn't move.

He simply watched.

Occasionally, one of us would glance towards the tree, confirm that he was still sitting there and return to work without giving it another thought. We had all seen monkeys wandering around the campus before. They were practically residents of IIT Madras.

"Just keep an eye on your bags," someone casually reminded the team.

That was usually enough.

Monkeys stole food.

Sometimes water bottles.

Occasionally an unattended backpack.

None of us had ever heard of one showing any professional interest in event management.

The distribution continued.

Participants collected their bibs, asked the usual questions about reporting time and route markings, thanked the volunteers and left. Every few minutes another small group arrived, and the table slowly became lighter as more bibs found their owners.

Everything was running exactly according to plan.

Then, in the space of barely two seconds, it wasn't.

Out of nowhere, the monkey jumped.

There wasn't any warning.

No dramatic build-up.

One moment he was sitting quietly on the tree.

The next, he landed directly beside our distribution table.

For a second, everyone froze.

The monkey looked at us.

We looked at the monkey.

It felt as though both sides were silently waiting to see who would make the first move.

The monkey won.

With astonishing confidence, he grabbed a bundle of Kampus Run bibs lying near the edge of the table. In the same movement, he somehow managed to pick up a packet of safety pins as well before leaping back towards the tree.

For a brief moment, nobody reacted.

Our brains were still trying to process what had just happened.

Then someone shouted,

"Hey! The bibs!"

That single sentence was enough to send half the Sports Department running.

The monkey, meanwhile, looked completely unbothered.

He climbed onto a branch a few metres above us, settled down comfortably and examined his newly acquired collection with remarkable curiosity.

If anyone had walked past at that exact moment, they would have witnessed one of the most unusual scenes in Paradox.

A group of event organisers standing beneath a tree...

Negotiating with a monkey.

"Can somebody get them back?"

"How?"

"I don't know!"

"You ask him nicely."

That suggestion was met with immediate laughter.

Unfortunately, the monkey was not particularly interested in negotiations.

Every time someone stepped closer to the tree, he climbed a little higher.

Every time we stepped back, he looked down again, almost as though he was trying to understand why so many humans suddenly cared so deeply about a handful of colourful pieces of paper.

Aman folded his arms and looked up.

"I don't think he's giving them back."

"I've started accepting that," I replied.

Someone searched for a long stick.

Another volunteer looked around for campus security, though none of us were entirely sure what we expected them to do if they arrived.

"Excuse me, sir... could you please arrest this monkey?"

The image alone was enough to make everyone laugh again.

Meanwhile, our unexpected guest had reached the next stage of his investigation.

He carefully pulled one of the bibs out of the bundle, looked at it from both sides and then promptly lost interest.

Apparently, runner identification was less exciting than he had anticipated.

One by one, the bibs began drifting back towards the ground.

Not because the monkey was returning them.

Because he had decided they were completely useless.

We watched pieces of our carefully sorted distribution material float gently through the air like oversized confetti.

A few landed on the grass.

One became trapped in the branches of a nearby tree.

Another somehow landed on the roof of a parked vehicle.

The packet of safety pins met a similar fate.

Thankfully, it remained unopened.

At least one disaster had chosen not to happen that evening.

Within a few minutes, the monkey had grown completely bored with us.

Having successfully interrupted the Sports Department's carefully organised evening, he climbed across another branch, jumped onto a neighbouring tree and disappeared into the campus as casually as he had arrived.

No apology.

No explanation.

No indication that he had just defeated an entire organising team.

For a few seconds, complete silence settled over the group.

Then someone quietly said,

"I think..."

"...the monkey won."

Nobody argued.

Because he had.

It took us another fifteen or twenty minutes to gather everything again.

Fortunately, the monkey had shown absolutely no interest in keeping our bibs. His objective, it seemed, had simply been to satisfy his curiosity before moving on to whatever important monkey business awaited him elsewhere on campus.

We checked every bib once again.

The ones that had fallen onto the grass were cleaned and sorted back into their proper order. Volunteers counted the remaining packets of safety pins one more time, partly to ensure nothing was missing and partly because none of us trusted the evening anymore.

"If another monkey comes," someone said, "I'm resigning."

That immediately drew laughter from everyone.

"I don't think resignation is covered under the volunteer policy."

"It should be."

"Especially under wildlife management."

The jokes continued long after the work had returned to normal.

Every participant who arrived after that unknowingly received not only their bib but also the story of the monkey who had briefly attempted to register himself for Kampus Run.

By the time the final participant collected their bib, the sun had already disappeared below the trees.

The evening sky had taken on the deep blue colour that always seems to arrive surprisingly quickly in Chennai. The heat of the afternoon had finally begun to ease, and for the first time since morning, the campus felt slightly calmer.

Our work, however, wasn't over yet.

I carefully packed the remaining bibs, participant lists and other material before carrying everything back towards Krishna Hostel.

Room 367 welcomed us once again, looking exactly the way we had left it that morning.

Except now, the stacks of material seemed noticeably smaller.

Tomorrow, even those would disappear.

For a few minutes, Aman and I sat quietly on our beds without saying much.

Neither of us was particularly tired of walking.

We were tired of thinking.

Organising an event has a peculiar effect on your mind. Even while sitting completely still, your thoughts continue moving through checklists.

Did we pack the extra safety pins?

Who is reporting at the starting point?

Did everyone receive their duty map?

What if someone forgets to bring the barricade tape?

The questions never really stop.

A knock on the door interrupted my thoughts.

"Come in."

The door opened.

Standing outside were Mannu Yadav, the Secretary of Sundarbans House, Aditya Vaidhya, the Deputy Secretary of Sundarbans, and Rushabh Kapse, one of their Regional Coordinators from Mumbai.

"Bibs?" Mannu asked with a smile.

"Bibs," I replied.

They stepped inside, and within moments Room 367 had once again transformed from a hostel room into an informal meeting room.

I handed over the bibs for the Sundarbans participants while they carefully checked the names one by one.

The official work took barely a few minutes.

Naturally, the conversation lasted much longer.

None of us seemed eager to leave.

Tomorrow morning, Kampus Run would be the first opportunity for every house to earn significant points. That alone was enough to make strategy the favourite topic of the evening.

"How many runners do you think will actually report on time?" someone asked.

"Hopefully all of them."

Mannu smiled.

"You're an organiser. I'm asking realistically."

I laughed.

"Then... fewer than all of them."

That answer earned immediate agreement around the room.

The discussion shifted towards pacing, hydration, motivating participants and making sure nobody underestimated the Chennai weather.

Although everyone wanted their own house to perform well, there was something refreshing about those conversations.

Nobody was looking for unfair advantages.

Everyone simply wanted their runners to enjoy the event and finish safely.

Looking back, I think that was one of the qualities I admired most about Paradox.

The competition was real.

So was the respect.

After nearly two hours of conversation, planning and far too many predictions about the next morning, Mannu finally stood up.

"I think we'll let you sleep."

"I appreciate that," I replied.

He laughed.

"You'll need it."

He was absolutely right.

Because despite everything we had done that day...

The most important part of Kampus Run hadn't even begun yet.

After Mannu, Aditya and Rushabh left, the room fell quiet once again.

The silence felt almost unfamiliar.

Over the previous two days, Room 367 had rarely stayed empty for very long. Someone was always dropping in to collect event material, ask a question, continue a conversation or simply spend a few minutes sitting with everyone else before heading back to their own hostel.

Tonight was different.

For the first time all day, there was nothing left to distribute.

Nothing left to collect.

Nothing left to organise.

At least, nothing that could still be done tonight.

Aman looked across the room at the remaining pile of Kampus Run material.

"Everything ready?"

I followed his gaze.

The bibs that hadn't been collected had been arranged neatly.

The remaining safety pins sat beside them.

Volunteer lists were clipped together.

Maps showing everyone's reporting locations had already been printed.

The emergency contact sheet rested on top of the folder, exactly where we would need it first thing in the morning.

I nodded.

"As ready as we're ever going to be."

That was the honest answer.

Every organiser eventually reaches a point where preparation has to end.

No amount of checking can eliminate every uncertainty.

At some stage, you simply have to trust the work you've already done.

Tomorrow would tell us whether that trust had been justified.

We changed into more comfortable clothes before making one final trip to Ishtara.

Dinner was quieter than usual.

Not because people had run out of things to say, but because almost everyone looked tired.

The excitement of Day One had gradually given way to fatigue.

Volunteers from different departments occupied the same familiar tables, yet the conversations had slowed noticeably. Some people absent-mindedly scrolled through their phones while eating. Others stared at duty charts one final time before folding them away.

Across the room, I noticed organisers from several other departments doing exactly what we had been doing all evening.

Preparing.

Double-checking.

Thinking one step ahead.

It reminded me that every department had its own version of tomorrow.

For us, it was Kampus Run.

For someone else, it would be another venue, another competition or another responsibility that participants would probably never notice unless something went wrong.

That is the invisible beauty of student festivals.

Hundreds of organisers spend their evenings worrying so that thousands of participants can spend theirs enjoying.

After dinner, Aman and I returned to Krishna Hostel one final time.

The walk back felt unusually peaceful.

The roads were quieter than they had been on any previous night since our arrival. Most participants had wisely decided to sleep early, knowing that the coming days would demand far more energy than they imagined.

As we climbed the stairs towards Room 367, neither of us spoke.

There wasn't much left to discuss.

Every checklist had been reviewed.

Every volunteer knew their reporting location.

Every piece of equipment was where it was supposed to be.

The work was finished.

Now came the difficult part.

Waiting.

I set my alarm for **4:30 a.m.**

Aman glanced over.

"You're not taking any chances."

"Neither should you."

He laughed softly before setting his own alarm.

For a moment, we both looked at the room around us.

Three days earlier, it had been nothing more than a hostel room with two unfamiliar beds.

Now it had become the place where Sportify had planned, laughed, argued, solved problems and quietly prepared for one of the biggest weeks of our lives.

I switched off the lights.

The room disappeared into darkness.

Outside, Krishna Hostel had finally fallen asleep.

Tomorrow, before the sun rose over IIT Madras, hundreds of runners would gather at the starting line.

Months of planning would be tested over a few kilometres.

And somewhere among the crowd, two organisers would be hoping they hadn't forgotten anything.

Sleep arrived quickly that night.

Not because I wasn't thinking.

Because tomorrow would demand everything I had.

And for the first time since reaching Chennai, I felt ready to give it.

Chapter 15

Kampus Run

Some events become successful.

A few become traditions.

Very rarely, an event quietly becomes a part of you.

For me, Kampus Run was never just another event on the Paradox schedule.

It was personal.

The previous year, I had served as the Event Head for Kampus Run. I had watched an idea slowly turn into an experience, one volunteer meeting, one route inspection and one participant at a time. Somewhere during that journey, the event had stopped feeling like an assignment and started feeling like something I genuinely cared about.

That was also the year we introduced one of my favourite ideas.

Seed paper bibs.

It wasn't a revolutionary innovation.

It wasn't going to change the world.

It was simply a small thought.

If hundreds of people were going to run through one of the greenest campuses in the country, why should their bibs become waste once the finish line disappeared behind them?

Instead of ordinary paper, we chose seed paper.

After the event, participants could take those bibs home, plant them in a pot or a garden and watch them grow into something living.

The race would end.

The memory wouldn't.

When preparations for this year's Kampus Run began, there were dozens of things that changed.

Routes.

Volunteer structures.

Timelines.

Responsibilities.

One thing, however, remained exactly the same.

The seed paper bibs.

Nobody asked whether we should continue them.

Nobody suggested replacing them.

By then, they had quietly become part of Kampus Run itself.

I don't think I've ever been happier about a small tradition.

Because that is what leadership should look like.

Not creating something people remember because your name is attached to it.

Creating something that continues even after your name disappears.

As Deputy Secretary, my role this year was very different from the previous one.

Last year, I had focused on making the event happen.

This year, I carried something much heavier.

Responsibility.

Every decision, every delay and every mistake eventually found its way back to me.

That never frightened me.

It reminded me why I had accepted the role in the first place.

Still, there was one challenge that worried all of us long before participants even registered.

Sponsors.

For the first time since planning had begun, Kampus Run had none.

No hydration partner.

No energy partner.

Nothing.

It wasn't ideal.

The event would happen regardless.

But we knew it deserved more.

Then something completely unexpected happened.

When Aman and I reached campus on the 7th of June during early accommodation, we were sitting with Shreyansh Bhaiya, the Student Activities Intern, discussing preparations for the coming week. Like every conversation with him, one topic quickly became another, until somehow we found ourselves talking about Kampus Run.

"So," he asked casually, "who's sponsoring the run?"

I looked at Aman.

He looked back at me.

Neither of us answered immediately.

Finally, I smiled.

"Nobody."

Shreyansh Bhaiya leaned back in his chair.

"No sponsors?"

I shook my head.

"We couldn't finalise one."

For a few seconds, he didn't say anything.

Then he turned towards Gurkeerat from the Sponsorship Department, who happened to be sitting nearby.

"What about Red Bull?"

The room became quiet.

Red Bull.

None of us had seriously considered that possibility.

Not because we didn't want them.

Because companies like Red Bull always seemed slightly beyond the reach of student organisers.

Gurkeerat thought for a moment.

"It won't be easy."

"We're already very close to the event."

Shreyansh Bhaiya nodded.

"I know."

Then he smiled.

"But let's try."

That evening quietly changed the story of Kampus Run.

Phone calls began.

Messages were exchanged.

Approvals were chased.

Conversations continued well into the night.

Nobody knew whether anything would actually come out of those discussions.

We simply kept trying.

Then, sometime before the festival truly began...

The confirmation arrived.

Red Bull was in.

I still remember the feeling that spread through our team.

It wasn't excitement because a famous brand had joined us.

It was relief.

Someone had believed in the event as much as we did.

Looking back now, I can't help laughing.

Because none of us realised that Red Bull would eventually become part of one of the funniest stories of the entire week.

At that moment, however, there was only one thing on my mind.

Tomorrow morning.

Kampus Run.

The biggest event I had ever helped organise.

And absolutely no idea that before breakfast, monkeys, collapsing gates, delayed inaugurations, campus police and complete chaos would somehow become part of its story.

I don't remember sleeping very deeply that night.

Not because I was anxious.

Because my mind refused to stop working.

Every time I closed my eyes, another checklist appeared.

Had every volunteer received their reporting location?

Were the hydration stations ready?

Did we have enough spare bibs?

Were the route marshals carrying whistles?

Had the medical volunteers confirmed their arrival?

The questions repeated themselves until I eventually drifted off to sleep.

Then, almost immediately, the alarm rang.

4:30 a.m.

For the first time that week, I didn't press snooze.

There wasn't even a temptation.

I sat up before the alarm had finished ringing.

Room 367 was completely silent.

For a few seconds I simply looked around.

The room that had become Sportify Headquarters over the previous three days looked different again.

The remaining bibs rested neatly against one wall.

The emergency contact sheets were clipped together.

Volunteer duty charts were lying exactly where we had left them the previous night.

Only a handful of seed paper bibs remained.

Almost all the others had already found their runners.

Seeing those few remaining bibs made me unexpectedly emotional.

Thousands of messages.

Hundreds of meetings.

Months of planning.

Everything had somehow become this small pile of paper.

Aman was already awake.

He looked at me, smiled and asked the most predictable question imaginable.

"Ready?"

I looked around the room one last time.

"No."

He laughed.

"Good."

"I thought you were going to say yes."

"I don't think organisers are ever completely ready."

He nodded.

"I was hoping you'd say that."

That conversation lasted barely twenty seconds.

Yet I still remember it.

Because it was honest.

Nobody organising something of this scale ever feels completely prepared.

Eventually, there comes a point where preparation ends and trust begins.

Today was that day.

Outside, Krishna Hostel still belonged to the night.

Most windows remained dark.

The corridors echoed softly beneath our footsteps as we carried the final folders and remaining material downstairs.

A few organisers from other departments crossed our path, each carrying their own version of responsibility.

Some had cameras hanging from their shoulders.

Others pushed carts loaded with equipment.

Nobody spoke much.

Everyone knew exactly where they had to be.

The campus felt almost magical before sunrise.

Streetlights still glowed beneath enormous rain trees, creating long stretches of golden light across otherwise empty roads. A cool breeze moved quietly through the avenues, carrying with it the smell of damp

earth that somehow always seemed stronger during the earliest hours of the morning.

It was difficult to believe that in another hour these same roads would be filled with runners.

As we approached the starting venue, the silence slowly disappeared.

Instead of birds, we began hearing volunteers.

Someone shouted for barricades.

Another team unloaded cartons of water bottles.

Walkie-talkies crackled constantly with updates from different checkpoints.

Every few seconds another volunteer reported in.

"Hydration Point One ready."

"Route volunteers have reached."

"Medical team has reported."

"Registration desk is set."

Those messages were strangely comforting.

Months earlier, those locations had existed only as coloured markers inside a planning document.

Now real people were standing there.

Waiting.

Ready.

One by one, our own volunteers began arriving.

Some looked unbelievably fresh for half past five in the morning.

Others looked as though they had been dragged out of bed against their will.

"Good morning, sir."

"It'll become a good morning if you've had breakfast."

"We haven't."

"Then don't call it a good morning yet."

Laughter spread through the registration area.

It was a small moment.

But it helped.

Everyone was carrying pressure.

Sometimes all a team needs is a reason to smile before the work begins.

As more volunteers reported, I started walking across the venue one checkpoint at a time.

I had done this mentally hundreds of times over the previous months.

Now I wanted to do it once with my own eyes.

The registration desk.

Perfect.

Hydration counters.

Ready.

Red Bull setup.

Almost complete.

Route signage.

Exactly where it was supposed to be.

Finish line.

Waiting.

For the first time since waking up, I stopped walking.

The venue looked exactly the way we had imagined it months earlier.

Not similar.

Exactly.

I smiled.

Then my phone vibrated.

One message.

Three words.

"Ma'am running late."

I stared at the screen.

For a moment, I didn't fully understand what it meant.

Then another message arrived.

"Please wait."

Everything changed.

I read the message twice.

Ma'am running late.

For a few seconds, it didn't seem like a problem.

People run late all the time.

Five minutes.

Ten minutes.

It happens.

I put my phone back into my pocket and continued checking the venue, assuming everything would fall into place before the scheduled flag-off.

Participants, meanwhile, continued arriving.

Some came jogging towards the registration desk, apologising for cutting it close. Others had reached much earlier than necessary and were already stretching near the starting line. House members gathered together for photographs, adjusting their bibs while teasing teammates who were clearly not morning people.

The atmosphere was exactly what we had hoped for.

Excited.

Energetic.

Hopeful.

The Red Bull team had also arrived by then.

Their stall stood neatly beside the venue, cans arranged carefully on the counters, promotional material in place and volunteers preparing for the rush that would come after the race. Looking at that setup brought an unexpected smile to my face.

Just a few days earlier, none of it had existed.

Now one of the world's most recognisable brands was standing beside an event that had started as a student idea.

It felt surreal.

I glanced at my watch.

The scheduled reporting time had already passed.

Still no sign of Bharathi Ma'am.

Still no sign of Andrew Sir.

Another message arrived.

"Please wait."

I walked over to Aman.

"Any update?"

He shook his head.

"Same."

"We're waiting."

Neither of us liked that answer.

Waiting sounds simple until you're responsible for an event.

Every additional minute creates another question.

Participants begin asking when the race will start.

Volunteers wonder whether their schedules need changing.

The hydration team starts calculating whether the water laid out in the morning sun will remain cool.

Every delay quietly creates three new problems.

Around us, those questions had already begun.

"Sir, how much longer?"

"We'll start soon."

"Five minutes?"

"We're waiting for confirmation."

"Should we continue warming up?"

"Yes, don't stop."

The same conversation repeated itself over and over again.

Every answer sounded confident.

Inside, however, none of us knew exactly how long "soon" actually meant.

To keep everyone engaged, volunteers encouraged runners to continue stretching and moving around instead of standing still. Small groups began walking laps around the assembly area, while others chatted with friends from different houses.

Thankfully, the participants were remarkably patient.

Nobody complained.

Most people understood that certain formalities were beyond the organisers' control.

That patience made our job much easier.

The clock, however, showed no such kindness.

Thirty minutes passed.

Then forty-five.

The sunlight grew noticeably brighter.

The cool morning breeze that had welcomed us before sunrise slowly disappeared, replaced by the familiar warmth of a Chennai morning.

I found myself looking at my watch far more often than I wanted to.

Every organiser has experienced that feeling.

You know there is nothing you can personally change.

Yet you keep checking the time anyway.

As though the clock might suddenly decide to cooperate.

An hour had passed.

The excitement around the starting line had changed.

It hadn't disappeared.

It had simply become quieter.

People were still smiling.

Still talking.

Still waiting.

But everyone had started asking the same question with their eyes.

When do we begin?

Our organising team gathered briefly near the starting arch.

Phone calls continued.

Updates travelled from one person to another.

Possible options were discussed.

Every decision carried consequences.

If we waited longer, the heat would become another challenge for the runners.

If we started without our invited guests, we would disappoint people who had agreed to support the event.

There was no perfect answer.

Only the least imperfect one.

Then, after nearly an hour and a half of waiting, the decision was finally made.

We couldn't wait any longer.

The run had to begin.

I looked towards the starting line.

Hundreds of runners stood ready.

Months of preparation had led us to this exact moment.

I picked up the microphone, took a deep breath and said the words everyone had been waiting to hear.

"Let's begin with the 5-kilometre run."

The crowd erupted into applause.

None of us knew that the morning's biggest surprises were still waiting.

Because just a few seconds later...

The starting gate had a plan of its own.

The atmosphere changed almost instantly.

The waiting was over.

Volunteers quickly moved into their assigned positions, making sure the starting lane remained clear while participants gathered behind the inflatable arch. Conversations that had continued throughout the delay slowly disappeared, replaced by the familiar silence that always exists a few seconds before the beginning of a race.

Some runners bounced lightly on their feet.

Others adjusted their watches one final time.

A few closed their eyes for a brief moment, taking one last deep breath before the run.

I stood near the side of the starting line with the microphone still in my hand, looking across the crowd.

Months of planning.

Hundreds of registrations.

Dozens of volunteers.

Everything had led to this moment.

The countdown began.

"Five..."

The runners leaned forward.

"Four..."

Someone raised a phone to record the start.

"Three..."

The energy became almost tangible.

"Two..."

The volunteers stepped aside.

"One..."

The horn sounded.

For a fraction of a second, everything was perfect.

Then...

The starting arch collapsed.

Not slowly.

Not dramatically.

It simply folded sideways and came crashing down across one side of the starting lane.

For perhaps two seconds, nobody moved.

Our brains needed a moment to understand what had just happened.

Then every organiser reacted at once.

"Lift it!"

"Hold the side!"

"Move it!"

Volunteers rushed forward from every direction.

Participants instinctively stepped back to create space while four or five of us grabbed the metal supports and fabric as quickly as possible.

Fortunately, nobody had been hurt.

The runners remained remarkably calm, watching the entire scene unfold with expressions that seemed to ask the same question all of us were asking.

Did that really just happen?

The arch had barely been standing for a few seconds before deciding it had fulfilled its responsibilities for the day.

For us, however, there wasn't time to process the absurdity of the situation.

The race had to begin.

Within moments, volunteers lifted the structure away from the running lane and cleared the path completely.

Someone quickly checked that everything was safe.

Another volunteer gave a thumbs-up from further ahead on the route.

I looked towards the runners.

They looked back.

I smiled.

"Let's try that again."

This time, the laughter came.

Not loud.

Just enough to release the tension that had built up over the previous ninety minutes.

Sometimes, when everything starts going wrong, the only sensible response is to smile and continue.

The horn sounded once more.

The runners surged forward together, filling the road with colour, movement and energy.

Cheers erupted from volunteers standing along both sides of the route as the first wave disappeared beneath the enormous rain trees lining the campus roads.

For a few seconds, I simply stood there watching.

The race was finally underway.

An hour and a half later.

One collapsed starting arch.

And yet...

Kampus Run had begun.

I took a long breath that I hadn't realised I had been holding.

Beside me, Aman laughed quietly.

"I don't think that was in the SOP."

I shook my head.

"No."

"It definitely should be now."

For the first time that morning, I genuinely laughed.

The biggest challenge of the day was behind us.

Or at least...

That's what we believed.

None of us knew that the real chaos hadn't even started.

Because while the 5-kilometre runners were making their way through the campus, another race still remained.

The 3-kilometre run.

And this time, the obstacle waiting for us wasn't a falling gate.

It was the campus police.

The moment the last of the 5-kilometre runners disappeared around the bend, the atmosphere near the starting area changed once again.

There was no time to celebrate.

The 3-kilometre run was scheduled to begin shortly afterwards.

Unlike the longer race, this one attracted a much larger number of participants. Students who wanted to experience the atmosphere without committing to a longer distance slowly gathered near the starting line, adjusting their bibs, greeting friends and waiting for the announcement.

Around the same time, Kothai Ma'am arrived at the venue.

The moment we saw her walking towards us, a wave of relief spread through the organising team.

Throughout the previous week, she had been a constant source of encouragement for every department. Whether it was a meeting in ESB, a casual conversation while walking across campus or our unforgettable dinner at Nandhini Sweets, she always had the remarkable ability to make organisers feel that their work mattered.

Inviting her to flag off the 3-kilometre run felt right.

She greeted everyone with her usual warm smile, asked how the morning had gone and laughed when someone briefly mentioned the dramatic collapse of the starting arch.

"So the event has already become memorable?" she joked.

"Very memorable," I replied.

"Let's hope that's the last surprise."

I smiled.

"I hope so too."

I should have known better.

Just as we began gathering the participants near the starting line, a police vehicle stopped near the venue.

At first, none of us thought much of it.

Campus police vehicles were a common sight during Paradox. Officers regularly moved between venues to ensure everything remained safe and well coordinated.

This looked no different.

Then two officers stepped out and started walking directly towards us.

Their expressions immediately told me this wasn't a routine visit.

One of them looked towards the assembled runners before asking,

"Who's in charge here?"

For a brief second, everything around me seemed to become quieter.

"I am," I replied, stepping forward.

He nodded politely before asking the question I never expected to hear.

"Who gave permission to block this road at this time?"

I explained that Kampus Run was an officially approved Paradox event and that all necessary planning had been completed well in advance.

He listened carefully.

Then he shook his head.

"The timing is a problem."

I frowned.

"Problem?"

"This is the time when Kendriya Vidyalaya students start arriving."

He pointed towards the road stretching ahead of us.

"The school buses use this route."

Only then did the situation fully register.

The road we had prepared for weeks...

The route we had inspected repeatedly...

The course our volunteers had already secured...

Was now being questioned just minutes before the 3-kilometre flag-off.

The officer remained calm.

So did we.

But the meaning of his next sentence landed heavily on every organiser standing nearby.

"You cannot conduct the run like this."

For a moment, nobody spoke.

I looked towards Aman.

He looked back at me.

Neither of us needed words.

We both understood exactly what those six words meant.

If this couldn't be resolved...

The run might have to be cancelled.

Or postponed.

Either option would undo months of preparation in a matter of minutes.

Participants continued waiting behind the starting line, completely unaware of the conversation taking place only a short distance away.

They laughed.

They stretched.

They took photographs.

None of them realised that, at that very moment, the future of the event was hanging in the balance.

The organisers, meanwhile, had quietly entered crisis mode.

Phone calls began immediately.

One volunteer contacted the central organising team.

Another rushed to find senior coordinators.

Someone else tried locating officials who had been involved in approving the event schedule weeks earlier.

Everyone moved at once.

Nobody panicked.

Because panic solves nothing.

Communication does.

Standing there, watching volunteers run in different directions with phones pressed against their ears, I realised something important.

Leadership is rarely about having all the answers.

More often, it is about remaining calm while everyone else searches for them.

For the next several minutes, the starting line waited.

So did we.

Time seemed to slow down.

In reality, the conversation probably lasted only a few minutes.

Standing there beside the starting line, however, it felt much longer.

The police officers weren't being unreasonable.

They weren't shouting.

They weren't trying to stop Paradox.

They were doing exactly what they had been asked to do—ensure that the morning traffic for Kendriya Vidyalaya students wasn't disrupted. Within another few minutes, school buses would begin entering the campus, and the route we intended to use overlapped with one of the busiest stretches of road.

From their perspective, the concern was perfectly valid.

From ours, the timing couldn't have been worse.

"We've got hundreds of participants waiting," one of our volunteers explained respectfully.

"I understand," the officer replied.

"But I also have school children arriving."

Neither side was wrong.

That was what made the situation so difficult.

A few metres away, Kothai Ma'am had quietly understood that something serious was happening. She walked over, listened patiently as everyone explained the situation and immediately joined the discussion, trying to help find a practical solution instead of allowing the conversation to become an argument.

That was something I admired about her.

Whenever a problem appeared, her first instinct was never to ask "*Who made the mistake?*"

It was always,

"How do we solve this?"

Meanwhile, the rest of our organising team had scattered across the venue.

Phones continued ringing.

Someone was speaking to the central organising committee.

Another volunteer was trying to confirm the original permissions.

Every few seconds somebody returned with another small update.

"They're checking."

"One minute."

"Please wait."

Those three sentences became the soundtrack of the morning.

I glanced towards the runners again.

Most of them still had no idea what was happening.

Some were taking photographs beneath what remained of the starting arch after its earlier collapse. Others were joking with their housemates, completely unaware that the organisers standing barely twenty metres away were trying to save the event they had come to participate in.

Oddly enough, that made me feel calmer.

Participants shouldn't have to carry an organiser's stress.

If we were doing our jobs properly, they would remember the run.

Not the crisis behind it.

Another few minutes passed.

Then, finally, one of the senior organisers walked over after finishing a phone call.

He spoke briefly with the police officers.

The discussion continued quietly.

There were a few more questions.

A few more explanations.

Then, almost unnoticed, the tone of the conversation changed.

The officers looked at one another before turning back towards us.

"Finish it quickly."

For a second, I wasn't sure I had heard correctly.

"Excuse me?"

"You can conduct it."

"But make sure the route is cleared as soon as possible."

I don't think I have ever felt relief arrive so suddenly.

There was no celebration.

No cheering.

Just a collective exhale from every organiser standing nearby.

The run was still alive.

I immediately turned towards the volunteers.

"We're starting."

The message spread across the venue almost instantly.

Like electricity travelling through a wire.

"Starting!"

"We're starting!"

"Everyone to your positions!"

Volunteers who had spent the last fifteen minutes waiting uncertainly suddenly sprang back into action. Marshals hurried towards their checkpoints. The registration desk closed. Route coordinators confirmed their positions over the walkie-talkies.

The venue that had briefly frozen now came alive again.

Kothai Ma'am smiled as she stepped towards the starting line.

"I think everyone's ready now."

I looked at the runners.

Hundreds of faces looked back with excitement, completely unaware of how close the morning had come to taking a very different turn.

Maybe that was for the best.

Some stories belong to the organisers.

This was one of them.

The microphone was handed to Kothai Ma'am.

She wished every participant the very best, thanked the volunteers who had been awake since before sunrise and spoke briefly about why events like Kampus Run were far more than competitions.

They brought people together.

They encouraged healthy living.

They reminded us that a university campus isn't just made up of classrooms.

It is also built through moments shared outside them.

As she stepped aside, I looked once more at the starting line.

This time, there was no delay.

No uncertainty.

No police vehicle approaching in the distance.

Only runners.

Ready.

The countdown began once again.

And for the second time that morning..

Every heartbeat at the starting line seemed to move together.

"Five..."

The crowd answered together.

"Four..."

Some runners bent slightly forward, eyes fixed on the road stretching ahead.

"Three..."

A volunteer gave one final thumbs-up from the first checkpoint.

"Two..."

The campus seemed to pause.

"One..."

The air horn echoed across IIT Madras.

This time, nothing fell.

A wave of colour burst forward from the starting line as hundreds of runners crossed beneath the arch, their footsteps replacing the silence that had hung over the venue only moments earlier.

For a few seconds, nobody standing near the start moved.

We simply watched.

The road that had looked empty less than a minute ago was suddenly alive.

House jerseys disappeared beneath the canopy of rain trees while cheers from volunteers followed them down the route.

Kampus Run had finally begun.

Properly.

I looked at Aman.

He looked back at me.

Neither of us said anything.

We didn't need to.

The smile on his face said everything.

We had made it.

Not because the event was over.

Because it had finally started.

The moment the last group of runners disappeared around the first turn, the venue transformed once again.

The participants were running.

The organisers started running too.

Not the race.

The event.

"Water Station One, status?"

"Ready."

"Checkpoint Three?"

"All clear."

"Medical?"

"In position."

The walkie-talkies came alive.

Every few seconds another update arrived from somewhere along the route.

A runner needed assistance tying a loose bib.

Another participant had accidentally taken the wrong turning before a volunteer redirected them almost immediately.

One runner stopped briefly with cramps before continuing after a few minutes of rest.

Nothing extraordinary.

Exactly the kind of small situations every organiser quietly prepares for.

For the first time since dawn, I allowed myself to walk instead of rush.

The starting area looked almost peaceful now.

Empty barricades.

Discarded water bottle cartons.

A few volunteers smiling at one another after surviving one of the most stressful mornings of Paradox.

I walked towards the Red Bull stall.

Their team had already started preparing refreshment hampers for the finishers.

Rows of cans stood neatly arranged beside T-shirts, merchandise and winner prizes.

Looking at that setup reminded me of the conversation from four days earlier with Shreyansh Bhaiya and Gurkeerat.

If they hadn't pushed us to try one last time...

None of this would have been here.

Sometimes the biggest changes begin with someone simply saying,

"Let's at least ask."

That lesson stayed with me long after Paradox ended.

My walkie-talkie crackled again.

"The first runners are approaching."

Almost instantly, the quiet finish line came alive.

Volunteers hurried into position.

Medals were picked up.

Water bottles were opened.

The medical team moved a little closer to the finishing chute.

Everyone instinctively knew what came next.

Then...

The first runner appeared.

Far down the road, beyond the trees, a lone figure rounded the final bend.

Someone spotted him first.

"Runner coming!"

Every volunteer turned.

The cheers started immediately.

They grew louder with every step he took.

Soon another runner appeared behind him.

Then another.

Within minutes, the finish line was exactly what we had imagined months earlier.

Exhausted runners crossed the line with tired smiles, some collapsing dramatically onto the grass while others immediately searched for friends who had already finished.

Volunteers placed medals around tired necks.

Someone handed over water.

Another volunteer offered Red Bull.

Photographers moved continuously through the crowd, trying to capture expressions that lasted only a second before they disappeared behind laughter.

Those moments are impossible to recreate.

You either capture them then...

or you lose them forever.

Standing near the finish line, watching participants congratulate one another regardless of which house they belonged to, I realised something that had quietly become true.

Nobody cared who had organised the event.

Nobody cared who had attended the meetings.

Nobody cared about the spreadsheets, route inspections, sponsor calls or sleepless nights.

And that was exactly how it should be.

Good organising is invisible.

If participants spend the day creating memories instead of noticing your effort...

You have succeeded.

For the first time that morning, I stopped thinking like an organiser.

I simply stood there.

Watching hundreds of people smile.

Watching months of work turn into memories.

Watching Kampus Run become everything we had hoped it would be.

I thought the difficult part was finally over.

Then someone shouted from the Red Bull stall.

"Monkey!"

I closed my eyes for a second.

Not again.

For a moment, I genuinely hoped I had misheard.

"Monkey!"

Surely not.

Not after everything that had happened over the previous twenty-four hours.

I turned instinctively towards the Red Bull stall.

There he was.

Or perhaps it wasn't the same monkey.

At that point, none of us were interested in investigating family relations within the IIT Madras monkey community.

As far as we were concerned...

It was him again.

The stall, which had looked perfectly organised only moments earlier, suddenly became the centre of everyone's attention.

Volunteers rushed towards it.

The Red Bull team looked completely confused.

Participants stopped in the middle of conversations and turned to see what was happening.

Perched comfortably on the edge of the table sat our newest unofficial organising committee member.

He examined the merchandise with remarkable concentration.

Energy drinks.

Not interested.

Leaflets.

Definitely not.

Caps.

Apparently not fashionable enough.

Then his eyes settled on the neatly folded Red Bull T-shirts.

Before anybody could react, he grabbed one.

Not a packet.

Not a corner.

An entire T-shirt.

With complete confidence, he jumped onto the nearest railing before climbing effortlessly onto a tree overlooking the finish area.

For perhaps three seconds, absolute silence followed.

Then somebody laughed.

Another volunteer pointed towards the tree.

"Oh no..."

"He's back."

"I refuse to believe this."

The monkey, meanwhile, seemed extremely pleased with his latest acquisition.

He unfolded the T-shirt with the curiosity of someone trying to understand why humans become so emotionally attached to fabric.

The Red Bull representatives looked up in disbelief.

One of them turned towards me and asked the most reasonable question imaginable.

"Does this happen often?"

I couldn't help smiling.

"Not this often."

That answer was technically true.

Unfortunately, it was becoming less true by the minute.

Several volunteers gathered beneath the tree.

Nobody seriously expected the monkey to return the T-shirt.

Experience had already taught us that negotiations were unlikely to succeed.

Still, optimism is difficult to suppress.

Someone picked up a stick.

Another volunteer suggested distracting him with food.

A third immediately rejected the idea.

"Then he'll come back tomorrow."

"Fair point."

Above us, the monkey continued examining his prize.

He pulled at one sleeve.

Looked inside.

Turned it around.

For a brief second, it genuinely appeared as though he was considering wearing it.

The thought alone sent another wave of laughter through the crowd.

Eventually, disappointment appeared to set in.

The T-shirt, much like the seed paper bibs the previous evening, failed to meet his expectations.

With complete indifference, he released it.

The shirt floated slowly through the branches before landing several metres away.

Unfortunately...

Not in a condition anyone would confidently hand to one of the prize winners.

One winner, quite unfairly, missed out on receiving a Red Bull T-shirt that morning.

Somewhere deep inside IIT Madras, however, there was now a monkey who had enjoyed an exclusive preview of the merchandise collection.

Looking back today, I find that strangely appropriate.

Even our sponsors had received the authentic IIT Madras experience.

By then, the final runners had crossed the finish line.

The last medals had been distributed.

The Red Bull hampers had almost completely disappeared.

Volunteers slowly began dismantling barricades while route marshals reported back one by one, confirming that every participant had safely completed the course.

The event was finally over.

Not just officially.

Emotionally.

For the first time since waking up at half past four, I felt the weight leave my shoulders.

I looked across the venue one final time.

The starting arch that had collapsed.

The road where hundreds of runners had begun their morning.

The finish line that had welcomed every exhausted participant.

The Red Bull stall that had briefly become a monkey's shopping destination.

Every corner carried a story.

Every story carried a memory.

Months of planning had finally come to an end.

Kampus Run had survived delayed inaugurations, collapsing structures, unexpected negotiations with the campus police and two separate monkey incidents.

Somehow...

It had still become everything we wanted it to be.

And in that moment, I realised something.

Perfect events are forgotten.

The imperfect ones become stories.

The venue slowly returned to normal.

Barricades disappeared one by one.

Volunteers collected discarded water bottles from the roadside while route marshals reported back from their final checkpoints. The Red Bull team packed their remaining merchandise, photographers reviewed hundreds of

photographs on their cameras and participants slowly dispersed across the campus, medals hanging proudly around their necks.

For the first time that morning, there was nothing left to organise.

No announcements.

No walkie-talkie updates.

No last-minute phone calls.

Only relief.

The organising team gradually came together near the finish area, exchanging tired smiles that required no explanation.

Nobody asked whether the morning had been difficult.

We had all lived through it.

Someone finally broke the silence.

"I think we survived."

"I wasn't sure we would," another volunteer replied.

That earned a laugh from everyone.

Looking around, it was difficult to believe everything that had happened in just a few hours.

A one-and-a-half-hour delay.

A collapsed starting arch.

A discussion with the campus police that nearly brought the event to a halt.

A monkey stealing a Red Bull T-shirt.

And despite all of it...

Hundreds of runners had completed Kampus Run.

Safely.

Smiling.

That was all that mattered.

The final responsibility was packing whatever remained.

A few unopened cartons.

Some extra bibs.

Unused safety pins.

The remaining refreshments.

Everything slowly disappeared back into boxes, just as it had emerged before sunrise.

It felt strangely symbolic.

Months of planning had arrived inside cardboard cartons.

Now those same cartons quietly marked the end of the journey.

By then, hunger had finally begun winning its argument.

"I don't care where," Aman said.

"I just want breakfast."

"I second that."

"So do I."

Nobody had the energy to disagree.

We collected the last few things before beginning the familiar walk towards Ishtara.

The campus looked completely different now.

Only a few hours earlier, these roads had belonged to runners.

Now they belonged to students beginning an ordinary day.

Cyclists rode towards their departments.

Institute buses moved slowly through the campus.

Some participants proudly wore their medals while others walked with the unmistakable stiffness that follows an early morning run.

The festival had already moved on to its next story.

Halfway to the mess, I noticed one unopened box of glucose powder still in my hand.

We had carried it back from the venue without thinking.

"I'll drop this off later," I said.

Aman nodded.

"Good."

I had barely taken another three steps.

Something moved.

Fast.

Before I could even react, a familiar blur landed directly in front of me.

I stopped instinctively.

The monkey looked at the box.

Then at me.

Then back at the box.

For one ridiculous second, it genuinely felt as though we recognised each other.

"Oh no," Aman muttered.

"Not again."

The monkey reached forward, trying to snatch the box from my hands.

This time, however, I was ready.

After everything we had gone through over the previous twenty-four hours, I had learned one valuable lesson.

Never underestimate an IIT Madras monkey.

I instinctively pulled the box back while taking two hurried steps away.

The monkey lunged once more before deciding the effort wasn't worth it.

Within seconds, he disappeared onto the nearest wall, paused for a brief moment to look back at us and then vanished into the trees.

Neither of us spoke.

We simply looked at each other.

Then we burst out laughing.

Properly laughing.

The kind that comes only after the pressure has finally disappeared.

It almost felt as though the campus itself had decided to give Kampus Run one final joke before allowing us to leave.

By the time we reached Ishtara, exhaustion had completely replaced adrenaline.

Breakfast tasted better than any breakfast had a right to.

Not because of the food.

Because it carried relief.

Months of planning had ended.

Kampus Run was over.

As I looked around the table at the people who had spent the morning running, organising, solving problems and somehow laughing through all of it, one thought stayed with me.

Years later, I don't remember every finishing time.

I don't remember every announcement.

I don't even remember every winner.

But I remember the people.

I remember the volunteers who refused to give up.

I remember the runners who waited patiently through every delay.

I remember the team that somehow found a solution every single time a new problem appeared.

And, of course...

I remember the monkeys.

Because if there is one thing Kampus Run taught me, it is that leadership is rarely about executing a perfect plan.

It is about finding a reason to smile when the plan falls apart...

...and still making sure everyone reaches the finish line.

Chapter 16

The Day We Finally Sat Down

There is a strange silence that arrives after organising something you've been thinking about for months.

It isn't the silence of an empty room.

It is the silence inside your own head.

For weeks, every morning had begun with another checklist. Every evening had ended with another meeting. Even while eating, walking or trying to sleep, some part of my mind remained occupied by Kampus Run.

Would the registrations be completed on time?

Were the route maps finalised?

Had every volunteer received their responsibilities?

Was the sponsorship confirmed?

Did we have enough bibs?

The questions had become so familiar that I had almost forgotten what it felt like to think about nothing at all.

As Aman and I walked towards Ishtara after packing the last of the Kampus Run material, I realised those questions had finally disappeared.

For the first time in months...

There was no next task waiting for me.

Breakfast felt different that morning.

Not because the food had changed.

Because we had.

The dining hall was filled with volunteers from every department, but the energy was nothing like the previous few days. Nobody looked rushed anymore. Nobody was running from one venue to another with a phone pressed against their ear. People sat a little longer, laughed a little louder and finally allowed themselves to enjoy conversations that had been postponed all week.

At one table, organisers from the cultural events were discussing a performance that had gone unexpectedly well.

At another, someone was dramatically narrating how a football player had celebrated a goal before realising it had been ruled offside.

Every few minutes, another conversation somehow reached Kampus Run.

"So the gate actually fell?"

"Twice?"

"And a monkey stole a Red Bull T-shirt?"

I stopped correcting people after the third version of the story.

Every retelling made the monkey slightly more intelligent and the organisers slightly more helpless.

By lunchtime, I was convinced people would believe the monkey had registered for the run.

Looking back, I don't mind.

Good stories are supposed to grow.

After finishing breakfast, Aman and I walked back towards Krishna Hostel without saying very much.

Neither of us was exhausted in the usual sense.

We were simply empty.

The kind of empty that appears after carrying responsibility for far longer than your body was designed to.

Room 367 welcomed us one more time.

Only now, it looked like an ordinary hostel room again.

The stacks of bibs were gone.

The folders had disappeared.

The emergency contact sheets that had covered one side of the table for three days were finally packed away.

Sportify Headquarters had officially shut down.

I stood quietly for a few moments, looking around the room.

It is surprising how quickly a place can return to normal.

Only yesterday it had looked like the control room for one of the biggest events of Paradox.

Now it looked exactly the way it had on the day we arrived.

Just two beds.

Two bags.

Two students.

As though nothing extraordinary had ever happened there.

After a quick shower and a much-needed change of clothes, the exhaustion began fading.

Not completely.

Just enough to remind us that Paradox wasn't over yet.

Kampus Run had ended.

The festival hadn't.

My phone buzzed.

"IPL Auction. NAC 2."

I smiled.

Somewhere else on campus, another Sportify event was waiting.

The walk to NAC 2 felt very different from every walk we had taken over the previous week.

There was no hurry.

No one was calling us every five minutes asking where we were. No volunteer was waiting for instructions, and for once, I wasn't mentally running through a checklist while walking across the campus.

Kampus Run had finally allowed me to slow down.

NAC 2 had become the new home of IPL Auction Showdown after the unexpected venue changes earlier in the week. Originally, Day Two was supposed to continue in Raman Block, just as we had initially planned. Then, almost overnight, those plans changed. Day One had shifted to the Biotech Department, and Day Two eventually found its place in **NAC 2, Room 633**.

By then, we had almost accepted that venue changes were simply another unofficial Paradox tradition.

When we entered the classroom, the atmosphere was completely different from the previous day.

The panic had disappeared.

Yesterday had been about making the event work.

Today was simply about finishing it well.

House representatives were already seated around the room, discussing possible outcomes while the auction team prepared the final rounds. Some participants looked confident, convinced they had built the strongest squads. Others had calculators open on their phones, trying to estimate points before the results were officially announced.

Every house believed it had a chance.

That optimism is one of the beautiful things about competitions.

Right until the final announcement, everyone quietly believes the story might still end in their favour.

I spent most of the afternoon walking around the venue rather than standing in one place.

Sometimes a participant would stop me to ask about certificates.

Someone else wanted to know when the final standings would be displayed.

A volunteer asked for an extension cord.

Another wanted help checking a participant list.

None of the questions were urgent.

None of them felt overwhelming.

After the morning we had just survived, they almost felt comforting.

Around four o'clock, the auction finally reached its conclusion.

The room slowly settled into silence as everyone waited for the final rankings.

This was the moment every participant had been waiting for.

The website calculated points automatically based on the squads each house had assembled throughout the auction. It was a system we had tested multiple times before the event.

At least...

We believed we had.

The first set of results appeared on the screen.

Volunteers quickly compared them with their own calculations.

Something didn't look right.

At first, we assumed someone had made a simple calculation error.

"Check it once more."

Another volunteer opened the spreadsheet.

The numbers still didn't match.

"Refresh it."

We did.

The rankings changed.

That was when every organiser in the room looked at each other.

Not because we had found the problem.

Because we had realised there was one.

The website wasn't calculating points correctly.

A small technical glitch had quietly worked its way into the final standings.

The room, which had been moments away from celebrating its winners, suddenly returned to problem-solving mode.

Once again.

For the next few minutes, the classroom became strangely quiet.

Not because people had stopped talking.

Because everyone who understood what had happened had immediately started thinking.

The auction itself had gone well.

Participants had enjoyed it.

The bidding had been competitive, the atmosphere energetic and the event had run almost exactly the way we had imagined.

But none of that would matter if we announced the wrong winners.

One incorrect result could undo two days of good work.

The technical team gathered around a laptop while a few of us opened the backup spreadsheets we had maintained throughout the event.

"Check House Seven."

"The points don't match."

"What about House Three?"

"They're different too."

Someone refreshed the website again.

The rankings changed.

Another volunteer manually recalculated one team's points.

The website still disagreed.

That was enough.

We knew we couldn't trust the system anymore.

The participants, meanwhile, had started noticing that something wasn't quite right.

People sitting in the front rows looked towards us every few seconds, trying to understand why the results were taking longer than expected.

Some houses had already started celebrating after seeing the first rankings.

Others immediately questioned them.

"That can't be right."

"We should have more points."

"I think they've missed one player."

The room slowly filled with conversations.

Nobody was shouting.

Nobody was angry.

Everyone was simply waiting for an explanation.

For organisers, those are often the most uncomfortable moments.

Not when people complain.

When they quietly wait for you to tell them what happened.

We decided to verify everything manually.

House by house.

Player by player.

Every bonus point.

Every deduction.

Every calculation.

It took time.

A lot more time than we had expected.

At one point, we genuinely believed we had finally corrected everything.

The revised standings were displayed.

A few seconds later, another discrepancy appeared.

Someone had spotted a mistake.

Again.

The rankings had to come down.

The room sighed collectively.

I couldn't even blame them.

If I had been a participant, I would have been equally confused.

A third attempt followed.

By then, everyone in the organising team had stopped worrying about finishing on time.

There was only one priority left.

Getting it right.

I remember looking around the room.

The participants were still waiting.

Some looked disappointed.

Others looked impatient.

Most simply looked tired.

They deserved accurate results.

Not quick ones.

I walked towards the front of the classroom and picked up the microphone.

The room gradually became silent.

I took a deep breath before speaking.

"I want to apologise for the delay."

Nobody interrupted.

"We've identified an issue with the point calculation system. We've tried correcting it, but we're still finding inconsistencies. Rather than announcing incorrect winners, we've decided to verify every score once again."

I paused for a moment.

"I know you've all been waiting for the final results, but I don't think it's fair to declare champions unless we're completely certain."

The room remained quiet.

"So here's what we'll do."

"We'll verify every score tonight. The final standings, medals and certificates will all be announced tomorrow after we've confirmed everything."

For a second...

Nothing happened.

Then someone clapped.

Another participant joined.

Soon the entire room applauded.

Not because they were happy about waiting another day.

Because they knew we had chosen honesty over convenience.

Looking back, I still believe it was the right decision.

Sometimes leadership isn't about having the correct answer immediately.

Sometimes it is about having the courage to admit that you don't have it yet.

As participants slowly began leaving the classroom, another update reached us.

Five houses had violated the auction rules during the event.

After reviewing the incidents and discussing them with the organising team, the decision was taken to disqualify them from the competition.

It wasn't a decision anyone enjoyed making.

Disqualifying participants is never satisfying.

But fairness matters most when it is uncomfortable.

The classroom slowly emptied.

The auction was over.

The results...

Would have to wait one more day.

By the time the last participant left the classroom, the silence felt almost unfamiliar.

Only a few minutes earlier, the room had been filled with discussions about points, rankings and calculations.

Now it belonged to the organising team.

Laptops slowly closed.

Extension boards disappeared back into bags.

Someone rolled up the event banner while another volunteer carefully packed the auction paddles that had travelled from one classroom to another over the previous two days.

The event was over.

Not perfectly.

But honestly.

For me, that mattered more.

As everyone began preparing to leave, I asked the Sportify team to wait for a few more minutes.

"Don't disappear yet," I said.

"I have something."

Aman looked at me curiously.

"What now?"

"You'll see."

A few puzzled expressions appeared around the room, but everyone stayed.

I walked towards my backpack, unzipped the front compartment and carefully took out a neatly packed bundle.

Inside were certificates.

Not official Paradox certificates.

Not institute certificates.

Something much more personal.

Several weeks before Paradox had even begun, I had quietly designed appreciation certificates for the Sportify team.

Nobody had asked me to.

There wasn't any budget for them.

In fact, I had paid to print every single one from my own pocket.

Some people spend money on souvenirs.

I wanted to spend it on gratitude.

Over the past eight months, I had watched this team give up weekends, late nights and countless hours of personal time without ever expecting recognition in return.

Most of their work would never appear on a stage.

Their names wouldn't always be announced.

Participants would remember the events.

Very few would remember the volunteers who made those events possible.

I didn't want our own team to feel invisible.

I looked around the room before speaking.

"I know these aren't official."

A few people smiled.

"And I know you'll get your Paradox certificates later."

I paused for a moment.

"But those certificates are for participating."

"These..."

"...are from me."

The room became completely silent.

I picked up the first certificate and called out a name.

As the volunteer walked forward, everyone else applauded.

Then another name.

Another round of applause.

Then another.

One by one, every member of our team came forward.

There was no stage.

No chief guest.

No photographer asking people to look at the camera.

Just a group of students standing inside a classroom, thanking one another for surviving one unforgettable week together.

Strangely...

It felt more meaningful than many formal ceremonies I have attended.

When Anshul received his certificate, everyone cheered a little louder.

Someone shouted,

"VolleyVibes!"

He laughed and shook his head.

"Still not over."

"Tomorrow," someone reminded him.

"Tomorrow."

The room filled with laughter once again.

Aman eventually looked down at the certificate in his hands before looking back at me.

"You actually printed these."

I nodded.

"You idiot."

I laughed.

"I've been called worse."

"No..."

He smiled.

"I mean it in a good way."

For a moment, nobody spoke.

Everyone simply looked at the certificates they were holding.

The paper itself wasn't expensive.

The printing wasn't extraordinary.

But sometimes...

Value has very little to do with cost.

Before leaving, we clicked one final picture together inside the classroom.

No trophies.

No medals.

Just tired faces, slightly crumpled Paradox T-shirts and a group of friends holding pieces of paper that, to me, represented something much bigger than certificates.

They represented appreciation.

And appreciation, I had learned over the past year, is often the rarest reward in student leadership.

By the time we finished taking photographs and packing the remaining certificates, the sun had already begun setting over the campus.

For the first time in several days, none of us had a venue to rush towards.

No registrations.

No participant queries.

No equipment to collect.

No emergency meetings.

Paradox had finally given us an evening.

We gladly accepted it.

Aman stretched his arms as we stepped out of NAC 2.

"I don't know about you..."

"...but I desperately need to lie down for half an hour."

"I was about to say the same thing."

Nobody argued.

Even excitement has its limits.

The walk back to Krishna Hostel felt unusually quiet. The campus around us remained as lively as ever, with participants moving between venues, music drifting through the trees and announcements echoing from distant buildings. Yet inside our little group, the silence wasn't uncomfortable.

It was earned.

Back in Room 367, I dropped my bag beside the bed and simply sat there for a moment.

The room looked exactly the same.

But somehow it felt completely different.

Three days earlier, it had been the headquarters of the Sports Department.

Now it was just...

Home.

I don't think either Aman or I intended to sleep.

We only meant to rest for a little while.

As it turned out, exhaustion had other plans.

I don't even remember closing my eyes.

I only remember waking up to someone knocking on the door.

"DJ Night!"

For a second, I had absolutely no idea what time it was.

Aman looked just as confused.

"What?"

"DJ Night!"

The voice outside the room laughed.

"Hurry up!"

Reality returned almost instantly.

We had forgotten.

The Open Air Theatre.

DJ Lush.

One of the biggest celebrations of Paradox.

Within minutes, Room 367 transformed into controlled chaos.

Someone couldn't find their ID card.

Another person was looking for a phone charger that had somehow disappeared into a backpack.

I spent nearly five minutes searching for my wristband before realising it was still on my wrist.

Sleep has a remarkable ability to reduce intelligence.

Eventually, we gave up trying to look organised and simply started running.

Literally.

There is something wonderfully ridiculous about a group of exhausted organisers sprinting across one of India's most beautiful campuses because they don't want to miss the beginning of a DJ night.

Yet that was exactly what we were doing.

As we approached the Open Air Theatre, the music reached us long before the venue came into view.

Heavy bass echoed through the campus.

Coloured lights swept across the night sky.

From outside the gates alone, we could already hear hundreds of students singing louder than the speakers themselves.

The moment we entered, every bit of exhaustion disappeared.

The Open Air Theatre looked completely transformed.

The same place that had hosted formal events and performances now looked like an ocean of moving lights and people. House T-shirts mixed together until colours no longer mattered. Volunteers, participants, organisers and guests—all distinctions that had defined the previous week—simply disappeared.

For one night...

Everyone was just another student dancing with their friends.

DJ Lush had somehow managed to turn an entire amphitheatre into a single heartbeat.

Nobody cared who could dance.

Nobody cared who couldn't.

In fact, I don't think anyone was actually dancing correctly.

We were simply celebrating.

Celebrating surviving the week.

Celebrating finishing events that had consumed months of our lives.

Celebrating the fact that, despite every delay, every venue change, every technical glitch and every monkey determined to sabotage the Sports Department, we had somehow reached this moment together.

I looked around and recognised faces from almost every department.

People who had spent the previous week carrying walkie-talkies were now jumping to the music.

Volunteers who had looked permanently stressed during meetings were laughing without a single worry on their faces.

It was impossible not to smile.

Because this...

This was what Paradox looked like after the work was done.

The music continued for what felt like hours.

Every time we thought one song would finally slow the crowd down, another one began, somehow carrying even more energy than the last.

Time stopped making sense.

There were no schedules anymore.

No reporting times.

No volunteer duty charts.

No reminders on WhatsApp.

For one evening, Paradox had forgotten that it was a festival organised by students.

It simply became a celebration.

At one point, I looked around and realised something that made me smile.

Almost every person I had spent the previous eight months working with was somewhere in that crowd.

Some were dancing without the slightest concern for how ridiculous they looked.

Some stood in small circles singing lyrics they barely knew.

Others had quietly moved to the back, perfectly happy watching everyone else enjoy the night.

Nobody cared which department you belonged to.

Nobody cared who was a secretary, deputy secretary or volunteer.

Those titles had disappeared the moment the music started.

For a few hours...

We were simply twenty.

Eventually, the lights began dimming.

The music slowed.

People started walking towards the exits, still humming songs that would probably remain stuck in their heads for the next several days.

The Open Air Theatre slowly emptied.

Nobody seemed eager to return to their hostels.

Perhaps everyone understood that moments like this don't come very often.

As Aman and I stepped outside, we noticed familiar faces waiting near the pathway.

Methelesh.

Sarthak.

Jahanvi.

Pratishtha.

Almost instinctively, we all began walking together.

Nobody suggested a destination.

Nobody made a plan.

Our feet simply carried us towards Raman Block, the building that had somehow become one of our unofficial meeting places throughout the week.

The campus had grown surprisingly quiet.

Only the occasional shuttle bus passed by, while small groups of students continued drifting back towards their hostels after the celebrations.

The warm Chennai night had finally become pleasant, and for the first time in days, there was absolutely nowhere any of us needed to be.

We found a spot on the pavement outside Raman Block and sat down.

No chairs.

No tables.

Just six tired students sitting on the ground after one of the busiest weeks of their lives.

Someone opened a bottle of water and passed it around.

Another person stretched their legs before announcing dramatically,

"I don't think I can walk tomorrow."

"You'll walk," Aman replied.

"You don't have a choice."

"I'm willing to negotiate."

"We're not."

The conversation wandered in every possible direction.

We spoke about Kampus Run.

About the IPL Auction.

About the monkey that had somehow become more famous than half the Sports Department.

Someone joked that the monkey deserved an appreciation certificate as well.

"I think he attended more Sports events than some volunteers."

That earned immediate laughter.

From there, the discussion moved somewhere completely different.

Favourite school memories.

Embarrassing stories.

People we had met during Paradox.

Who had slept the least.

Who had somehow survived only on coffee.

Nobody followed any particular topic for more than a few minutes.

The conversation simply flowed wherever it wanted.

Looking back now, I can't tell you everything we talked about.

I don't remember every joke.

I don't remember every story.

But I remember exactly how it felt.

There was an incredible comfort in sitting with people who had watched you at your best and your worst over the previous week.

These were the same people who had seen me stressed before Kampus Run, laughing after the monkey incidents, worried during the police discussion and relieved once everything was finally over.

There was nothing left to prove.

No impression left to make.

Just friendship.

Real, uncomplicated friendship.

The kind that only forms when people build something difficult together.

Time slipped away unnoticed.

One conversation became another.

One laugh became the next.

Every now and then, complete silence settled over the group for a few seconds.

Not the awkward kind.

The comfortable kind.

The kind that only exists between people who no longer feel the need to fill every quiet moment with words.

I looked around at everyone sitting there beneath the yellow streetlights.

None of us realised it then.

But this...

This ordinary conversation on the pavement outside Raman Block...

Would become one of the memories I would miss the most.

Not because anything extraordinary happened.

Because nothing needed to.

By the time we finally looked at our phones, it was already past one in the morning.

"How long have we been sitting here?" Sarthak asked.

Methelesh checked the time and laughed.

"Around two hours."

"Seriously?"

Nobody had noticed.

That was probably the best part of the night.

For two hours, none of us had looked at a schedule.

Nobody had spoken about registrations.

Nobody had asked whether a volunteer had reported.

Nobody had worried about logistics.

We had simply existed.

Eventually, Aman stood up first, stretching as though every muscle in his body had finally remembered the previous week's workload.

"I think my legs have officially resigned."

"They resigned after Kampus Run," I replied.

"They're just serving their notice period now."

Everyone laughed.

One by one, we got to our feet.

The campus had almost completely fallen asleep.

The roads that had carried thousands of participants during the day now belonged to nothing more than the occasional cycle, a distant security vehicle and the soft sound of leaves moving in the night breeze.

As we walked back towards our hostels, the group slowly became smaller.

One by one, people peeled away towards their own accommodation.

"Good night."

"See you tomorrow."

"Don't be late."

"I'm never late."

"That's a lie."

Another round of laughter followed before everyone continued in different directions.

Soon it was just Aman and me again.

Something about that felt familiar.

Almost every day of Paradox had begun with the two of us walking somewhere together.

Almost every night had ended the same way.

We walked through Krishna Hostel without saying much.

The hostel, which had felt so busy since the day we arrived, was finally quiet.

A few room lights were still on.

Someone was probably finishing an assignment.

Someone else was packing for the journey home.

Life outside Paradox had quietly continued all along.

Room 367 greeted us one more time.

I placed my phone on the table, dropped onto the bed and stared at the ceiling for a few moments.

Neither of us had the energy for another conversation.

Tomorrow wasn't going to be any easier.

It was Finals Day.

Badminton.

Volleyball.

Echo // Prometheus.

More winners.

More photographs.

More memories waiting to happen.

Before switching off the lights, I set one more alarm.

5:00 a.m.

Aman looked over.

"Seriously?"

I smiled.

"I've got a plan."

"What plan?"

"You'll find out tomorrow morning."

He shook his head.

"I don't trust that smile."

"You shouldn't."

The lights went off.

Within seconds, Room 367 disappeared into darkness once again.

Outside, IIT Madras slept peacefully after another unforgettable day of Paradox.

Inside, six hours of sleep waited before another story began.

The next morning..

Instead of walking towards another venue...

We walked towards the sea.

Chapter 17

Sunrise Before the Finals

There are photographs that become special because they capture an extraordinary moment.

Then there are photographs that become special because they capture an ordinary one.

If you open my gallery from Paradox today, you'll find thousands of pictures.

Football grounds.

Volleyball courts.

Packed auditoriums.

Medal ceremonies.

Crowds.

Stages.

Events.

But one of my favourite memories from the entire week wasn't taken at any venue.

It wasn't taken during an event.

It wasn't even taken inside IIT Madras.

It was taken on a quiet beach, just after sunrise.

Ironically...

That peaceful morning almost never happened.

The previous night had stretched far longer than it should have.

After Kampus Run, IPL Auction, our internal certificate ceremony and DJ Night, the six of us had spent nearly two hours sitting outside Raman Block talking about absolutely everything and absolutely nothing.

By the time Aman and I finally returned to Room 367, it was already well past one in the morning.

Any sensible person would have cancelled the beach plan.

Fortunately...

None of us were behaving very sensibly that week.

The alarm rang at five.

I stared at the ceiling for a few seconds, genuinely wondering whether the person who had decided on a sunrise beach trip after one of the busiest days of Paradox deserved to be questioned.

Then I remembered.

That person was me.

Aman looked over from the other bed.

"We're actually doing this?"

"We said we would."

"We were half asleep when we said that."

"So?"

"So we clearly weren't thinking."

I laughed as I got out of bed.

"Exactly."

Some opportunities don't become memorable because they're convenient.

They become memorable because you choose them despite the inconvenience.

Twenty minutes later, we stepped out of Krishna Hostel.

The campus was almost unrecognisable.

For the first time since Paradox had begun, there were no announcements.

No music.

No volunteers carrying barricades.

No crowds moving from one venue to another.

Only the soft sound of birds greeting another morning and the occasional cyclist passing through roads that had been overflowing with people just a few hours earlier.

One by one, everyone arrived.

Methelesh.

Pratishtha.

Nikhil.

Aman stood beside me, still trying to convince himself that waking up had been the right decision.

"You still have time to go back," I told him.

"And miss this?"

He looked around at the almost empty campus before smiling.

"No chance."

We booked an auto from outside the Velachery Gate.

The driver didn't seem surprised when five sleepy students climbed in and said only one word.

"Thiruvannamiyur."

The streets of Chennai were only just beginning to wake up.

Milk vans moved quietly through residential colonies.

Tea stalls had started serving their first customers.

Newspaper vendors cycled past us with impossible stacks of newspapers balanced on the back of their bicycles.

Nobody inside the auto said much.

There was no need to.

Some mornings are too peaceful for conversation.

Fifteen minutes later, the smell of the sea reached us before we could see it.

The auto stopped.

The driver smiled.

"Beach."

We climbed out.

And for the first time in nearly a week...

There wasn't a single responsibility waiting for us.

Only the sunrise.

The beach was quieter than I had imagined.

Coming from Paradox, where every hour seemed to be filled with announcements, cheering, music and people rushing from one venue to another, the silence almost felt unfamiliar.

A few fishermen stood near their boats, preparing for another ordinary day.

Morning walkers moved along the shoreline at their own pace, occasionally stopping to watch the waves before continuing again.

A handful of runners passed by us, earphones plugged in, completely unaware that five exhausted student organisers had arrived carrying an entire festival inside their heads.

For the first few minutes, none of us spoke.

We simply walked.

The waves rolled towards us with the same rhythm they had followed long before Paradox existed and long after it would end.

There was something strangely comforting about that.

The sea had no idea that one of the biggest student festivals of the year was taking place barely a few kilometres away.

It didn't care.

And somehow, that was beautiful.

Aman was the first one to remove his shoes.

"I'm not ruining my shoes today."

Without saying another word, he walked barefoot towards the water.

The rest of us followed almost immediately.

The wet sand felt surprisingly cold beneath our feet, making all of us instinctively step back for a moment before laughing at ourselves.

"So much confidence," Pratishta said, laughing.

"I wasn't expecting the water to be this cold," Aman defended himself.

"You literally came to a beach."

"I know."

"And you're surprised there's water?"

"I said cold water."

Nobody let him win that argument.

Within minutes, the teasing had begun.

Nikhil tried skipping a shell across the water.

It sank almost immediately.

"I think that was one skip," Methesh said.

"It was a practice throw."

"You've been saying that since yesterday."

The laughter echoed across the shoreline.

Nobody was trying to be funny.

That was the best part.

The conversations had reached the point where simply being together was enough.

Pratishta bent down to collect a shell that looked slightly different from the others.

"I'll take this one."

"For what?" I asked.

"As a memory."

I smiled.

"Good choice."

Months later, when someone asked me what I had brought back from Chennai, my answer wasn't going to be medals, certificates or photographs.

It was moments like these.

Small.

Ordinary.

Almost invisible while they were happening.

The horizon slowly began changing colour.

The deep blue sky gave way to soft shades of orange, pink and gold, each minute looking slightly different from the one before.

Almost instinctively, all five of us stopped walking.

Nobody suggested it.

Nobody said a word.

We simply stood there, looking towards the sea.

The sun appeared slowly above the horizon, as though it had no intention of being rushed.

Golden light spread across the water, turning the waves into thousands of tiny reflections that seemed to dance every time the sea moved.

For a brief moment, everything around us became quiet.

Not because the beach had fallen silent.

Because all of us had.

Phones remained inside our pockets.

Nobody asked for a photograph.

Nobody tried to record a video.

Some memories deserve to be experienced before they are captured.

After almost a minute, Aman finally broke the silence.

"Worth waking up at five?"

I didn't take my eyes off the horizon.

"Absolutely."

No one disagreed.

Looking back today, I honestly don't remember how long we stayed there after sunrise.

Maybe twenty minutes.

Maybe forty.

Time had quietly stopped mattering.

For one peaceful morning, before the finals, before another long day of responsibilities, before the phones started ringing again...

We weren't organisers.

We weren't secretaries.

We weren't coordinators.

We were just five friends watching the sun rise over the Bay of Bengal, completely unaware that within the next hour we would once again be running across IIT Madras, solving problems we hadn't even imagined yet.

Eventually, reality reminded us that the day wasn't going to wait forever.

It was Pratishta who looked at her phone first.

"Guys..."

She turned the screen towards us.

"We should probably head back."

Nobody argued.

Not because we wanted to leave.

Because we all knew she was right.

The finals were waiting.

Somewhere inside IIT Madras, volunteers had already begun setting up venues, participants were probably finishing breakfast, and organisers across different departments had once again started another long day.

Paradox had quietly resumed without us.

We took a few photographs before leaving.

Not the perfectly posed kind.

Just five friends standing near the sea with sleepy faces, messy hair and smiles that no camera could completely capture.

Someone suggested taking "one last picture."

That somehow became another five.

"Can we go now?" Aman laughed.

"You people will still be taking pictures after sunset."

"They're called memories," Pratishta replied.

"They're called delays."

"I'll take both."

Nobody had a better answer than that.

The auto ride back to campus felt very different from the ride that had brought us there.

Earlier, everyone had been half asleep.

Now the conversation refused to stop.

The topic changed every few minutes.

Someone started discussing who would probably win the badminton finals.

Another person confidently predicted the volleyball champions.

At one point, the conversation somehow returned to Kampus Run.

"I still can't believe the gate actually fell," Nikhil said.

"I still can't believe the monkey came back."

"Twice."

"Three times," Aman corrected.

"The glucose powder."

Everyone laughed again.

"I genuinely think he recognised you."

"I hope not."

"If he did, he'll probably attend next year's Kampus Run as well."

"At this point, he deserves an organising committee T-shirt."

"And an ID card."

"Don't encourage him."

By the time we reached Velachery Gate, Chennai had completely woken up.

The roads that had looked almost empty an hour earlier were now filled with office-goers, buses, cyclists and students making their way through another ordinary morning.

It felt strange.

Only a little while ago, the five of us had stood beside the sea feeling as though the world had paused.

Now the world was moving again.

We entered the campus a little after seven-thirty.

The transformation was immediate.

Announcements echoed through the institute once more.

House jerseys appeared everywhere.

Volunteers hurried across the roads carrying banners, certificates and sports equipment.

Participants gathered outside different venues discussing strategies for the finals.

The peaceful beach already felt like another lifetime.

Back at Krishna Hostel, everyone drifted towards their own rooms.

"I'll be ready in twenty minutes," Aman announced confidently.

I looked at him.

"The same twenty minutes you promised yesterday?"

"These are different twenty minutes."

"They're never different."

He laughed as we unlocked Room 367.

The room was unusually tidy now.

The mountains of event material had disappeared.

No cartons.

No bibs.

No volunteer lists covering the tables.

It finally looked like the hostel room we had originally checked into.

I took a quick shower, changed into fresh clothes and lay down on the bed for what I hoped would be five minutes of rest.

Outside, I could hear students walking through the hostel corridors, excitedly talking about the finals scheduled throughout the day.

My eyes had barely begun to close when my phone started vibrating.

The name flashing on the screen was enough for me to sit upright immediately.

Shreyansh Bhaiya.

I answered almost instantly.

"Hello, Bhaiya."

"Krish, where are you?"

"In the hostel."

"Can you come to ICSR?"

His voice sounded calm.

But I had spent enough time working with him to recognise that calm usually meant something needed immediate attention.

"Everything okay?"

"There is an issue with Echo // Prometheus."

I glanced across the room at Aman.

He looked at me for a second and immediately understood.

"No rest?" he asked.

I smiled.

"Looks like not."

Within ten minutes, we were walking out of Krishna Hostel once again.

The beach was over.

The organiser inside us had officially returned.

Chapter 18

Echo // Prometheus

Some of the hardest problems during Paradox had nothing to do with events.

They had everything to do with communication.

When my phone rang that morning, I expected another technical issue.

Maybe a venue change.

Maybe equipment.

Maybe another volunteer had gone missing.

Instead, it turned out to be something much simpler.

And much more complicated.

As Aman and I walked towards the ICSR building, neither of us knew exactly what had happened.

All Shreyansh Bhaiya had said over the phone was,

"Come to my office."

"We need to sort something out."

That was enough.

The ICSR building had a completely different atmosphere from the rest of the campus.

Outside, Paradox was in full swing.

Participants hurried between venues.

Announcements echoed across the institute.

House jerseys filled every pathway.

Inside...

It felt strangely calm.

For the first time during the festival, I stepped into what everyone casually called the **CODE Office**.

Until then, I had heard people referring to it countless times.

"Go to the CODE Office."

"Shreyansh Bhaiya is in the CODE Office."

"The meeting is in CODE."

That morning was the first time I actually walked inside.

It wasn't grand.

It wasn't intimidating.

It looked exactly the way an organising office should look in the middle of India's biggest student festival.

Open laptops covered almost every table.

Whiteboards were filled with hastily written notes.

Charging cables crossed each other like railway tracks.

Half-finished cups of coffee occupied whatever empty space remained.

It looked messy.

It looked busy.

Most importantly...

It looked alive.

Shreyansh Bhaiya was standing outside his cabin when we reached.

He smiled.

"Come."

"We'll talk inside."

Devishi was already there.

We exchanged a quick smile before everyone took a seat.

For a few seconds, nobody spoke.

Then Bhaiya looked towards me.

"Tell me."

"What happened?"

I took a deep breath.

"It isn't about volunteers."

He nodded.

"I know."

"It's about communication."

That was the real issue.

Echo // Prometheus had required on-ground volunteers for execution.

There was nothing wrong with that.

In fact, Sports had always been happy to support other departments whenever possible.

The problem was...

Nobody from their team had contacted us before the festival.

No planning meetings.

No discussions.

No volunteer requirement sheet.

No sharing of responsibilities.

No coordination.

Nothing.

Then, almost at the last moment, we suddenly received a request asking for nearly fifteen volunteers.

Fifteen.

During Paradox.

When every department was already struggling to manage its own responsibilities.

I looked towards Bhaiya.

"If they had spoken to us even a week earlier..."

"...we would've planned accordingly."

"We would've identified people."

"We would've adjusted duties."

"But you can't ask for fifteen trained volunteers after the festival has already started."

Aman nodded beside me.

"That's exactly the problem."

"It isn't about helping."

"It's about asking at the right time."

The room became quiet.

Nobody interrupted.

Nobody became defensive.

Devishi listened carefully before speaking for the first time.

"I understand why you're upset."

She paused for a moment.

"And honestly..."

"...you're right."

That wasn't the response I expected.

She explained how their team had been overwhelmed with technical preparations, backend development and constant changes leading up to the event.

In trying to solve those problems...

They had neglected communication with the departments that would eventually help execute the event.

It wasn't intentional.

But it had happened.

Listening to her, I realised something important.

Every department had spent the previous month fighting its own fires.

Sometimes, while solving your own problems...

You accidentally create one for someone else.

Shreyansh Bhaiya leaned back in his chair.

"This..."

He said, looking at all of us,

"...is exactly why I wanted everyone in the same room."

"No WhatsApp."

"No phone calls."

"No misunderstandings."

"Just people talking."

And somehow...

The solution became surprisingly simple.

For the next few minutes, nobody spoke.

Not because the discussion had ended.

Because everyone was thinking.

It would have been very easy to start blaming one another.

Sports could have complained about the last-minute request.

Echo // Prometheus could have argued that they genuinely needed the volunteers.

Neither argument would have solved the problem standing in front of us.

Shreyansh Bhaiya looked around the room before finally speaking.

"Let's forget what should have happened."

He paused for a moment.

"Tell me what needs to happen now."

That one sentence completely changed the direction of the conversation.

We stopped talking about mistakes.

We started talking about solutions.

Devishi opened her notebook and quickly listed every responsibility that still required volunteers.

Not all fifteen positions actually needed technical knowledge.

Some only required people to manage participant queues.

Some were needed for registrations.

A few were simply required to guide participants between different checkpoints.

Immediately, the problem looked much smaller than it had sounded over the phone.

"These six positions don't need technical experience," I pointed out.

She nodded.

"Yes."

"And these four?"

"Just basic coordination."

I looked towards Aman.

"We can probably manage that."

He nodded almost immediately.

"Sports can help with the on-ground coordination."

The room slowly became lighter.

One by one, responsibilities were redistributed.

Some volunteers would come from Sports.

A few would be arranged by the central organising team.

Echo // Prometheus would continue handling everything that actually required technical expertise.

Within fifteen minutes, what had sounded like an impossible requirement had quietly become a manageable plan.

That meeting taught me something I still carry with me today.

Most disagreements don't begin because people refuse to help.

They begin because people stop talking early enough.

Communication delayed is often communication denied.

As we finished discussing the volunteer plan, the conversation naturally shifted away from work.

Shreyansh Bhaiya leaned back in his chair and smiled.

"So..."

"Kampus Run."

I laughed.

"I knew we'd eventually come back to that."

"I've only heard half the stories."

"Oh, you've heard the short version."

Aman immediately joined in.

"No, Bhaiya."

"You haven't heard about the monkey."

"The monkey?"

"There were multiple monkey incidents."

For the next several minutes, the office stopped feeling like a meeting room.

It became a group of exhausted organisers exchanging stories from the previous week.

The collapsing start gate.

The one-and-a-half-hour delay.

The campus police.

The monkey stealing bibs.

The monkey stealing the Red Bull T-shirt.

The monkey trying to steal my glucose powder while we were walking to breakfast.

By the end of the story, even Devishi was laughing.

"I think the monkey deserves a certificate."

"No," I replied.

"He deserves an organising committee badge."

"And probably a volunteer T-shirt."

"Please don't give him ideas."

The room burst into laughter once again.

Looking back now, I think that's one of the things I loved most about Paradox.

A meeting that began with frustration...

Ended with everyone laughing together.

No ego.

No bitterness.

Just people trying to make one festival a little better than it had been the previous day.

As Aman and I stood up to leave, Shreyansh Bhaiya looked at us.

"Thanks."

I shook my head.

"No, Bhaiya."

"Thank you for calling us here."

"If this conversation had happened over WhatsApp..."

I didn't even finish the sentence.

He smiled.

"I know."

Some conversations need a table.

Not a phone screen.

We stepped out of the CODE Office into the bright Chennai afternoon.

The issue had been resolved.

Echo // Prometheus had its volunteers.

Sports had clarity.

And somewhere in the middle of all that, I had visited the CODE Office for the very first time—a place I had heard about throughout the festival, but one that, from that day onward, would always remind me of something much bigger than technology.

It reminded me that the strongest teams aren't the ones that never disagree.

They're the ones that know how to sit in the same room...

...and leave it together.

By the time Aman and I stepped out of the CODE Office, the tension we had carried into the meeting had disappeared.

The issue had been resolved.

Echo // Prometheus had its volunteers.

Sports knew exactly what was expected from us.

And perhaps more importantly, every misunderstanding had been replaced with a conversation.

It felt good.

Not because we had won an argument.

Because nobody had.

Everyone had simply found a way forward.

As we walked across the campus, my phone buzzed once again.

"The football finals are over."

I stopped walking for a second.

"Already?"

Aman looked at his phone as well before nodding.

"We completely missed them."

For a brief moment, I felt disappointed.

Football had always been one of the flagship sporting events of Paradox, and I had genuinely wanted to be there for the finals. But organising a festival teaches you a lesson very quickly.

You cannot be everywhere.

Every department believes its event is the centre of the festival.

And for those organising it...

They're right.

Sometimes helping another department quietly becomes more important than watching your own event conclude.

We smiled, accepted that football had slipped away from us, and continued walking.

"There is still badminton," Aman said.

"There is."

The Sitara Indoor Sports Complex was already buzzing by the time we reached.

Unlike the open venues we had spent most of the week running around, the indoor stadium had its own atmosphere.

Every smash echoed across the hall.

Every rally was followed by applause from both sides of the court.

The audience sat surprisingly close to the action, making every point feel even more intense.

The finals were already underway.

We quietly found a place near the side of the court, trying not to disturb anyone.

For the first few minutes, neither of us spoke.

We simply watched.

One thing I have always loved about badminton is how quickly momentum changes.

A player can be completely in control one moment and suddenly find themselves chasing the game the next.

Every point mattered.

Every mistake mattered.

The finalists played with an intensity that reminded everyone watching why they had reached this stage in the first place.

The crowd appreciated good badminton, regardless of which house was winning.

A perfectly placed drop shot earned applause.

A remarkable defensive rally earned even louder cheers.

For a little while, I forgot I was an organiser.

I became just another spectator.

And honestly...

That felt wonderful.

After spending days worrying about registrations, schedules, volunteers and logistics, simply sitting in the stands and enjoying a match felt almost like a luxury.

When the final point was won, the entire hall erupted into applause.

The winners celebrated with their teammates while the runners-up, despite their disappointment, walked over to congratulate them.

That moment stayed with me.

Competition had ended.

Respect hadn't.

Soon afterwards, we moved towards the court for the medal and certificate distribution ceremony.

The smiles looked different now.

Not the nervous smiles from before a match.

The satisfied smiles that only appear after giving everything you have.

One by one, medals found their rightful owners.

Certificates changed hands.

Photographs were taken.

House flags appeared once again for victory pictures that would soon fill WhatsApp groups and Instagram stories.

Standing there, handing over certificates, I realised something.

Participants usually remember the medal they received.

Organisers remember the smile that came with it.

Those smiles were the real reward.

As the ceremony concluded, the hall slowly began emptying.

Players packed their racquets.

Spectators moved towards the exits.

Volunteers folded banners and collected the remaining certificates.

Another event had quietly become another memory.

Only then did my stomach remind me that we had completely skipped breakfast.

Aman looked at me and laughed.

"I don't think sunrise counts as a meal."

I shook my head.

"I was just thinking the same thing."

"So..."

"Brunch?"

"Definitely brunch."

We stepped out of the indoor stadium and started walking towards Ishtara once again, completely unaware that the next stop on our day would be one of the events closest to Sportify's heart.

VolleyVibes.

An event led by someone who had shared Room 367's chaos from the very beginning.

Anshul's moment had finally arrived.

Chapter 19

VolleyVibes

Every event has a face.

For Kampus Run, people often saw me.

For IPL Auction, they saw Aman standing with a microphone, controlling the room while dozens of participants argued over player prices.

But when people thought about volleyball during Paradox...

They thought about Anshul.

By the time Aman and I finished brunch and started walking towards the volleyball courts, I wasn't walking towards just another Sports event.

I was walking towards months of someone else's hard work.

Ever since we had reached IIT Madras, Room 367 had been occupied by more than just two roommates.

It had become a planning room.

A storage room.

A meeting room.

A place where volunteers walked in without knocking because everyone somehow knew that someone from Sportify would always be there.

In the middle of all that chaos, I had watched Anshul prepare for VolleyVibes.

Sometimes he sat quietly on his bed with his laptop open, updating fixtures for what felt like the hundredth time.

Sometimes he disappeared for hours to inspect the courts before returning with another small improvement that nobody else would probably notice.

Other times, he simply lay on the bed staring at the ceiling, mentally replaying every possible situation that could go wrong once the tournament started.

I recognised that expression immediately.

Every organiser wears it.

It is the look of someone carrying an event long before the event actually begins.

Now...

It was finally his day.

As we approached the volleyball courts, the atmosphere felt completely different from every other venue we had visited during Paradox.

The first thing we noticed wasn't the court.

It was the sound.

Volleyball has a rhythm unlike any other sport.

The sharp echo of the ball.

The referee's whistle.

Players calling for the next set.

Spectators applauding after a perfectly timed block.

Every rally created its own soundtrack.

Long before we could see the match, we could hear it.

The courts were already surrounded by students from different houses.

Some stood behind the barricades.

Others sat wherever they could find space, turning staircases, railings and even patches of grass into temporary seating areas.

Everyone wanted a better view.

Finals always attract a different kind of audience.

Even people who hadn't followed the tournament from the beginning somehow found their way there.

Because everyone likes watching a championship.

I spotted Anshul almost immediately.

He wasn't watching the match.

He was doing exactly what every good event head does.

Watching everything except the match.

One moment he was speaking with the referees.

The next, he was checking whether the score table had been updated correctly.

A volunteer stopped him with a question.

Someone else called him from the opposite side of the court.

He barely remained in the same place for more than thirty seconds.

I smiled.

For the first time since arriving in Chennai...

I wasn't seeing my roommate.

I was seeing an Event Head.

And he looked completely different.

I didn't walk up to him immediately.

There was no point.

He was busy.

One volunteer asked him about the next fixture.

Another needed clarification regarding substitutions.

The referees wanted to confirm the order of the medal ceremony once the finals concluded.

Every few seconds, somebody called his name.

"Anshull!"

"Bhai..."

"One minute..."

"Can you come here?"

He somehow managed to answer every question without looking rushed.

Watching him reminded me of something I had realised during my own events.

Participants only see the court.

An Event Head sees everything around it.

The scoreboard.

The officials.

The volunteers.

The spectators.

The equipment.

The schedule.

The next match.

The weather.

The photography team.

The prize table.

Everything.

That invisible responsibility is what separates watching an event from organising one.

After a few minutes, he finally noticed us standing near the side of the court.

He walked over, wiping the sweat from his forehead.

"You both finally made it."

"We weren't going to miss your finals," I replied.

He smiled.

"You've already missed half the tournament."

"I know."

"Kampus Run happened."

He laughed.

"I'll allow that excuse."

Before we could continue, another volunteer called him again.

"Anshul!"

He looked at us helplessly.

"Duty calls."

I smiled.

"Go."

"We'll catch up later."

Within seconds, he was back on the other side of the court, once again solving another small problem before anyone else even noticed it existed.

Aman looked at me and quietly said,

"You know..."

"...he's doing well."

I nodded.

"He really is."

There is a different kind of happiness that comes from watching someone you have worked with grow into their responsibility.

Not because the event is successful.

Because you know how much work nobody else has seen.

The whistle blew.

The finals began.

Unlike the friendly matches we had seen throughout the week, every point now carried weight.

The crowd reacted to everything.

A powerful spike drew loud cheers from one side.

An incredible save immediately earned applause from the other.

Every rally seemed longer than the previous one, with both teams refusing to let the ball touch the ground.

Nobody wanted to give away even a single point.

The energy around the court became contagious.

Students who had arrived merely to watch soon found themselves cheering after every remarkable rally, regardless of which house they belonged to.

That is one of the beautiful things about good sport.

For a little while...

Skill becomes more important than allegiance.

Standing beside the court, I realised how different every Sportify event felt.

Kampus Run had been spread across kilometres of roads.

IPL Auction had unfolded inside classrooms through strategy and discussion.

VolleyVibes was compact.

Fast.

Loud.

Every second demanded attention.

Every rally could change the match.

Every point brought someone one step closer to becoming Paradox champions.

The final set was exactly what everyone had hoped for.

Neither team was willing to surrender.

The scoreboard remained close enough that every single point drew louder cheers than the last.

Players dived fearlessly to keep impossible balls alive.

Blocks at the net were celebrated almost as passionately as winning points themselves.

Even the substitutes standing outside the court looked more nervous than the players.

Around me, the spectators had completely forgotten the Chennai heat.

Nobody was looking at their phones anymore.

Nobody was thinking about the next event.

For those few minutes...

The entire world existed inside one volleyball court.

And that is probably the highest compliment any sporting event can receive.

The final whistle echoed across the court.

For a brief second, everything stood still.

Then the celebrations began.

One side erupted into cheers, players running towards one another before disappearing into a pile of hugs and laughter. On the other side of the net, disappointment was evident, but so was respect. One by one, the runners-up walked across the court to congratulate the champions before shaking hands with every player they had just competed against.

Moments like that have always been my favourite part of sport.

Not the victory.

The respect that follows it.

As volunteers quickly prepared the court for the presentation ceremony, another event was waiting to begin.

It wasn't part of the official tournament.

There were no points to be won.

No championship trophy at stake.

Yet, in many ways, it became one of the most meaningful moments of the entire volleyball competition.

For the first time in Sportify's history, we were conducting a **Women Only 5v5 Volleyball Exhibition Match**.

Looking back, it may have seemed like a small addition to the schedule.

To us...

It meant much more.

Over the past year, Sportify had constantly tried to create spaces where more women felt encouraged to participate in sports. From launching **Sportify HER** to introducing women-centric initiatives throughout the year, the objective had always remained the same.

Participation.

Not just attendance.

Seeing the women walk onto the court that afternoon brought a quiet sense of satisfaction.

There were no expectations.

Only enthusiasm.

Some players looked slightly nervous before the first serve.

Others couldn't stop smiling.

The spectators welcomed them with exactly the same energy they had shown during the finals.

Perhaps even more.

Because everyone understood they were witnessing something new.

The whistle blew.

The match began.

The atmosphere immediately became lighter than the finals.

There was healthy competition, of course, but there was also laughter after long rallies, teammates cheering every successful point regardless of the score and spectators applauding good volleyball from both sides.

Nobody seemed particularly concerned about who would eventually win.

Simply seeing the match take place already felt like a victory.

Standing beside the court, I found myself thinking back to the day Sportify HER had first been discussed.

At the time, it had been nothing more than an idea.

A belief that if we intentionally created opportunities, participation would naturally follow.

Now...

That belief was standing in front of us.

Not inside a proposal.

Not inside a presentation.

On the volleyball court itself.

Sometimes progress isn't measured by numbers.

Sometimes it is measured by moments.

This was one of those moments.

When the exhibition match concluded, the applause lasted noticeably longer than usual.

The smiles on the players' faces made it clear that they had enjoyed every minute of it.

For me, that mattered more than the final score ever could.

Soon afterwards, we gathered everyone near the podium for the closing ceremony.

Medals were placed around the necks of the finalists.

Certificates were handed over one after another.

Photographers called out instructions as every house wanted one final team photograph before leaving the venue.

As I handed certificates to the winners, I couldn't help looking towards Anshul.

The rush had finally ended.

For the first time that afternoon, he wasn't answering someone's question.

He wasn't checking a fixture.

He wasn't solving another logistical issue.

He was simply standing near the court, watching the ceremony unfold.

There was an unmistakable smile on his face.

Not the smile of someone relieved that an event had ended.

The smile of someone quietly realising that months of work had finally become memories.

I walked over to him once everything was finished.

"So..."

He looked at me.

"So."

"How does it feel?"

He looked around the now-emptying volleyball court before answering.

"Worth every sleepless night."

I smiled.

"I know exactly what you mean."

He laughed.

"I knew you would."

We didn't need to say anything else.

Some conversations can only happen between people who have carried an event on their shoulders.

And sometimes...

A single sentence is enough to understand everything the other person means.

By the time the last group photograph had been taken, the volleyball courts slowly began returning to normal.

The crowd that had filled every corner of the venue only a few minutes earlier gradually disappeared.

Some participants walked away with medals hanging proudly around their necks.

Others carried only memories.

Either way...

Everyone left with a story.

The volunteers, meanwhile, had already returned to work.

Banners came down.

Score sheets were collected.

The referee's table was dismantled.

Plastic chairs that had been scattered around the venue slowly found their way back into neat stacks.

It is remarkable how quickly an event disappears once it ends.

A venue that had felt alive only moments ago suddenly becomes just another empty court.

I stood there for a while, watching the cleanup.

Perhaps because I knew exactly what Anshul was feeling.

When you've spent months preparing for an event, its ending always arrives unexpectedly.

Not because you don't know it's coming.

Because you've been too busy making sure it happens.

Aman walked over beside me.

"So..."

"Another one done."

I nodded.

"Another one done."

For a few seconds, neither of us spoke.

We simply watched volunteers finishing the last few tasks while players slowly disappeared towards their hostels.

Sportify had organised multiple events during Paradox.

Each one had looked completely different.

Each one had demanded something different from the team.

But standing there that afternoon, I realised they all shared one thing.

Every event eventually ended.

The memories never did.

Before leaving, I walked over to Anshul one last time.

He was finally sitting down.

Probably for the first time all afternoon.

"Congratulations, Event Head."

He laughed.

"It still feels strange hearing that."

"It shouldn't."

"You earned it."

He looked around the court one more time before smiling.

"I'll probably miss this place."

"You will."

"And next year..."

"...you'll be standing where we are."

Watching someone else organise it.

He smiled.

"I hope they make it even better."

That answer made me happier than he probably realised.

Because that is how traditions survive.

Not when people try to protect them from change.

When they genuinely hope the next team improves them.

We shook hands before finally leaving the courts behind.

As Aman and I walked away, I turned back one last time.

The nets were already coming down.

The spectators had disappeared.

The applause had faded.

If someone had walked past at that moment, they would never have guessed that a Paradox final had just taken place there.

That's the strange thing about student festivals.

Months of preparation.

Hours of execution.

And then...

Within minutes...

The campus quietly resets itself, ready for another story.

Little did we know, ours wasn't over yet.

Instead of returning to our hostel rooms, our feet once again carried us towards the place that had somehow become the unofficial headquarters of Paradox.

Electronic Sciences Block.

Because if there was one building that had witnessed almost every chapter of our week...

It was waiting for us once again.

Chapter 20

Vasanta

If someone had asked me that evening what I would remember most from the day, my answer would've been simple.

The volleyball finals.

The women's exhibition match.

Watching another Sportify event come to life.

The dinner that followed wouldn't even have crossed my mind.

Funny how memory works.

Sometimes the moments you think are ordinary quietly become the ones that change everything.

By the time we left the volleyball courts, the Sports Department had finally exhaled.

Every major event was over.

For nearly a week, our lives had revolved around fixtures, registrations, volunteer duties, venue inspections, score sheets and endless phone calls.

Now...

There was nothing left to rush towards.

For the first time during Paradox, we were simply walking.

Without a destination that mattered.

Almost instinctively, Aman and I found ourselves heading towards the Electronic Sciences Block.

By then, ESB no longer felt like an academic building.

It felt like home.

Room 127 had somehow become the place where every organiser eventually ended up.

If someone disappeared during Paradox, there was a very good chance they would eventually be found sitting somewhere inside ESB.

Sometimes with a laptop.

Sometimes asleep.

Sometimes solving a crisis.

Sometimes doing absolutely nothing.

That evening...

It was the fourth one.

People drifted in and out of the room throughout the evening.

Someone sat down for five minutes before leaving again.

Someone else arrived only to realise the person they were looking for had already gone somewhere else.

A few volunteers quietly scrolled through photographs from the past week, laughing every time an unflattering candid picture appeared.

"Delete that."

"No."

"Please."

"Absolutely not."

Some traditions exist in every organising team.

This is one of them.

The room felt lighter than it had all week.

Nobody was discussing emergency plans anymore.

Nobody was checking registration numbers.

Nobody seemed worried about tomorrow.

Tomorrow could wait.

Today had finally slowed down.

For a while, we simply sat there.

Talking.

Laughing.

Interrupting one another.

Retelling stories that had somehow already become legends despite happening only a day earlier.

Apparently, the monkey from Kampus Run had already achieved celebrity status far beyond the Sports Department.

By now, even people who had never attended the event knew about him.

I was beginning to suspect he deserved his own appreciation certificate.

Someone eventually looked at the clock.

"Dinner?"

That was all it took.

Within minutes, everyone was collecting bags, calling people who had disappeared somewhere else on campus and trying to figure out where we should eat.

Like every large group of students...

Choosing the restaurant took longer than actually reaching it.

Suggestions came one after another.

Each one was immediately rejected by somebody else.

Finally, someone said,

"Vasanta?"

This time...

Nobody objected.

So we started walking.

At that moment, it felt like nothing more than another group dinner.

If I could go back and tell my twenty-year-old self one thing as we left ESB that evening...

It wouldn't be about the restaurant.

It would simply be this.

"Walk a little slower."

Because none of us knew that this ordinary walk would quietly become one of the most important memories of the entire week.

The roads inside IIT Madras looked different that evening.

Perhaps they hadn't changed at all.

Perhaps we had.

For nearly a week, those same roads had witnessed volunteers carrying barricades, participants running towards venues, organisers answering

phone calls before the previous one had even ended and students trying to be in three different places at the same time.

Now, as we walked towards the Velachery Gate, the pace felt slower.

Nobody seemed to be in a hurry anymore.

The conversations wandered effortlessly from one topic to another.

Someone was already making plans for the next Paradox.

Someone else insisted they wouldn't volunteer ever again.

Nobody believed them.

"I've heard that every year," someone laughed.

"And every year, you're back."

"Because we never learn."

"No."

"Because we love this."

For a few seconds, nobody argued.

Because deep down...

We all knew that was the real answer.

Paradox exhausted you.

Then somehow convinced you to return the following year.

That was its magic.

There were nearly a dozen of us walking together now.

Some walked ahead in small groups.

Others slowed down without any particular reason.

The formation kept changing every few minutes, just like every large group of friends does.

One conversation ended.

Another began.

Someone called another person's name from the back.

Laughter travelled up and down the road.

It felt wonderfully ordinary.

As we approached the main road near the Velachery Gate, a bus appeared in the distance.

Almost instinctively, a few of us looked at one another.

"If we catch that..."

"...we won't have to walk the rest of the way."

Without thinking too much, four of us started running.

Not because we wanted to leave everyone behind.

Quite the opposite.

The idea was simple.

If we could stop the bus, the entire group could board it together instead of walking another kilometre or more.

It seemed like the obvious thing to do.

We ran.

The bus didn't stop.

By the time we reached it, it had already begun moving again.

We stood there for a second, slightly out of breath, watching it disappear down the road.

"So much for that plan," someone laughed.

"Worth trying."

I turned around almost immediately.

The rest of the group was still walking towards us.

We waited.

There was no point going anywhere until everyone had caught up.

As the others came closer, the conversations simply picked up from where they had left off before the short sprint.

Nobody seemed annoyed.

Nobody seemed upset.

At least...

That's what I believed.

Looking back now, memory has a strange way of changing ordinary moments.

At the time, nothing about that walk felt important.

It was simply a group of tired students trying to reach dinner after another long day.

If someone had asked me then whether anything unusual had happened...

I would've said no.

And I would've genuinely believed it.

Because sometimes...

The beginning of a misunderstanding looks exactly like an ordinary evening.

The walk continued as though nothing had happened.

By the time we reached the gate, the group had naturally spread out once again.

Some people were walking together in pairs, still discussing the volleyball finals.

Others had drifted behind, stopping every now and then whenever another familiar face crossed their path.

I looked around.

Deepak was already standing near the gate.

Saurabh was beside him.

Ansh had reached there as well.

We all knew where we were going.

Or at least...

I thought we did.

One question immediately crossed my mind.

"How long is the waiting time going to be?"

Vasanta was one of those places that became crowded very quickly, especially during Paradox. Large groups usually meant long waits, and I didn't particularly enjoy the idea of fifteen people standing outside a restaurant waiting for someone to finally call our number.

Ansh was standing beside me.

"Aman and the others are coming," he said.

I nodded.

"Can you just call him once?"

He looked at me.

"I'll go ahead and collect the waiting token."

"If they're still behind, just share the live location with everyone. They'll come directly."

"Done."

It felt like the most practical decision.

Someone had to collect the token anyway.

If I could save fifteen or twenty minutes of waiting, why wouldn't I?

Without thinking twice, a few of us started walking towards the restaurant.

I remember looking back once.

The rest of the group was still somewhere behind us.

I wasn't worried.

Not even for a second.

In my mind, everyone already knew the plan.

They knew the destination.

They had each other's numbers.

We would all meet there in a few minutes.

Simple.

Looking back today...

I realise leadership often creates a dangerous habit.

You begin filling the gaps in your head.

"They'll understand."

"Someone must have told them."

"They probably already know."

Sometimes...

Nobody does.

At the restaurant, the first thing I asked was exactly what I had expected to ask.

"How much is the waiting time?"

The person at the counter looked up briefly before checking the list.

"There'll be a wait."

I immediately took the token.

"Perfect," I thought.

"By the time everyone reaches here, our turn should almost be here."

At that moment...

I genuinely believed I was saving everyone's time.

I had absolutely no idea that the decision I had just made would later become one of the biggest regrets of my entire Paradox.

But that realization...

Would come much later.

That evening, I was simply waiting for my friends to arrive.

And I couldn't wait for all of us to have dinner together after surviving the busiest week of our lives.

A few minutes later, the rest of the group began arriving.

One by one, familiar faces walked towards the entrance.

Some looked tired.

Some were still laughing about something that had happened on the way.

Someone complained about how far we had walked.

Another immediately reminded them that we had tried stopping the bus.

The conversation continued as naturally as it had throughout the evening.

I walked towards everyone.

"Token mil gaya."

"Perfect," someone replied.

"How long?"

"Not too much."

"Good."

We stood outside the restaurant while waiting for our number to be called.

The atmosphere still felt completely normal.

People were checking photographs from the volleyball finals.

Someone had already started teasing Anshul about finally surviving his event.

Another person insisted that Kampus Run was still the most chaotic event of Paradox.

"I still think the monkey planned everything," someone joked.

"I think he was secretly part of the organising committee," another replied.

That immediately started another round of laughter.

Even today, when I think about that evening, I don't remember tension.

I remember conversations.

I remember laughter.

I remember waiting outside a restaurant after one of the busiest weeks of our lives.

Nothing felt unusual.

Our table was finally ready.

The staff asked us to move inside.

Finding seats for such a large group took a few minutes, and naturally everyone settled wherever space was available.

Nobody had assigned seats.

Nobody had planned who would sit with whom.

People simply occupied the nearest empty chair.

I found a seat and looked around the table.

The restaurant was noisy.

Orders were being shouted across the room.

Plates moved constantly between tables.

The waiters somehow remembered everyone's orders despite what looked like complete chaos.

It felt exactly like every large group dinner after a college event.

Menus passed from one person to another.

"You're ordering that?"

"Obviously."

"Share with me."

"No chance."

"At least let me taste it."

"We'll negotiate later."

Somewhere between deciding what to order and arguing over who was paying for what, I noticed Aman.

He wasn't speaking as much as he usually did.

At first, I didn't think much of it.

Everyone was exhausted.

The previous week had taken its toll on all of us.

I assumed he was simply tired.

Still...

Something felt slightly different.

Not enough for me to understand.

Just enough for me to notice.

When the conversation around us became louder, I quietly leaned towards him.

"You okay?"

He looked at me for a second.

"Yeah."

It was a simple answer.

Short.

Almost too short.

I nodded.

I didn't ask another question.

Looking back today...

I wish I had.

Because sometimes the difference between "*Yeab.*" and "*Yeab, I'm fine.*" is much greater than it sounds.

At that moment, however, I believed him.

I thought he was simply tired.

I had no idea that the evening was beginning to mean very different things to different people sitting around the same table.

None of us realised it then.

But sometimes...

The hardest conversations begin with a single word.

"Yeah."

Dinner arrived gradually.

One dish after another found its way to the table until there was barely any space left.

Someone immediately reached across to steal a piece from another plate.

"Excuse me?"

"I was just checking the quality."

"You didn't even ask."

"If I ask, you'll say no."

"Correct."

"Exactly."

Another round of laughter followed.

The conversations split into smaller groups.

People sitting next to each other spoke about completely different things.

One side of the table discussed the volleyball finals.

Another had somehow reached childhood stories.

Someone was already talking about travelling back home after Paradox.

Others were making impossible plans about meeting again "very soon," despite knowing that everyone lived in different corners of the country.

It felt...

Normal.

That is probably the word I remember most from that night.

Normal.

After everything the Sports Department had gone through during the previous week, sitting together over dinner felt like the perfect ending.

At one point, I looked around the table.

Almost every face there had become a part of my everyday life over the past eight months.

Some had joined Sportify much later than others.

Some I had known long before Paradox.

But somewhere along the journey, designations had quietly disappeared.

Secretary.

Deputy Secretary.

Department Head.

Coordinator.

Volunteer.

Those words still existed on paper.

Not at the table.

At that table, I wasn't sitting with a committee.

I was sitting with people I genuinely considered family.

Perhaps that is why I failed to notice what now seems so obvious.

I was looking at everyone through the comfort of familiarity.

I assumed that if something was wrong...

Someone would simply tell me.

I had always believed that was what families did.

If I had hurt someone, they would pull me aside.

Scold me.

Argue with me.

Tell me I was wrong.

Then we'd sort it out.

That belief felt so natural to me that I never questioned it.

Looking back...

Maybe I should have.

Dinner eventually came to an end.

The plates disappeared.

The conversations slowed.

People gradually stood up, stretched after another long day and began walking back towards the campus.

As we stepped outside Vasanta, I remember thinking only one thing.

"What a week."

I had no idea that while I was remembering the events...

Some people were already remembering the evening.

The walk back to IIT Madras felt quieter than the walk towards the restaurant.

Perhaps everyone was simply tired.

Perhaps we had finally run out of stories.

Or perhaps...

There are silences whose meanings we only understand much later.

That night, I slept believing Paradox had given me one more beautiful memory.

Months later...

I realised it had also given me one of my biggest lessons.

I just wasn't ready to learn it yet.

PART IV

***THE LAST FEW DAYS
OF FOREVER***

Nobody tells you when you're living the last ordinary day.

One morning, the conversations become memories.

And by the time you realise it... everyone has already gone home.

Chapter 21

Temples

There is something strangely beautiful about waking up before sunrise when you no longer have an event to organise.

For nearly a week, every alarm had meant responsibility.

Football trials.

Kampus Run.

Finals.

Volunteer briefings.

Every morning began with somewhere to be and something to solve.

The alarm that rang on **13 June** was different.

There was no venue waiting.

No registrations.

No emergency phone calls.

For the first time since arriving at IIT Madras, we were waking up simply because we wanted to.

It was barely six in the morning when my phone buzzed.

Shreyansh Bhaiya.

"Ready?"

"Almost."

"Hurry."

"We're leaving."

That was all the information I received.

A few minutes later, I met him outside.

Saksham was already there, somehow looking far more awake than any person had the right to be at six in the morning.

"So..."

I asked.

"Where are we going?"

Shreyansh Bhaiya smiled.

"Temple tour."

I laughed.

"That's the entire plan?"

"That's the entire plan."

Somehow...

That was enough.

No itinerary.

No detailed schedule.

No Google Maps shared in the WhatsApp group.

Just three people stepping out of IIT Madras early in the morning because someone had suggested visiting a few temples before Paradox came to an end.

Looking back...

Some of the best memories from that week began exactly like that.

With absolutely no planning.

The roads outside the campus were still unusually quiet.

Chennai was only beginning to wake up.

Tea stalls had started serving their first customers.

Flower vendors were arranging fresh garlands outside small shops.

The air carried the familiar smell of jasmine mixed with freshly brewed filter coffee.

It felt like a completely different city from the one we had experienced throughout Paradox.

For the past week, Chennai had only existed as the place surrounding IIT Madras.

That morning..

For the first time, we actually saw Chennai itself.

The first temple welcomed us with complete silence.

No crowds.

No queues.

Only the soft ringing of temple bells somewhere inside and the quiet footsteps of a handful of devotees beginning their day.

We removed our shoes and walked in without saying much.

Perhaps places like that naturally ask for silence.

Or perhaps...

After everything Paradox had been, silence simply felt comforting.

The temple was beautiful in the quietest possible way.

No grand announcements.

No crowds waiting outside.

No volunteers trying to manage queues.

Only the gentle sound of bells, the fragrance of incense and a peacefulness that somehow made all three of us lower our voices without anyone asking us to.

We walked around slowly, taking in details that we probably would've ignored on any other day.

The intricate carvings on the pillars.

The oil lamps flickering in the early morning breeze.

Fresh flower garlands hanging outside the sanctum.

Everything seemed unhurried.

And after the previous week...

That was exactly what we needed.

Once we stepped outside, Saksham stretched dramatically.

"I think this is the calmest I've felt all week."

Shreyansh Bhaiya laughed.

"Wait till you reach home."

"I don't think I'll even know what to do with free time anymore."

"I'll probably wake up at six automatically," I said.

"Same," Bhaiya replied.

"I've forgotten what sleeping late feels like."

For the next hour, we visited another couple of temples around the city.

None of us were in a hurry.

If we liked a place, we stayed for a little longer.

If the roads were empty, we simply enjoyed the drive.

The conversations drifted naturally between Paradox, college life, future plans and completely random topics that made absolutely no sense outside that car.

That, I realised, was one of the nicest things about travelling with people you are comfortable around.

Silence never felt awkward.

Somewhere between one temple and the next, Bhaiya suddenly looked at us and smiled.

"I want to show you one more place."

"What place?" I asked.

"You'll see."

A few minutes later, the car stopped outside a beautiful old church.

For a second, both Saksham and I looked at each other.

"A church?" I asked.

Bhaiya nodded.

"Why not?"

He was right.

Why not?

We walked inside quietly.

The atmosphere was completely different from the temples we had visited earlier.

Soft light filtered through the stained-glass windows, colouring the floor in shades of blue, red and gold.

The entire place felt unbelievably peaceful.

Nobody spoke.

We simply walked around, admiring the architecture and enjoying the silence.

Then...

One completely unnecessary idea entered my head.

Usually...

Those are the ideas that become memories.

I took out my phone.

Saksham looked at me suspiciously.

"What are you doing?"

"I've got an idea."

"I don't like that smile."

Neither did Bhaiya.

He had already started laughing before I had even done anything.

I opened my music app.

For a brief second, I considered playing something soft.

Something peaceful.

Something appropriate.

Instead...

I played the Hanuman Chalisa.

The sound echoed softly through my phone as all three of us looked at each other.

For two seconds, nobody reacted.

Then Saksham burst out laughing.

"Bhai!"

"What?"

"You are impossible."

I stopped the music almost immediately, making sure we weren't disturbing anyone inside.

We laughed quietly like school kids trying not to get caught.

Then, as if that wasn't enough, someone—I still refuse to say whose idea it was—said,

"Now play Maria Maria."

That was it.

The three of us completely lost it.

Standing outside the church, laughing over something so unbelievably silly, we probably looked ridiculous to anyone passing by.

But that's exactly what made it memorable.

It wasn't about the songs.

It wasn't about the church.

It was about three exhausted organisers who had finally reached a point where they could laugh at absolutely anything.

Looking back today, I don't even remember which church it was.

I remember the laughter.

Sometimes...

That is all a place needs to become unforgettable.

By the time we finished our little "tour of Chennai," the city had completely come alive.

The quiet streets we had driven through early in the morning were now filled with traffic.

Tea stalls had transformed into breakfast crowds.

The same roads that had felt peaceful a few hours earlier now carried buses, office-goers and students beginning another ordinary day.

For us, however, the morning had already become something special.

As we drove back towards IIT Madras, nobody spoke very much.

Not because we were tired.

Because there wasn't much left to say.

Some mornings don't need conversations.

They become memories all by themselves.

The familiar gates of IIT Madras appeared once again.

Every single time we entered the campus, it somehow felt like coming home.

Paradox had managed to do something remarkable over the previous week.

It had turned an institute into a neighbourhood.

Every road reminded us of an event.

Every building carried a story.

Every corner held a conversation we had once had.

As soon as we reached Krishna Hostel, reality quietly returned.

Phones that had remained silent throughout the morning suddenly came back to life.

Messages.

Missed calls.

Updates from different departments.

The festival wasn't over yet.

I quickly freshened up before heading towards ESB once again.

By then, it almost felt automatic.

Without even thinking about it, my feet knew exactly where to go.

Room 127.

When I entered, a few familiar faces were already there.

Some volunteers were sorting medals into separate boxes.

Others were arranging certificates according to different events.

A large table in one corner had disappeared beneath neat piles of envelopes, ribbons and winner lists.

The atmosphere inside the room felt completely different from the previous days.

There was no panic anymore.

No one was rushing from one venue to another.

No emergency phone calls echoed through the room.

Instead, everyone worked quietly.

Methodically.

One certificate after another.

One medal after another.

One winner after another.

There is something deeply satisfying about the final stage of an event.

Planning is exciting.

Execution is chaotic.

But distribution...

Distribution is where you finally see months of work reach the people it was meant for.

I picked up a stack of badminton certificates while Aman sorted another pile beside me.

Across the room, someone was cross-checking winner names for football.

Another volunteer carefully counted medals before placing them back into their respective boxes.

The room had become an assembly line of appreciation.

Looking around, I couldn't help smiling.

Only a few days earlier, this same room had been overflowing with strategy meetings, event material, last-minute discussions and volunteers trying to solve impossible problems.

Now...

It was simply full of people making sure every participant went home with what they had earned.

The chaos had finally transformed into closure.

And somehow...

That felt just as important as the events themselves.

Hours passed almost without anyone noticing.

Every few minutes another winner walked into the room.

Some arrived alone.

Some came with their entire house.

A few had already worn their medals around their necks before leaving the venue, proudly taking photographs with anyone willing to click them.

Others simply smiled, collected their certificates, thanked the volunteers and quietly walked away.

Every interaction lasted barely a minute.

Yet each one somehow reminded us why we had spent months organising Paradox in the first place.

One participant looked at the certificate before saying,

"I wasn't expecting it to look this nice."

Another carefully rolled it instead of folding it.

Someone immediately asked where the official photographs would be uploaded.

Another wanted to know whether there would be another edition next year.

That question made all of us smile.

"There definitely will be."

Because if there was one thing Paradox had taught me...

It was that every organiser eventually becomes a participant in someone else's legacy.

One day, another team would sit in this very room.

Another Deputy Secretary would be sorting certificates.

Another Event Head would be wondering whether everything had gone according to plan.

The festival would continue.

Only the faces would change.

By late afternoon, the once-overflowing tables had finally started looking empty.

The piles of certificates had become noticeably smaller.

The medal boxes that had occupied half the room were now almost completely cleared.

Someone looked around and quietly said,

"I think that's the last one."

For a second...

Nobody moved.

It was a surprisingly emotional sentence.

Not because distributing certificates was particularly exciting.

But because it quietly confirmed something none of us had wanted to admit.

Paradox was ending.

There would still be photographs.

There would still be conversations.

There would still be one more night together.

But the work...

The work was over.

I looked around Room 127 one more time.

Only a week earlier, every desk had been buried beneath event material.

Walkie-talkies.

Volunteer lists.

Venue maps.

Sports equipment.

Registration sheets.

Now...

The tables were almost empty.

The room itself looked ready to become a classroom again.

As though none of us had ever been there.

That is perhaps the strangest thing about student festivals.

For the organisers, they become some of the defining weeks of our lives.

For the campus...

It is simply another week on the calendar.

Aman closed the final medal box and looked towards me.

"So..."

"What now?"

For the first time in days...

I genuinely didn't know.

Then somebody walked into the room and asked,

"Movie?"

Before I could answer, another voice followed.

"And Snow Zone?"

I looked at Aman.

He looked back at me.

We both smiled.

"One last adventure?"

"One last adventure."

Neither of us realised it then...

But that night would become one of the funniest nights of the entire trip.

Chapter 22

The Last Certificates

There is something strangely satisfying about finishing the very last task on a project.

Not because the work itself is exciting.

But because it quietly tells you,

"You did it."

By the afternoon of **13 June**, almost every Sports event had officially concluded.

The football ground had fallen silent.

The volleyball nets had already been taken down.

The badminton courts had returned to their usual routine.

Even the registration desks that had looked so alive a few days earlier had disappeared as though they had never existed.

Only one responsibility remained.

Making sure every winner received what they had earned.

For the next several hours, Room 127 in the Electronic Sciences Block became less of an office and more of a distribution centre.

Boxes of medals covered one side of the room.

Certificates occupied the other.

Lists of winners lay open across multiple desks while volunteers patiently checked names one by one before handing over the final rewards.

Compared to the previous week, the atmosphere felt almost peaceful.

Nobody was running anymore.

Nobody was shouting across the room.

Nobody was asking,

"Where's the football?"

"Has volleyball started?"

"Who's carrying the barricades?"

Those questions belonged to another week.

Now...

Everything happened slowly.

One winner walked in.

Collected a certificate.

Smiled.

Thanked the volunteers.

Left.

Then another.

Then another.

Every few minutes another familiar face appeared at the door.

Some arrived wearing medals they had already received earlier that day.

Others came with teammates, refusing to leave until everyone had collected their certificates together.

Some stayed only for a minute.

Others ended up sitting inside ESB for half an hour, talking about the tournament they had just played.

That was another thing I loved about Paradox.

Even after the competition ended...

Nobody seemed in a hurry to leave.

One by one, the medal boxes grew lighter.

At the beginning of the week, we had spent hours counting them, arranging them according to events, checking quantities again and again to make sure nothing was missing.

Now, those same boxes were slowly becoming empty.

Every medal leaving the room meant another participant had a memory to take home.

The same was true for the certificates.

What had started as thick stacks of paper gradually reduced to just a handful.

Someone carefully ticked another name off the list.

Another envelope disappeared from the table.

Another winner walked out smiling.

Watching that process felt surprisingly satisfying.

Not because we were distributing certificates.

Because every certificate represented a story.

Behind every name was someone who had woken up early for trials.

Someone who had practised with their house.

Someone who had lost one match before winning another.

Someone who had celebrated.

Someone who had cried.

We only handed them a piece of paper.

They carried home the journey behind it.

Throughout the afternoon, familiar faces continued appearing at Room 127.

Some walked in confidently.

"Bhaiya, football."

Someone else smiled before saying,

"Badminton doubles."

Another voice came from behind,

"VolleyVibes winners."

At one point, three different house captains walked in together, each insisting that their team deserved the loudest applause while collecting their certificates.

Naturally, nobody agreed.

The room erupted into another round of laughter.

One participant carefully opened the envelope before looking at the certificate for a few seconds.

"This is definitely going on my wall."

That single sentence stayed with me.

We often underestimate small gestures.

To us, it had been another certificate.

To someone else...

It had become something worth preserving.

Another participant asked,

"Sir, next year Paradox kab hai?"

I smiled.

"Already planning for next year?"

He laughed.

"I have to win properly next time."

That answer made everyone around him smile.

Without realising it, he had captured exactly what Paradox was about.

Not just winning.

Wanting to come back.

As the afternoon slowly turned into evening, the room became quieter.

The queue at the door disappeared.

The constant movement slowed.

The volunteer checking names looked down at the final page of the register.

"Bas... ek aur."

One final certificate.

One final medal.

One final signature.

The last participant thanked us, shook hands with a few volunteers and walked out of the room.

For a few moments...

Nobody spoke.

The silence felt strangely different.

Not awkward.

Not sad.

Complete.

Aman looked around the room before closing the final medal box.

"I think..."

"...that's it."

I looked at the nearly empty tables.

The lists that had once been full of unchecked names were now completely marked.

The stacks of certificates had vanished.

The cartons that had occupied one entire corner of the room were folded neatly against the wall.

Room 127 looked almost unfamiliar.

It no longer looked like the headquarters of the Sports Department.

It looked like an ordinary classroom again.

And somehow...

That hurt a little.

Over the previous week, this room had witnessed almost everything.

Morning meetings.

Late-night planning.

Emergency discussions.

Volunteer briefings.

Laughter.

Stress.

Victory.

Exhaustion.

Friendship.

For a brief period of time, it had become the heartbeat of Sportify.

Now...

It quietly returned to being just another room in the Electronic Sciences Block.

Funny how places never realise the memories they hold.

As we picked up our bags and switched off the lights, I turned around for one last look.

Nothing in that room suggested that hundreds of medals and certificates had passed through it.

Nothing suggested that dozens of organisers had called it home for a week.

Tomorrow, another class would probably take place there.

Students would sit at the same desks.

A professor would write on the same board.

And nobody would ever know the stories those walls had witnessed.

We closed the door behind us.

Sportify's work at Paradox was finally over.

Or so we thought.

Because sometimes...

The best memories begin only after the work is finished.

Chapter 23

Snow Zone, Again

Some plans are made weeks in advance.

Others are made in less than ten seconds.

This was definitely the second kind.

By the time we finished distributing the last certificates, the atmosphere inside Room 127 had changed completely.

The work was over.

Not almost over.

Not nearly over.

Over.

The tables that had been covered with medals throughout the afternoon were now almost empty.

The final certificate had found its owner.

The last winner had walked out smiling.

For the first time since arriving at IIT Madras...

The Sports Department had absolutely nothing left to organise.

People didn't leave immediately.

Nobody seemed eager to return to their hostel rooms.

Instead, they simply stayed.

Talking.

Laughing.

Reliving moments that had somehow already become stories despite happening only a few days earlier.

Sometime during those conversations, Saksham walked into the room.

A few minutes later, Shreyansh Bhaiya arrived as well.

Neither of them had been called.

Neither had planned to meet us there.

It just...

Happened.

Looking back, that somehow feels like the perfect description of Paradox itself.

The best memories rarely began with planning.

They began with coincidence.

Someone pulled another chair.

Someone else moved a bag from one desk to another.

Within minutes, the room once again looked less like an organising office and more like a hostel common room.

The conversation wandered wherever it pleased.

For a while, we spoke about the events that had just concluded.

Then someone mentioned Varad.

That naturally led to another conversation.

Then another.

Nothing about it felt formal.

Nobody was trying to solve anything.

Nobody was trying to prove a point.

We were simply talking.

Looking back today...

That conversation means far more to me than I realised at the time.

Just a few hours earlier, I had found closure with someone who had once been one of the closest people in my IITM journey.

Months of awkwardness had quietly disappeared.

There wasn't a dramatic apology.

There wasn't a grand emotional scene.

Just...

A conversation.

Sometimes that's all it takes.

As I looked around Room 127 that afternoon, something felt different.

Lighter.

For the first time in a very long time...

Everything felt normal again.

Then, almost out of nowhere, Komoli looked up from her phone.

"Movie dekhne chale?"

The room became quiet for exactly one second.

"I'm in."

The answer left my mouth almost automatically.

Not because I desperately wanted to watch a movie.

If I'm being honest, after the previous week's sleep schedule, I was almost guaranteed to sleep through it anyway.

I agreed because everyone was together.

That was enough reason.

Within the next few minutes, our little movie group had quietly assembled.

Me.

Shreyansh Bhaiya.

Saksham.

Sarthak.

Shambhavi.

Komoli Priya.

Varad.

Seven people.

One completely unplanned evening.

And absolutely no idea that we were about to create another collection of stories that would stay with us long after Paradox ended.

About half an hour later, we were once again standing outside Phoenix Marketcity.

I couldn't help laughing.

"Didn't we come here just a few days ago?"

Saksham looked at me.

"The one where you all slept through the movie?"

"Not all."

"Bhaiya?"

Shreyansh Bhaiya smiled.

"This time we'll stay awake."

Looking back now..

That statement aged very badly.

Unlike our first visit to Phoenix Marketcity..

This time, we had learned absolutely nothing.

Or perhaps...

We had learned that sleeping through movies was perfectly acceptable.

As we entered the mall, somebody looked towards the cinema.

"Movie first?"

Before anyone could answer, another voice came from behind.

"Snow Zone pehle."

I don't even remember who suggested it.

I only remember that nobody objected.

Apparently, we had all silently agreed that any trip to Phoenix Mall was incomplete without freezing ourselves inside a room full of artificial snow.

As we walked towards Snow Zone, Aman wasn't there this time.

Nikhil wasn't there.

Anshul wasn't there either.

The faces had changed.

But somehow the excitement hadn't.

Standing outside the entrance, I couldn't help remembering my spectacular fall from five days earlier while trying to throw snow at Aman.

Someone asked me,

"You've been here before, right?"

I smiled.

"Yes."

"So you know what you're doing?"

"Absolutely."

That statement turned out to be just as inaccurate as Shreyansh Bhaiya's promise about staying awake during the movie.

A few minutes later, we were all dressed in oversized winter jackets, gloves and boots that somehow made walking feel much more difficult than it should have been.

Every single time I visit a Snow Zone, I have the same thought.

"This outfit cannot possibly look good on anyone."

Looking around...

Nobody looked even remotely fashionable.

Which made it much easier to laugh at everyone else.

The moment the doors opened, the familiar blast of freezing air hit us again.

Almost instinctively, everyone reacted the same way.

"Yaar..."

"Itni thand!"

"This is worse than I remember."

Within seconds, the snowballs had started flying.

Nobody announced the beginning of the snow fight.

It simply happened.

One snowball landed on Saksham.

Another flew towards Sarthak.

Someone immediately declared revenge.

That was all the encouragement anyone needed.

The next few minutes dissolved into complete chaos.

There were no teams.

No rules.

No safe zones.

If you entered the arena...

You accepted your fate.

Shreyansh Bhaiya tried maintaining some dignity for approximately thirty seconds.

Then Saksham and I looked at each other.

Without saying a word...

We both reached down together.

Picked up as much snow as we possibly could.

And attacked.

Poor Bhaiya never stood a chance.

Before he could even react, snow landed directly on his face.

Some of it found its way into his eyes.

"Bhai!"

He shouted while trying to brush the snow away.

"You two are finished!"

Instead of apologising..

We laughed.

That was our second mistake.

Because now..

The chase had officially begun.

For the next several minutes, Bhaiya abandoned every attempt at behaving like the responsible senior organiser we all respected.

He became just another participant in the snow fight.

Unfortunately for Saksham and me...

He was surprisingly accurate.

Every opportunity he got, another snowball came flying in our direction.

Naturally...

Self-preservation became the highest priority.

And that was precisely where I made the biggest mistake of the evening.

Trying to save myself...

Trying to save myself...

...I did what any completely innocent person would do.

I hid behind someone else.

Unfortunately...

That "someone else" happened to be Shambhavi.

In my defence, I wasn't planning anything.

I simply saw the nearest human shield and instinctively moved behind her.

From my perspective, it was a brilliant survival strategy.

From Shambhavi's perspective...

Probably not.

Shreyansh Bhaiya had already prepared another snowball.

He looked straight at me.

"I can still see you."

"You'll have to get through her first," I laughed.

He didn't reply.

He threw.

At that exact moment, every survival instinct inside me activated.

I ducked.

The snowball sailed perfectly over my head.

For a fraction of a second, I felt victorious.

Then came the sound.

"AAH!"

I looked behind me.

The snowball had completely missed me.

Instead...

It landed straight on Shambhavi's head.

Silence.

Absolute silence.

For exactly two seconds.

Then everyone burst into laughter.

Including me.

Which, looking back, was probably another mistake.

Shambhavi turned towards both of us with the expression of someone trying to decide who deserved to be blamed more.

"Bhai!"

She looked at me first.

"Tumhare chakkar mein laga hai!"

I immediately raised both hands.

"My Lord, I am innocent."

"Innocent?"

"You literally used me as a shield!"

I looked towards Shreyansh Bhaiya for support.

He betrayed me immediately.

"I was aiming at Krish."

"I was."

"He escaped."

"So technically..."

"...this is his fault."

"Traitor," I replied.

Saksham had laughed so much by that point that he could barely stand properly.

Sarthak wasn't helping either.

Every time someone tried to calm the situation, they started laughing again.

Thankfully, Shambhavi herself eventually started laughing too.

Although...

She also made one thing very clear.

"I'm remembering this."

"You'll pay for this."

Looking back now, I don't think a single Paradox memory involving Shambhavi ever gets discussed without someone bringing up that snowball.

Even today, whenever the story comes up, the verdict remains unanimous.

According to everyone else...

It was completely my fault.

I still maintain that I was merely trying to survive.

History, unfortunately, has judged me very differently.

The snow fight continued for several more minutes.

Nobody kept score.

Nobody declared a winner.

By the end, all of us had snow inside places where snow should never have reached.

Our gloves were soaked.

Our jackets looked as though we had survived a blizzard.

And every single one of us walked out of Snow Zone laughing.

As we returned our jackets and stepped back into the warmth of the mall, someone stretched dramatically.

"Chennai suddenly feels hot again."

"It is hot," someone replied.

"We just forgot."

After everything that had happened over the previous week...

I don't think any of us realised it then.

But this would be the last completely carefree evening we would spend together before Paradox slowly began saying goodbye.

By the time we stepped out of Snow Zone, every single one of us was exhausted.

Not the kind of exhaustion that comes from organising an event.

The kind that comes after laughing continuously for almost an hour.

Our hair was a mess.

Our jackets had returned.

Our hands had finally started feeling warm again.

And somehow...

We were all hungry.

"McDonald's?" someone suggested.

This time, nobody debated.

After the amount of running, laughing and freezing we had just done, almost anything edible sounded like a good idea.

Within a few minutes, all seven of us were sitting around two joined tables with trays full of burgers, fries, Coke and the occasional extra packet of ketchup that nobody remembered asking for.

There is something wonderfully simple about McDonald's after a long day.

Nobody tries to act sophisticated.

Nobody orders fancy food.

You simply eat.

And keep talking.

The conversations picked up exactly where they had paused inside Snow Zone.

Naturally, Shambhavi's "headshot incident" became the topic of discussion once again.

"I still can't believe you used me as a shield."

"I prefer the term 'strategic positioning.'"

"There was nothing strategic about it."

"It worked."

"It worked for you!"

Everyone burst out laughing again.

Shreyansh Bhaiya immediately joined in.

"I was aiming perfectly."

"I know," I replied.

"That's exactly the problem."

Saksham shook his head.

"The funniest part wasn't even the snowball."

"It was watching Krish disappear at exactly the right moment."

"I call that survival instinct."

"I call that betrayal," Shambhavi replied.

"I object."

"Objection overruled."

Apparently, I had already lost the case.

The food arrived one tray after another.

For a few minutes, the table became unusually quiet.

Not because the conversations had ended.

Because everyone had suddenly remembered how hungry they were.

The silence lasted barely three minutes.

Then, without warning..

Chaos returned.

Shreyansh Bhaiya reached for his Coke.

Or at least...

That was the plan.

His hand accidentally clipped one of the glasses sitting near Komoli Priya.

Time slowed down.

The glass tilted.

For one hopeful second, it looked as though someone might catch it.

Nobody did.

The entire Coke emptied straight onto Komoli Priya.

For half a second...

The whole table froze.

Then Bhaiya looked at the overturned glass.

Then at Komoli.

Then back at the glass.

"I'm... so sorry."

Komoli stared at her completely soaked clothes.

Another second of silence passed.

And then...

The entire table exploded with laughter.

Even Komoli couldn't hold it for long.

"This only happens when I come out with you people."

"I promise," Bhaiya laughed, still apologising, "this wasn't part of the plan."

"You people don't seem to have plans anyway," she replied.

"Fair point," Saksham added.

Someone rushed to grab tissues.

Another volunteer went to ask for extra napkins.

Within a couple of minutes, the crisis had officially been declared under control.

Looking back now, it's funny how none of us remember what burgers we ordered.

None of us remember who paid first.

None of us remember how long we actually sat there.

But every single one of us remembers the Coke.

Because somehow...

The funniest memories are almost always accidental.

Eventually, someone looked at the time.

"Guys..."

"The movie."

For a second, all of us looked at each other.

Then someone asked the most important question of the evening.

"Think we'll stay awake this time?"

I looked at Shreyansh Bhaiya.

He looked back at me.

Neither of us answered.

We simply laughed.

Deep down...

We already knew the answer.

By the time we reached the PVR INOX on the top floor, none of us had much energy left.

Snow Zone had somehow managed to drain whatever enthusiasm the Sports Department still possessed.

We collected our tickets, bought the compulsory overpriced popcorn that somehow accompanies every movie outing, and slowly walked inside.

The movie was **Backrooms**.

Or at least...

That is what the ticket said.

I honestly couldn't tell you much more than that.

As the lights dimmed and everyone settled into their seats, I looked towards Shreyansh Bhaiya.

"This time we'll actually watch the movie."

He nodded confidently.

"Definitely."

Some promises are destined to be broken.

The movie had barely begun.

A few scenes passed.

Someone on screen was running through endless yellow corridors.

The background music grew louder.

The theatre became darker.

The air conditioning became colder.

And my eyes slowly began losing the battle.

I remember trying very hard to stay awake.

I shifted in my seat.

Took another handful of popcorn.

Drank some Coke.

Looked at the screen.

Everything seemed to be happening.

I just wasn't processing any of it.

Then...

Nothing.

The next thing I remember was hearing a voice.

"Krish..."

I ignored it.

Another voice.

"Lagta hai gaya."

Somewhere in the distance, I could hear people laughing.

Then someone gently shook my shoulder.

"Krish."

I slowly opened my eyes.

For a second, I had absolutely no idea where I was.

The theatre lights were on.

People were already standing up.

The credits were rolling.

Sarthak was standing beside me, trying very hard not to laugh.

"Uth."

"Movie khatam ho gayi."

I looked around in complete confusion.

"What?"

"Khatam."

"The whole movie?"

"The whole movie."

I stared at the screen.

Then at Sarthak.

Then around the theatre.

People were leaving.

Cleaning staff had already begun walking between the rows.

I had...

Somehow...

Managed to sleep through another movie.

Five days earlier, during our first Phoenix Mall visit, almost the entire group had slept through the film.

This time...

History had repeated itself.

With fewer people.

I immediately looked towards Shreyansh Bhaiya.

He was only just opening his eyes.

I couldn't help laughing.

"Bhaiya..."

He looked at me with the same confused expression.

"Ho gayi?"

I nodded.

"Apparently."

He looked at the screen for a second before quietly accepting reality.

"I think we should stop going to movies."

Saksham burst out laughing.

"I don't think the movies are the problem."

"They're just too late at night."

Komoli immediately added,

"You both paid for reclining beds, not movie tickets."

That somehow made everyone laugh even harder.

As we walked out of the theatre, the discussion wasn't about the Backrooms.

It was about the fact that neither Bhaiya nor I had the slightest idea what the movie was actually about.

"So..."

Sarthak asked.

"How was the movie?"

I answered honestly.

"The first five minutes were good."

"And the last two?"

"I didn't see those either."

Shreyansh Bhaiya raised his hand.

"I support that review."

To this day...

Whenever someone mentions **Backrooms**, I don't think of endless yellow corridors.

I think of Sarthak waking me up after the credits had already started rolling.

Some movies are remembered because they are unforgettable.

Others...

Because you never actually watched them.

By the time we stepped out of the theatre, it was already close to half past midnight.

Phoenix Marketcity looked completely different now.

The crowds that had filled the mall throughout the evening had disappeared.

Most of the shops had already pulled down their shutters.

Only a handful of people still wandered through the corridors, making their way towards the exits.

For the first time that day...

Nobody was in a hurry.

We slowly walked towards the parking area, still laughing about the movie we hadn't actually watched.

"I still want my money back," I said.

"For what?" Saksham replied.

"You slept."

"That's exactly why."

"You paid for the best sleep of your week."

"I could've done that in Krishna Hostel for free."

Shreyansh Bhaiya nodded immediately.

"I agree."

Komoli looked at both of us and laughed.

"I have never seen two people sleep through the same movie with this much confidence."

"It takes experience," I replied.

"No," Sarthak interrupted.

"It takes talent."

Everyone laughed again.

The ride back to IIT Madras was much quieter.

Not because anyone was upset.

Simply because the day had finally caught up with us.

Snow Zone.

McDonald's.

A movie.

Almost an entire week of Paradox.

Our bodies had finally decided they were done.

Every now and then, someone made another joke.

The rest of us laughed.

Then silence returned.

Outside the windows, Chennai looked peaceful.

Streetlights stretched endlessly along the roads while the occasional late-night tea stall still served customers who, like us, weren't quite ready to end the day.

I rested my head against the window and watched the city pass by.

It suddenly struck me that this had become our routine.

Every evening, we'd leave IIT Madras together.

Every night, we'd return together.

Without ever deciding it, we had become used to each other's company.

That thought made me smile.

When we finally reached the familiar gates of IIT Madras, the security guards barely looked surprised.

Perhaps they had already become accustomed to seeing groups of Paradox organisers returning long after midnight.

As we walked back towards Krishna Hostel, the campus was almost silent.

The same roads that had echoed with announcements, cheering crowds and whistles only a few days earlier now belonged to nothing but crickets, distant streetlights and a handful of sleepy organisers making their way back to their rooms.

Halfway through the walk, someone yawned loudly.

"Tomorrow..."

"...I'm sleeping till noon."

"You've been saying that for a week," I replied.

"And every day someone wakes you up."

"This time nobody will."

We all laughed.

Looking back now...

That conversation feels strangely innocent.

None of us knew that tomorrow wouldn't really be another ordinary day.

Tomorrow would be the beginning of goodbyes. Hostel rooms would slowly empty. Suitcases would appear outside doors.

People would begin checking train tickets and flight timings instead of event schedules.

The festival wasn't ending all at once.

It was quietly beginning to disappear.

But that night...

None of us thought about leaving.

As we reached Krishna Hostel, we exchanged the same words we had spoken countless times throughout the week.

"Good night."

"See you tomorrow."

"I'll call you in the morning."

Nobody realised that, for some of us...

There were only a few more "tomorrows" left together.

I unlocked the door to Room 367 one more time. The room felt unusually quiet.

No event material lay scattered across the tables.

No volunteer lists.

No banners.

No bibs.

Only two tired organisers returning after another unforgettable day.

I lay down on the bed, smiled to myself, and thought about everything that had happened over the past week.

The monkey.

Kampus Run.

The beach.

Volleyball.

Snow Zone.

Sleeping through another movie.

If someone had asked me that night whether Paradox had been worth all the sleepless nights...

I wouldn't have needed even a second to answer.

Absolutely.

I switched off the lights.

Outside, IIT Madras slept peacefully.

Inside Room 367...

We didn't know it yet.

But the countdown had already begun.

Chapter 24

The Last Day

There is a peculiar feeling that comes with the last morning of something beautiful.

Nothing looks different.

The roads are the same.

The buildings haven't changed.

The people are still around.

Yet somewhere deep inside, you know that by the end of the day...

None of this will ever exist in quite the same way again.

The alarm rang at five in the morning.

For the third consecutive day, I found myself waking up before sunrise.

Only this time, there were no sporting events waiting for us.

No volunteer briefings.

No registrations.

No emergency phone calls.

Paradox had finally become quiet.

Just like the previous morning, Shreyansh Bhaiya, Saksham and I stepped out of IIT Madras while the campus was still asleep.

Our destination that morning was the **Kapaleeshwarar Temple**.

If someone had told me a week earlier that one of my favourite Paradox memories would involve waking up at five in the morning to visit temples around Chennai, I probably wouldn't have believed them.

Yet here we were.

Three exhausted organisers.

One peaceful morning.

And nowhere in particular we needed to rush.

The roads through Chennai were still wrapped in the calm that only exists before the city fully wakes up.

Flower vendors sat outside small shops, carefully threading fresh jasmine garlands together.

Tea stalls had just begun serving their first customers.

The occasional cyclist passed by while buses slowly started another ordinary day.

For the first time since arriving in Chennai, it felt as though we were seeing the city not as organisers...

But as travellers.

Kapaleeshwarar Temple welcomed us with the same serenity that had made the previous morning's temple visits so memorable.

The temple courtyard was already alive with devotees offering their morning prayers.

The sound of temple bells echoed gently through the air, blending with the rhythmic chanting that floated from inside the sanctum.

We removed our shoes and quietly walked in.

Nobody spoke.

There was nothing to say.

Sometimes silence itself feels like prayer.

I don't remember how long we stayed there.

Time seemed irrelevant inside those walls.

Perhaps because none of us wanted to think about what waited after we returned to campus.

The final day.

The closing ceremony.

The goodbyes.

Eventually, we stepped back outside into the warm Chennai morning.

Shreyansh Bhaiya stretched his arms and smiled.

"Breakfast?"

Neither Saksham nor I needed convincing.

A few minutes later, we found ourselves walking into another branch of **Vasanta**.

The three of us looked at one another and laughed almost immediately.

"Again?"

"It seems Vasanta isn't done with us yet," Bhaiya joked.

Only the previous evening, another branch of the same restaurant had witnessed one of the funniest dinners of the entire week.

Now, less than twelve hours later, we were back.

This time...

Without snowballs.

Without spilled Coke.

Without movies we wouldn't watch.

Just breakfast.

Hot idlis.

Crisp dosas.

Filter coffee.

Simple food somehow tastes extraordinary after a week like Paradox.

The conversations wandered effortlessly.

We spoke about the previous week's chaos.

About Kampus Run.

About the monkey that had somehow become one of the unofficial mascots of the Sports Department.

About the ridiculous number of kilometres we had walked inside IIT Madras.

Every now and then, one of us would stop mid-conversation, laugh at another memory, and then continue as though nothing had happened.

There was no agenda.

No planning.

No responsibilities left to discuss.

For the first time in months...

We were simply three people having breakfast together.

Looking back today, I don't remember every sentence from that meal.

I remember how peaceful it felt.

Perhaps that was exactly what we needed before the day ahead.

Because by sunset...

Paradox would officially be over.

The drive back to IIT Madras felt much shorter than the drive to the temple.

Perhaps because we had finally accepted that the day had begun.

As the familiar gates appeared once again, I found myself looking around a little more carefully than usual.

The giant trees.

The cyclists rushing past.

Students walking with backpacks slung over one shoulder.

The signboards I had walked past dozens of times during the week.

Nothing had changed.

Yet everything somehow felt different.

Maybe because I knew this would be one of the last times I would enter the campus before leaving Chennai.

Back at Krishna Hostel, reality returned almost immediately.

The peaceful morning was replaced by the familiar sound of trolley bags rolling across hostel corridors.

Doors opened and closed one after another.

Someone was stuffing clothes into a suitcase.

Someone else was trying to zip a bag that clearly contained more things than it was designed to hold.

The festival was ending.

And the hostels had begun to show it.

I unlocked Room 367 one more time.

For a few seconds, I simply stood at the entrance.

It looked nothing like it had a week ago.

The room that had once been overflowing with event material now looked almost empty.

No cartons filled with medals.

No Kampus Run bibs.

No certificates waiting to be sorted.

No volunteers walking in every ten minutes asking,

"Krish bhaiya, ek minute?"

Only two neatly arranged beds.

Two bags waiting to be packed.

And a week that somehow still lingered inside those four walls.

I took out my formal clothes and laid them carefully on the bed.

Today wasn't another event day.

Today was the closing ceremony.

The same Sportify T-shirt that I had proudly worn throughout the week was folded neatly and placed inside my backpack.

For a moment, I held it in my hands.

That blue T-shirt had travelled everywhere with me.

The football ground.

The volleyball courts.

The Electronic Sciences Block.

The Open Air Theatre.

The beach.

Phoenix Mall.

Snow Zone.

Every stain, every crease and every thread somehow carried a memory.

I folded it one final time.

Not because I was packing a piece of clothing.

Because I was packing an entire week.

After changing into formals, I walked towards Isthara.

One by one, familiar faces began gathering there.

Some had already packed their luggage.

Some still carried their Sportify jackets over one shoulder.

Everyone looked strangely different in formal clothes.

For the first time in days, nobody looked like an organiser.

They looked like students again.

Someone immediately shouted,

"Team photo!"

Another replied,

"Not yet."

"We'll take one after the ceremony."

"Why not both?"

Nobody argued.

That had become our solution for everything involving photographs.

Just take another one.

The conversations flowed as naturally as they always had.

Someone was already asking about everyone's journey home.

"Train?"

"Flight."

"Bus."

"When are you leaving?"

"Tonight."

"I'm staying one more day."

"I'm not ready to leave."

That sentence hung in the air for a moment.

Nobody laughed.

Because nobody was ready.

Around one in the afternoon, we finally began walking towards the Student Activities Centre.

The closing ceremony would begin later, but organisers had been asked to report early.

Old habits refused to leave us.

Even on the final day, we reached before time.

As SAC slowly came into view, I realised this wasn't just another walk across campus.

It was the last time the entire Sportify team would walk together as one organising committee.

None of us said it aloud.

But I think all of us felt it.

The Student Activities Centre looked completely different from the way I had seen it throughout the year.

The auditorium was slowly filling with students from every corner of the IITM BS community.

University Houses.

Technical societies.

Cultural clubs.

Professional societies.

Volunteers.

Faculty members.

Everyone had gathered one last time before Paradox officially came to an end.

The atmosphere felt different from the opening ceremony.

Back then, the room had been full of anticipation.

Today...

It was full of satisfaction.

People weren't wondering what Paradox would become.

They were remembering what it had already been.

The Sportify team made its way upstairs, occupying the first few rows of the balcony.

I watched everyone settling down before Aman and I were asked to remain downstairs near the stage.

It felt strange.

For the first time all week, we weren't coordinating anything.

We weren't checking registrations.

We weren't solving problems.

We simply sat there and waited.

Waiting..

is surprisingly difficult after spending months constantly doing something.

I looked around the auditorium.

Different society members were laughing with one another, exchanging photographs, waving across rows and trying to spot familiar faces sitting elsewhere in the hall.

Everywhere I looked, I saw people who had spent the last year building something.

Not for themselves.

For the community.

That thought made me smile.

Slowly, the lights dimmed.

The conversations became quieter.

The closing ceremony had begun.

One after another, different recognitions were presented.

The University Houses were invited first.

Applause echoed through the auditorium as representatives walked onto the stage to receive their certificates.

Then came the societies.

Every announcement was followed by cheers from somewhere inside the hall.

Each society had its own little corner of supporters who somehow managed to sound louder than everyone else.

Sportify was no different.

Every now and then, I looked up towards the balcony.

Our team was impossible to miss.

Somebody waved.

Someone else made a gesture asking whether I was nervous.

I smiled and shook my head.

Truthfully...

I wasn't nervous.

I was grateful.

Grateful that I had been given the opportunity to spend one year building something that meant so much to me.

Then...

A voice I had heard countless times over the previous week echoed through the auditorium.

Shreyansh Bhaiya.

"Ladies and gentlemen..."

He paused briefly before reading the next line.

"I invite the PORs of Sportify..."

"...Mr. Aman Sagar..."

"...and Mr. Krish Gupta..."

"...to please come onto the stage."

For just a moment...

Everything else disappeared.

The applause became distant.

The auditorium blurred.

I looked towards Aman.

Without saying a single word...

We both stood up.

For the last time as Secretary and Deputy Secretary of Sportify.

Together.

And began walking towards the stage.

The walk to the stage lasted only a few seconds.

It somehow carried an entire year.

As Aman and I climbed the steps, I wasn't looking at the audience.

I was looking at memories.

I remembered the first meetings where Sportify was still trying to figure out what it wanted to become.

I remembered endless Google Sheets that somehow never stayed updated for more than five minutes.

Late-night calls.

Volunteer recruitments.

The first department meetings.

The arguments.

The laughter.

The uncertainty.

Then Paradox.

The sleepless nights.

The early mornings.

Kampus Run.

The monkey.

Room 127.

The beach.

Snow Zone.

Volleyball.

Every single memory somehow walked onto the stage with us.

Kothai Ma'am stood at the centre, holding our certificates.

As we reached her, she smiled.

"Congratulations."

She handed the first certificate to Aman.

Then she turned towards me.

For a brief second, I looked at the certificate.

My name was printed on it.

But somehow...

It didn't feel like mine alone.

Before taking it, I instinctively bent down and touched her feet.

It wasn't something I had planned.

There was no thought behind it.

Only gratitude.

She gently placed her hand on my head and blessed me.

"All the best."

Those three words stayed with me far longer than the applause.

Some blessings don't need long speeches.

They simply become part of you.

A few steps ahead stood Bharathi Ma'am and Andrew Sir.

Both congratulated us warmly, shaking our hands with genuine smiles.

"Well done."

"Congratulations."

Simple words.

Yet after months of work, they carried unexpected weight.

I thanked them quietly before moving towards the centre of the stage once again.

The official photographer adjusted his camera.

"Sir... a little closer."

Aman and I stood side by side, certificates in our hands.

The camera flashed.

Then another.

For a moment, I looked beyond the lights into the audience.

My eyes immediately found the first row of the balcony.

There they were.

Our team.

Some were clapping.

Some were cheering.

A few had already taken out their phones to record the moment.

Looking at them, one thought crossed my mind.

People often congratulate the faces they see.

Very few notice the dozens of people standing behind those faces.

That certificate had my name on it.

But it belonged to every volunteer who woke up before sunrise.

Every department head who stayed back after midnight.

Every coordinator who quietly solved problems nobody else ever knew existed.

Every person who believed Sportify could become something bigger than itself.

I was simply fortunate enough to receive it on their behalf.

A few moments later, representatives from every society were invited onto the stage for the official group photograph.

One by one, familiar faces joined us.

Technology.

Culture.

Media.

Entrepreneurship.

Community.

Different societies.

Different journeys.

One shared purpose.

Standing there, shoulder to shoulder with everyone, I realised something.

None of us would ever experience this version of IIT Madras again.

Next year, new faces would stand where we stood.

New secretaries.

New deputy secretaries.

New volunteers.

New dreams.

That is how student communities survive.

Not by staying the same.

But by trusting the next batch to write the next chapter.

The photographer smiled.

"Everyone ready?"

We nodded.

The flash went off.

And just like that...

One year of Sportify was captured in a single photograph.

The moment the photographs were over, the stage slowly began to empty.

One by one, society representatives stepped down, still holding their certificates carefully.

Aman and I did the same.

As my feet touched the ground again, it felt strangely symbolic.

A journey that had begun with uncertainty had quietly reached its destination.

As we walked back towards our seats, people from different societies stopped us along the way.

"Congratulations."

"Well deserved."

"You guys did an amazing job this year."

Every handshake felt genuine.

Every smile carried the warmth that only people who have organised something together can truly understand.

When I looked up towards the balcony again, I saw our Sportify team already waiting for us.

The moment Aman and I reached them, the applause started all over again.

Someone hugged Aman.

Another volunteer shook my hand.

Someone else simply said,

"We're proud of you."

That sentence affected me far more than I expected.

Because throughout the year, we had spent so much time worrying about registrations, reports, meetings and deadlines that we rarely stopped to ask ourselves a simple question.

Had we made our team proud?

Standing there...

I finally felt that perhaps we had.

The ceremony officially came to an end.

People slowly began walking out of the auditorium.

Nobody seemed to be in a hurry.

The corridors outside SAC quickly filled with familiar faces once again.

Every few steps, another photograph.

Another handshake.

Another conversation that began with,

"Before you leave..."

The sunlight outside had already started turning golden.

The campus looked exactly as it always had.

Yet everyone walked a little slower than usual.

Almost as if nobody wanted to be the first person to admit that Paradox was over.

Before leaving the auditorium, I turned around one last time.

The stage was empty again.

The chairs were being rearranged.

Volunteers had already begun removing banners from the sides.

Within a few hours, nothing inside SAC would suggest that hundreds of students had gathered there to celebrate an entire year's worth of work.

That's the strange thing about student life.

You spend months building moments...

And then the venue quietly resets itself for the next batch.

As Aman and I stepped outside together, he looked at the certificate in his hand before smiling.

"So..."

"Secretary saab."

I laughed.

"So..."

"Deputy Secretary saab."

For a second, we both stood there laughing.

Not as Secretary and Deputy Secretary.

Not as organisers.

Just as two friends who had somehow survived one unforgettable year together.

Neither of us realised it then...

But this wasn't really the end of our journey.

It was only the end of one chapter.

The rest of the story...

Was still waiting outside the doors of the Student Activities Centre.

Chapter 25

Everybody Started Leaving

I have often wondered when a festival actually ends.

Is it when the closing ceremony finishes?

When the final event concludes?

When the lights are switched off?

Or...

Is it when the first suitcase quietly rolls across the hostel corridor?

For me, Paradox didn't end inside the Student Activities Centre.

It ended one goodbye at a time.

As we stepped out of SAC, nobody wanted to go back immediately.

Instead, almost every society gathered somewhere outside the auditorium.

The official programme had ended.

The unofficial one had just begun.

Photographs.

Lots of photographs.

Someone shouted,

"Sportify!"

Within seconds, people who had somehow disappeared into the crowd moments earlier started appearing again.

Department heads.

Coordinators.

Volunteers.

Even people who had been halfway to the parking lot turned around after hearing someone yell,

"Bas ek photo aur!"

We all knew it was never just one.

Every photograph created an excuse for another.

"Core team."

"Entire team."

"Only department heads."

"Only volunteers."

"Girls."

"Boys."

"Now everyone."

"Portrait."

"Landscape."

"One funny pose."

By the end, nobody remembered how many photographs we had actually taken.

Only that nobody wanted to stop taking them.

Perhaps because every photograph delayed goodbye by another minute.

At one point, I quietly stepped aside for a moment.

From a distance, I watched everyone laughing.

Deepak was trying to organise people into rows.

Sarthak kept making someone laugh just as the camera clicked.

Ansh was busy taking photographs on three different phones at once.

Someone was adjusting a Sportify flag that refused to stay straight.

A volunteer ran across the frame at exactly the wrong moment.

"Arre!"

"Dubara."

Everyone laughed.

Again.

Looking at all of them together, I realised something.

Eight months earlier...

Most of us had entered Sportify as strangers.

Now, standing outside the Student Activities Centre, it felt impossible to imagine this group not existing.

Someone eventually looked at the time.

"I have to pack."

That sentence changed everything.

Almost instantly, conversations shifted.

"What time's your train?"

"When's your flight?"

"Cab booked?"

"Who's leaving tonight?"

For the first time all week...

Nobody was asking about fixtures anymore.

Everyone was asking about departures.

And somehow...

That felt much harder.

One by one, people began walking away from the group.

Some promised to meet before leaving.

Others said,

"I'll text you."

Some simply hugged everyone nearby before disappearing towards the hostels.

The crowd became smaller without anyone noticing.

Goodbyes rarely happen all at once.

They happen quietly.

One person at a time.

One hug at a time.

One suitcase at a time.

And before you realise it...

The place that felt full of people begins to feel strangely empty.

Eventually, I made my way back towards Krishna Hostel.

The walk felt unusually quiet.

Not because the campus had become silent.

Because the noise had changed.

Just a few days earlier, the roads had been filled with participants rushing towards venues, volunteers carrying equipment and organisers answering phone calls before the previous one had even ended.

Now...

The same roads were filled with trolley bags.

Parents.

Airport cabs.

Students checking Google Maps instead of event schedules.

Paradox had quietly transformed back into an ordinary Sunday.

As I entered Krishna Hostel, the change became impossible to ignore.

The corridor that had once echoed with constant conversations now felt strangely empty.

Some room doors stood wide open while people packed hurriedly inside.

Others were already locked.

Outside a few rooms, neatly packed suitcases waited patiently for their owners.

Every now and then, another familiar face walked past.

"Leaving?"

"Yeah."

"When?"

"Half an hour."

"You?"

"Evening."

A quick hug.

A handshake.

A promise to meet again.

Then another person disappeared down the staircase.

Room 367 was exactly where I had left it.

Except now...

My own bag waited beside the bed.

For the first time that week, I actually started packing.

The Sportify T-shirt.

My formal clothes.

A pair of shoes still carrying traces of red soil from the football ground.

The jacket from Snow Zone.

The certificate from the closing ceremony.

One by one, every item disappeared into my suitcase.

Packing is a strange activity.

You aren't just putting clothes into a bag.

You're deciding which memories get folded first.

I picked up my accreditation badge before placing it carefully inside one of the side pockets.

For a second, I just looked at it.

A small laminated card.

To anyone else...

Almost meaningless.

To me...

It was the key that had opened every venue, every meeting room and every unforgettable day of the previous week.

I couldn't bring myself to throw it away.

Even today...

I still have it.

Before closing my bag, I looked around the room one final time.

It suddenly struck me that this room had witnessed almost every version of me.

The stressed organiser.

The sleepy volunteer.

The excited event head.

The exhausted student.

The friend laughing at two in the morning.

The person wondering whether everything would somehow work out.

Room 367 had quietly seen all of it.

I switched off the lights.

Then immediately turned them back on.

I had forgotten my charger.

Some habits...

Never change.

I laughed at myself, picked it up and finally closed the door behind me.

As I walked down the stairs, I didn't know when I would stay in Krishna Hostel again.

But I knew one thing.

Whenever I did...

This building would never feel the same without Paradox.

By early evening, my suitcase was finally packed.

The room that had been my home throughout Paradox looked exactly as it had on the first day.

Clean.

Quiet.

Almost anonymous.

If someone walked into Room 367 at that moment, they would never have guessed that only a few hours earlier it had been filled with stories, laughter, event material and conversations that stretched late into the night.

It was just another hostel room again.

I picked up my bag and stepped outside.

The sun had begun its slow descent behind the trees of IIT Madras, covering the campus in the soft golden light that somehow made every road look more beautiful than usual.

Maybe it wasn't the light.

Maybe it was the knowledge that I was seeing it for the last time on this trip.

Near the hostel entrance, I found familiar faces once again.

Ansh.

Devam.

Anshul.

Nandhini.

The five of us had already decided that instead of heading home immediately, we would steal two more days from reality and spend them in Pondicherry.

It sounded like exactly the kind of decision twenty-year-olds should make.

"Sab ready?"

Ansh asked.

"As ready as we'll ever be," I replied.

We loaded our luggage into the cab one bag at a time.

The driver looked at the growing pile of backpacks and suitcases before smiling.

"Lagta hai pura hostel shift ho raha hai."

We laughed.

"Bas thoda sa."

As the cab slowly pulled away from Krishna Hostel, I instinctively turned towards the building one last time.

Room 367 was no longer visible.

Only the familiar hostel block remained.

A place that, for one unforgettable week, had felt more like home than any hotel ever could.

The cab drove through the familiar roads of IIT Madras one final time.

Past the towering trees.

Past the deer that wandered around as though they owned the campus.

Past buildings that had become landmarks in our own little world.

The Open Air Theatre.

The Student Activities Centre.

The Electronic Sciences Block.

Every place we crossed carried a memory.

Nobody inside the cab spoke for a while.

Not because we were sad.

Because each of us was quietly saying goodbye in our own way.

As we approached the Main Gate, I rolled down the window.

The evening breeze rushed in.

The security guard checked the vehicle before lifting the barrier.

For a brief second, the cab slowed down.

Then it crossed the gate.

I watched IIT Madras disappear behind us through the rear window.

A strange thought crossed my mind.

When we had entered the campus a week earlier, we had arrived carrying bags full of clothes.

Now...

We were leaving carrying stories.

None of us knew when we would return.

But all of us knew one thing.

Whenever we did...

This campus would never feel ordinary again.

The city traffic slowly replaced the quiet roads of IIT Madras as we made our way towards the bus stand.

Paradox was behind us now.

Ahead of us...

Waited one last little adventure before we finally returned home.

The bus stand was exactly what every Indian bus stand becomes after sunset.

Bright lights.

Constant announcements.

Vendors calling out to passengers.

Families saying hurried goodbyes.

Travellers trying to figure out whether they were standing at the correct platform.

The five of us stepped out of the cab and stretched after the drive.

Almost immediately, someone asked the most important question.

"Khana?"

"We'll eat after boarding," Ansh replied.

"First let's find the bus."

Finding the correct platform turned out to be much easier than we had expected.

Our bus to Pondicherry was already waiting.

Its headlights cut through the evening crowd while passengers slowly loaded their luggage into the storage compartment below.

One by one, we handed over our bags.

Backpacks.

Duffel bags.

Suitcases that somehow looked heavier than they had in the morning.

I watched as my own bag disappeared into the luggage compartment.

A strange thought crossed my mind.

Everything I had carried to Paradox...

Was packed inside that single bag once again.

The only difference was that this time, I was carrying home much more than clothes.

We climbed aboard and found our seats.

As always, there was a brief discussion.

"Window?"

"Middle?"

"You always take the window."

"Exactly."

Some things never change.

I settled beside the window and rested my head against the glass.

Outside, Chennai continued moving at its usual pace.

People hurried across the roads.

Autos weaved confidently through impossible gaps in traffic.

Tea stalls welcomed another round of customers.

For the city...

It was just another evening.

For us...

It marked the end of a week we would probably spend the rest of our lives talking about.

The engine started.

Slowly, almost reluctantly, the bus pulled away from the platform.

Nobody said much.

The excitement of the previous week had finally given way to a comfortable silence.

Somebody plugged in their earphones.

Someone else immediately fell asleep.

Ansh was still scrolling through photographs from Paradox, occasionally smiling at something on his screen before showing it to the rest of us.

"Look at this one."

We laughed.

Another photograph.

Another memory.

The bus gradually left the city behind.

Streetlights gave way to darker roads.

The conversations became softer.

One by one, everyone around me drifted off to sleep.

I stayed awake a little longer.

Watching the lights outside blur into long golden lines against the window.

Thinking about everything that had happened over the previous seven days.

If someone had asked me then what my favourite memory from Paradox was...

I honestly wouldn't have been able to answer.

It wasn't Kampus Run.

Or Snow Zone.

Or the beach.

Or the closing ceremony.

It was the people.

Always the people.

Sometime after midnight, the conductor's voice broke the silence.

"Pondicherry."

I opened my eyes.

Outside the window, unfamiliar streets stretched beneath rows of yellow streetlights.

We had arrived.

Paradox was over.

But somehow...

The journey wasn't ready to end just yet.

Chapter 26

Home

When our bus rolled into Pondicherry a little after midnight, none of us were thinking about going home.

Not yet.

Reality could wait.

For two more days, we allowed ourselves to believe that Paradox hadn't really ended.

It had simply changed locations.

The streets of Pondicherry were almost empty at that hour.

The sea breeze carried a coolness we hadn't felt during the humid days in Chennai.

Compared to the constant movement of Paradox, everything here seemed slower.

Quieter.

Kinder.

After checking into our hotel, the only discussion that mattered was surprisingly simple.

"So..."

"Tomorrow morning?"

Nobody had a plan.

Nobody opened Google Maps.

Nobody prepared an itinerary.

For an entire week, every hour of our lives had been scheduled.

Now...

Doing nothing felt like the best possible plan.

The next two days passed exactly the way every good trip with friends should.

Without urgency.

Without alarms.

Without responsibilities.

We wandered through the French Quarter without caring where a particular road would lead.

We sat beside the sea for longer than necessary, talking about everything except the future.

Sometimes we laughed about Kampus Run.

Sometimes someone brought up the monkey again.

Sometimes we recreated conversations from Paradox so dramatically that strangers walking past probably wondered what was wrong with us.

Every memory already sounded bigger than it had when it happened.

That is the strange thing about beautiful weeks.

They begin turning into stories almost immediately.

For those two days, nobody mentioned registrations.

Nobody mentioned reports.

Nobody mentioned pending work.

Sportify was no longer a society.

It was simply a collection of memories we carried together.

Looking back now...

I'm grateful we took that trip.

If I had returned home directly after Paradox, perhaps the ending would've felt too sudden.

Pondicherry became a gentle pause between two very different chapters of life.

A place where we unknowingly celebrated the end of one journey...

Before the next one quietly began.

The morning of **17 June** arrived much sooner than any of us wanted.

Just like that...

Our little escape had come to an end.

After breakfast, we packed our bags once again and boarded a bus back to Chennai.

This journey felt different from the one three days earlier.

On the way to Pondicherry, we had spent most of our time laughing about Paradox.

Now...

The conversations had become quieter.

Not because we had run out of things to say.

Because we were all slowly preparing ourselves to return to our own lives.

By early afternoon, I was back in Chennai.

But before heading to the airport, there was one last thing I wanted to do.

One last lunch.

One last conversation.

One last goodbye.

Shreyansh Bhaiya and Saksham were already waiting near the Main Gate of IIT Madras.

It felt strangely familiar.

Only three days earlier, we had been together before sunrise, visiting temples across Chennai.

Now...

The festival was over.

The city had returned to normal.

And we were meeting one final time before heading in completely different directions.

We walked to a small Chinese restaurant near the campus.

Nothing about the place was extraordinary.

If anything, it was wonderfully ordinary.

Plastic menus.

Simple tables.

The constant sound of plates arriving from the kitchen.

People around us having completely normal lunches, unaware that three students sitting in one corner were quietly bringing an unforgettable week to an end.

As always, the conversation started with food.

"What are you ordering?"

"Whatever you're having."

"No copying."

"I've copied your assignments before."

"You definitely haven't."

"Exactly."

We laughed.

Some things never changed.

The food arrived quickly.

For almost an hour, we spoke about everything.

Paradox.

Sportify.

Future plans.

The internship Bhaiya was beginning.

What Saksham wanted to do next.

What I wanted to build after returning home.

There was no grand farewell speech.

No emotional promises.

No dramatic silence.

Just three people sharing one final meal together.

Looking back now..

I think that's exactly why I treasure it so much.

The best goodbyes rarely announce themselves.

They simply happen.

When the lunch ended, we stepped back outside.

The Chennai sun felt as warm as ever.

Cars moved in and out of the Main Gate.

Students continued entering the campus as though it were just another ordinary afternoon.

Life had already moved on.

We hadn't.

Not completely.

Bhaiya looked at me.

"So..."

"Safe journey."

"You too."

Saksham smiled.

"Next time..."

"...without Paradox stress."

"Deal."

We shook hands.

Then, almost instinctively, we hugged.

There wasn't much left to say.

Some relationships never need long conversations to understand one another.

I watched as they walked back towards the campus.

For a few moments, I simply stood there.

I didn't know it then...

But that would be the last time I would see both of them together before life carried all of us in different directions.

A cab was already waiting.

The driver placed my suitcase inside the boot and asked,

"Airport?"

I nodded.

As the cab pulled away from IIT Madras one final time, I looked back through the rear window.

The Main Gate slowly disappeared behind the traffic.

The trees.

The walls.

The familiar roads.

Everything gradually faded from view.

A week earlier, I had entered that gate as the Deputy Secretary of Sportify, carrying months of planning on my shoulders.

Now I was leaving with something far more valuable.

Memories.

An entire year compressed into a single journey.

A few hours later, my flight landed.

I stepped out of the airport, took a deep breath, and walked towards home.

The trip was over.

Or at least...

That's what I believed.

Because sometimes...

The longest part of a journey doesn't begin until after you've already returned home.

I thought the story had ended.

PART V

THINGS LEFT UNSAID

Nobody remembers the exact moment a friendship begins to change.

At first, everything still looks the same.

*Only later do you realise you were already saying goodbye without
knowing it.*

Chapter 27

Brothers

Every society has a hierarchy.

Secretary.

Deputy Secretary.

Department Heads.

Coordinators.

Volunteers.

On paper...

Sportify had one too.

But somewhere along the way, we quietly stopped living by those designations.

Nobody remembers exactly when it happened.

There wasn't a meeting where we collectively decided,

"From today onwards, we're family."

It happened much more naturally than that.

One late-night meeting turned into dinner together.

Dinner became inside jokes.

Inside jokes became long phone calls.

Long phone calls became trust.

And somewhere between deadlines, Google Sheets and sleepless nights...

We stopped becoming colleagues.

We became each other's people.

Looking back today, I think that's the greatest thing Sportify ever gave me.

Not leadership.

Not event management.

Not confidence.

People.

Real people.

The kind who slowly become part of your everyday life without asking for permission.

When I first joined Sportify, I expected to work with a Secretary.

Instead...

I found a brother.

Aman and I were very different people.

He was calmer than I was.

I usually thought aloud.

He preferred thinking first.

I often got emotionally attached to ideas.

He looked at them practically.

Many of our discussions began as disagreements.

Most of them ended in laughter.

Somewhere along the way, the words "Secretary" and "Deputy Secretary" quietly disappeared.

We became two people trying to build something together.

Whenever someone appreciated Sportify's work, they usually saw the two of us standing in front.

Very few people saw what happened behind the scenes.

The late-night calls.

The endless planning.

The moments where one of us had almost given up and the other quietly said,

"Ho jayega."

No speeches.

No motivation.

Just faith.

Sometimes...

That is enough.

Then there was Shreyansh Bhaiya.

Calling him a mentor somehow feels incomplete.

Mentors teach you skills.

He taught me perspective.

Whenever I found myself worrying about things that felt impossibly large, Bhaiya somehow managed to reduce them to one simple conversation.

He rarely told us what to do.

Instead...

He asked questions that somehow made us find the answers ourselves.

That is a very rare quality.

Perhaps that is why everyone naturally called him "Bhaiya."

Not because of age.

Because of the comfort he carried with him.

Saksham was different.

Every group has one person capable of making stressful days feel lighter.

For us...

That was Saksham.

It didn't matter whether we were running behind schedule, solving last-minute problems or surviving another twelve-hour workday.

He somehow found something to laugh about.

Looking back, I genuinely don't know how many difficult days became easier simply because he refused to let the room stay serious for too long.

Then there were the people who carried Sportify alongside us.

Methelesh.

Varad.

Sarthak.

Deepak.

Saurabh.

Ansh.

Pratham.

Ashish.

Anshul.

Jahanvi.

Pratishtha.

Shreya.

Lata.

VSS.

And so many others whose names deserve to be written here.

Each of them carried a different part of Sportify.

Different departments.

Different responsibilities.

Different personalities.

Yet somehow...

We all ended up protecting the same dream.

That is probably why, whenever people ask me about Sportify, I never begin by describing our events.

I begin by describing the people.

Because events end.

Certificates gather dust.

Instagram posts disappear beneath newer ones.

But the people...

If you're lucky...

They stay with you long after the applause has faded.

At least...

That's what I believed.

Back then, I couldn't imagine a future where we wouldn't all continue talking exactly the way we always had.

I couldn't imagine silence finding its way into a group that had once spoken every single day.

I couldn't imagine that the strongest relationships could be shaken...

Not by hatred.

But by misunderstanding.

If someone had told me that during Paradox...

I would've laughed.

Because from where I stood...

We weren't just a team anymore.

We were brothers.

And brothers always find their way back.

At least...

That was what I thought.

People often assume friendships are built through long conversations.

I don't think ours were.

They were built through ordinary moments.

Sharing breakfast after sleeping barely three hours.

Waiting outside venues before sunrise.

Fighting over who forgot to bring extension boards.

Arguing about Google Sheets.

Walking kilometres across IIT Madras because booking a shuttle somehow always felt unnecessary.

Sitting on the floor of ESB at midnight because everyone was too tired to find actual chairs.

Those moments rarely appear in official reports.

Yet...

They are the moments that quietly build families.

I realised this during Paradox.

If one person disappeared for more than fifteen minutes, somebody would immediately ask,

"Where is he?"

If someone skipped a meal, another person would somehow notice.

If someone looked unusually quiet, at least one of us would ask,

"Sab theek hai?"

Nobody appointed anyone to care.

It simply happened.

That is probably why the word **Sportify** stopped meaning a society to me.

It became a place.

Not a physical place.

A feeling.

The feeling that no matter how difficult the day became, there would always be someone beside you.

Looking back today, I realise how rare that kind of trust actually is.

We celebrated birthdays together.

Travelled together.

Lost sleep together.

Won together.

Failed together.

Made mistakes together.

And somehow...

Every experience stitched another invisible thread between us.

Perhaps that is why Paradox felt so different.

People often praised our events.

The registrations.

The management.

The execution.

Those things certainly mattered.

But if I'm being honest...

They weren't the reason Paradox became unforgettable.

Paradox became unforgettable because it allowed us to spend an entire week living together.

Not as office bearers.

As friends.

Morning tea became a memory.

Walking back to Krishna Hostel became a memory.

Room 127 became a memory.

Even eating at Vasanta somehow became a memory.

When I look back today, I don't remember our conversations word for word.

I remember how they made me feel.

Safe.

Comfortable.

Accepted.

There is a photograph from Paradox that has always been one of my favourites.

Nothing special is happening in it.

Nobody is receiving an award.

Nobody is standing on a stage.

We're simply sitting together.

Somebody is laughing.

Someone else is looking away from the camera.

Half the group probably didn't even know the photograph was being taken.

That picture means more to me than any official photograph ever could.

Because it captures something impossible to organise.

Belonging.

Perhaps that is why everything that happened after Paradox felt so unbelievable.

When strangers misunderstand you...

It hurts.

When colleagues misunderstand you...

It becomes frustrating.

But when people you consider family misunderstand you...

You begin questioning yourself.

Not because they are always right.

But because their opinion matters enough to make you wonder if you missed something.

For a long time...

I kept asking myself the same question.

"Where did we stop understanding each other?"

I never found a single answer.

Because relationships rarely change in one dramatic moment.

They change quietly.

One assumption at a time.

One silence at a time.

One conversation that never happens.

Looking back now, I don't think our story ended because we stopped caring.

It became difficult because we cared too much.

And sometimes...

That is exactly what makes misunderstandings hurt the most.

Chapter 28

We Stopped Talking

For the first few days after Paradox, I didn't miss the events.

I missed the people.

Nobody prepares you for what happens after a festival ends.

For months, your phone never stops ringing.

Someone needs a volunteer.

Someone wants a meeting.

Someone has forgotten to update a Google Sheet.

Someone is asking where the footballs are.

Someone else has accidentally broken something and doesn't know whether to laugh or panic.

Then...

One day...

Everything becomes quiet.

I woke up the next morning expecting another message in the Sportify group.

Another discussion.

Another random debate.

Another meme from Aman.

Another impossible request from someone.

Instead...

There was nothing urgent waiting for me.

No venue.

No deadline.

No volunteer shortage.

Just an ordinary morning.

For the first time in months, my calendar belonged entirely to me.

Oddly enough...

I didn't like it.

People often think peace arrives with silence.

I discovered that sometimes silence only reminds you how beautiful the noise had been.

Life slowly resumed.

My internship began.

Assignments returned.

The laptop that had spent weeks displaying registration sheets and event schedules now returned to presentations, documents and deadlines.

Outwardly...

Everything was perfectly normal.

Inside...

Something felt missing.

Every now and then, my phone would buzz.

Someone had uploaded another Paradox photograph.

Another volunteer had shared a reel.

Somebody had found yet another video of the monkey from Kampus Run.

Even after coming home, Paradox somehow refused to leave us.

Our phones became little museums of the previous week.

Every notification carried another memory.

Sometimes I'd stop working for ten minutes just to scroll through old photographs.

The beach.

Room 127.

Snow Zone.

The volleyball courts.

The closing ceremony.

It amazed me how quickly ordinary moments had become things I already missed.

I realised something during those days.

We spend so much time wishing stressful weeks would end.

Then they do.

And somehow...

They're the weeks we spend the rest of our lives remembering.

I still spoke to people from Sportify.

Messages came and went throughout the day.

Someone asked for photographs.

Someone needed a document.

Someone wanted the certificate template.

The conversations hadn't disappeared.

They had simply...

Changed.

Less urgency.

More nostalgia.

At first, I thought this was completely natural.

After all...

Paradox was over.

Everyone had returned to their own cities.

Their own colleges.

Their own routines.

It would've been unrealistic to expect life to continue exactly as it had inside IIT Madras.

So I didn't think much about it.

Not then.

Because when you're twenty...

You believe friendships naturally survive distance.

You never imagine that silence can begin so quietly that you don't even notice it arriving.

And perhaps...

That was my biggest mistake.

The funny thing about habits is that they don't disappear just because an event ends.

For weeks after returning home, I still caught myself doing things that no longer made sense.

I'd wake up early and instinctively check the Sportify groups before even getting out of bed.

Then I'd remember.

There wasn't going to be another fixture list.

No volunteer allocation.

No emergency meeting.

No last-minute venue change.

Those days were over.

Sometimes I'd be working on my internship when a random memory would interrupt everything.

A football lying in the corner of a photograph.

Someone wearing a Sportify hoodie.

A song that had played during DJ Night.

Without warning, I'd stop whatever I was doing and spend the next twenty minutes scrolling through old pictures instead of finishing my work.

My parents noticed it too.

"Still looking at Paradox photos?"

I smiled.

"Just this one."

It was never just one.

Every photograph opened another memory.

One memory led to another.

Soon I'd find myself laughing alone in my room remembering how a monkey had stolen our Kampus Run bibs... or how Shreyansh Bhaiya and I had somehow managed to sleep through an entire movie for the second time.

Sometimes I'd come across the photograph from the closing ceremony.

The one where Aman and I stood together holding our tenure certificates.

I always paused at that picture a little longer.

Not because it was perfect.

Because it reminded me of everything that photograph couldn't capture.

The late-night planning.

The disagreements that always ended with a solution.

The excitement before every major event.

The relief after every successful one.

A single photograph had frozen the final moment.

But it couldn't show the journey that led there.

Every now and then, I'd think of sending that picture to Aman with some stupid caption.

"We actually survived."

Or,

"Can't believe it's over already."

Sometimes I even typed the message.

Then I'd stop.

Not because anything had happened.

Simply because I assumed we'd talk properly some other day.

There was no hurry.

That's what I believed.

After all, some friendships become so normal that you stop worrying about keeping them alive.

You assume they'll always be there.

Looking back...

That assumption frightens me more than anything else in this story.

Because relationships rarely disappear overnight.

They slowly become tomorrow's priority.

And then...

Tomorrow quietly becomes next week.

Without realising it, I had started saying,

"I'll call him later."

Later is a dangerous word.

Sometimes...

Later never comes.

As the days turned into weeks, another strange thing began happening.

The Sportify groups slowly grew quieter.

Not empty.

Just...

Different.

Earlier, there had been hundreds of messages every day.

Fixture discussions.

Volunteer allocations.

Design approvals.

Random voice notes.

Memes sent at two in the morning.

Somebody asking,

"Who's awake?"

And somehow...

Five people replying instantly.

Now, the messages were mostly photographs.

"Found this one."

"Who clicked this?"

"Please send in HD."

Occasionally someone shared a reel from Paradox.

The comments underneath looked exactly like our conversations used to.

"Bhai, remember this?"

"Peak moment."

"Monkey still owes us six bibs."

For a few seconds, everything felt normal again.

Then the conversation ended.

Not because anyone wanted it to.

Because everyone had somewhere else to be.

Someone had classes.

Someone had an internship.

Someone had gone back to office.

Someone was preparing for exams.

Life has a very polite way of asking everyone to move on.

And most of the time...

We do.

Without noticing.

There were evenings when I'd open the Spotify chat for no particular reason.

Not to send a message.

Just...

To scroll.

I'd read conversations from two months earlier.

Planning meetings.

Arguments about schedules.

Volunteer lists that had seemed impossibly important at the time.

Sometimes I'd laugh at how seriously we had taken problems that now felt insignificant.

Other times...

I'd simply smile.

Because every message reminded me of a version of us that existed only for those few months.

One evening, I found myself listening to an old voice note.

It wasn't important.

It wasn't motivational.

It was just a random discussion about an event.

Yet hearing familiar voices together again made the room feel a little less quiet.

That was when I realised something.

I wasn't missing Paradox anymore.

I was missing the routine of having these people in my life every single day.

And routines are strange.

You only realise how much they mattered after they've quietly disappeared.

At the time, I still believed this was temporary.

I thought everyone was simply settling back into their own lives.

I told myself,

"Give it a little time."

"Things will go back to normal."

Sometimes hope isn't built on evidence.

It's built on habit.

Because when you've spent months talking to someone every single day...

It's impossible to imagine that one day you won't know how to begin a conversation anymore.

I still didn't think anything was wrong.

I simply thought...

We were all busy.

I had no idea that, somewhere beyond the messages, photographs and everyday routines...

A completely different conversation had already begun.

One that I wasn't a part of.

One that I wouldn't even know existed...

Until much later.

Chapter 29

Everybody Noticed

The strange thing about misunderstandings is that they rarely happen in front of everyone.

Most of the time...

They happen while someone else is completely unaware.

Looking back today, that's the part that still surprises me the most.

While I was slowly settling back into everyday life, I genuinely believed everyone else was doing the same.

I thought Paradox had simply become another beautiful memory.

I had no idea that, for some people, the story hadn't ended the way it had for me.

The days continued moving forward.

My internship kept me busy.

Assignments slowly reclaimed whatever free time I had left.

Every now and then, someone from Sportify would message asking for an old document, a photograph or the certificate template.

Nothing about those conversations seemed unusual.

At least...

Not to me.

Whenever I looked back at Paradox, I remembered laughter.

Kampus Run.

The beach.

Snow Zone.

The closing ceremony.

The movie I never really watched.

I remembered friendships.

I remembered feeling grateful.

It never occurred to me that someone else could be remembering the same week very differently.

Perhaps that's the most dangerous thing about perspective.

Two people can live through the exact same moment...

And carry completely different memories home.

Weeks passed.

Life became busy enough that I stopped counting the days since Paradox.

The routines of everyday life quietly took over.

Morning classes.

Internship work.

Late-night assignments.

Phone calls with friends.

Nothing felt out of place.

Until, every now and then, something small would interrupt that normality.

Someone would ask a question that seemed oddly specific.

"Everything okay?"

"Yeah... why?"

"Nahi, bas aise hi."

The conversation would move on.

I never thought much about it.

Another time, someone casually mentioned a discussion that I didn't remember being part of.

I assumed I had simply missed it.

That happens in every organisation.

People talk.

Conversations overlap.

Not everyone is present every time.

Again...

I thought nothing of it.

Looking back now, those were probably the first signs.

Not loud enough to alarm me.

Not clear enough to understand.

Just small moments that, in hindsight, fit together like pieces of a puzzle.

But at the time...

They were simply ordinary conversations.

I still believed everyone was okay.

I still believed that, once life settled down, we'd all go back to talking the way we always had.

I still believed the silence was temporary.

Sometimes...

The hardest part of a misunderstanding isn't the misunderstanding itself.

It's not knowing that one exists.

Because you don't even know which question you're supposed to ask.

And if you don't know the question...

You rarely find the answer.

Chapter 30

The Longest Ten Days

For a long time, I kept asking myself the wrong question.

I kept asking,

"When did everything change?"

Years later, I realised the better question was,

"When did I first realise something had already changed?"

Those are two very different moments.

The truth is...

Nothing fell apart in front of me.

There wasn't one dramatic fight.

There wasn't one phone call where everything ended.

There wasn't one message saying,

"We're done."

If there had been...

Perhaps it would've been easier.

Instead, I slowly began hearing fragments.

One sentence here.

A passing remark there.

Someone mentioning something I didn't understand.

Another person becoming strangely quiet whenever a certain topic came up.

It felt as though everyone else had already watched a film...

...and I had arrived after the interval.

People knew something.

I didn't.

At first, I dismissed it.

Then it happened again.

And again.

Until one evening, I finally stopped pretending that I wasn't noticing.

Something had happened after Paradox.

Something I hadn't understood.

And somehow...

It involved people I loved the most.

That frightened me more than I can explain.

Not because I was afraid of being blamed.

Because I genuinely didn't know what had gone wrong.

When you know you've made a mistake, you know where to begin.

You apologise.

You explain.

You try to fix it.

But what do you do when you don't even know which mistake everyone is talking about?

I started replaying Paradox in my head.

Day by day.

Morning by morning.

Conversation by conversation.

The temple visits.

The beach.

Room 127.

Kampus Run.

The closing ceremony.

Snow Zone.

The dinner after volleyball.

I kept searching for the moment where everything had changed.

And every time...

I reached the same conclusion.

I couldn't find it.

Then, slowly...

People began telling me their version of the story.

Not all at once.

One conversation at a time.

One perspective at a time.

And for the first time...

I realised something that leadership books rarely teach.

The same event can exist in two completely different realities.

Both can be honest.

Both can be painful.

Both can believe they are right.

The story I had lived...

Wasn't the only story that existed.

And once I understood that...

I finally knew where I needed to go back.

Back to one evening.

One bus.

One restaurant.

One decision that had looked completely ordinary to me.

A decision that, without me ever realising it...

Had quietly hurt people I loved.

Everything that happened afterwards...

Started there.

I have replayed that evening in my head more times than I can count.

Not because I wanted to change the past.

Because I wanted to understand it.

Memory is a strange thing.

Every time you revisit it, you notice something you had missed before.

A face.

A pause.

A sentence.

A silence.

Looking back now, I don't think anyone woke up on 12 June intending to hurt anyone else.

We were simply exhausted.

Physically.

Mentally.

Emotionally.

Paradox had demanded everything we had.

The previous few days had been a blur of early mornings, last-minute crises, skipped meals and endless walking across the IIT Madras campus.

We weren't thinking as clearly as we normally would have.

And perhaps that matters.

Not because exhaustion excuses mistakes.

Because it explains how ordinary people make them.

That evening, after another long day of events, a group of us decided to go out for dinner.

It wasn't an official meeting.

It wasn't a celebration.

It was simply a group of tired friends looking for food.

At the time, I thought that was all it was.

Today...

I know that several people remember that evening very differently.

For a long time, I struggled with that idea.

How could one dinner create two completely different memories?

Eventually, I realised something uncomfortable.

Because we weren't all experiencing the same evening.

We were each experiencing our own version of it.

Mine began with a bus.

Someone noticed that a bus had arrived.

If we managed to catch it, the entire group could avoid walking nearly one and a half kilometres.

Without thinking much, a few of us instinctively ran ahead.

Not to leave anyone behind.

Quite the opposite.

The idea was to stop the bus before it drove away.

We never managed to stop it.

By the time we reached it, the bus had already gone.

So we waited.

I still remember standing there, looking back down the road until I saw the rest of our group walking towards us.

Only after I knew everyone was coming did we continue towards the main gate.

In my mind...

That chapter of the evening had ended there.

I never imagined that, for someone else, it had only just begun.

That is perhaps the hardest lesson I learned from my time in Sportify.

Intentions belong to us.

Experiences belong to everyone.

And the two are not always the same.

When we reached the Main Gate, a few people had already arrived.

Deepak.

Saurabh.

Ansh.

The rest of the group was still a little behind.

Someone asked,

"So... where are we eating?"

After a few quick discussions, a restaurant was decided.

I remember turning towards Ansh and saying,

"Call Aman once and send him the live location. Everyone will come directly."

In my head, the problem had been solved.

Everyone knew where we were going.

Everyone would reach.

Simple.

That assumption would stay with me for a very long time.

As we started walking, another thought crossed my mind.

It was dinner time.

A large group.

If we all reached together, we'd probably spend fifteen or twenty minutes just waiting outside for a table.

So I did what felt practical.

I walked a little ahead.

Not to leave anyone behind.

Not because I didn't want to walk with them.

I simply wanted to reach the restaurant first and get a waiting token before the others arrived.

At the time, it felt like a tiny decision.

One of those dozens of small decisions organisers make every single day without thinking twice.

Save a few minutes here.

Reduce waiting there.

Keep things moving.

I had spent months doing exactly that.

Efficiency had become second nature.

What I didn't realise was that this wasn't an event anymore.

It was dinner with friends.

Those are two very different situations.

Organisers think about logistics.

Friends think about staying together.

That evening...

Without even noticing...

I was still thinking like an organiser.

By the time I reached the restaurant, a few others had also arrived.

I collected the waiting token and stood outside.

One by one, people began reaching.

Conversations started.

Someone joked about how tired we all looked.

Someone else was already discussing what to order.

From where I stood...

Everything seemed completely normal.

If someone had asked me that night,

"Did anything unusual happen?"

I would've honestly answered,

"No."

That is the part that still stays with me.

Sometimes...

The moments that change relationships don't feel important while you're living them.

Only later do you realise they meant something entirely different to someone standing a few steps behind you.

Inside the restaurant, the usual chaos of a large group immediately took over.

Nobody really knew where to sit.

Someone pulled another chair from a nearby table.

Two tables were pushed together.

Someone insisted everyone should shift one seat to the left so another person could fit.

Menus began travelling around faster than anyone could actually read them.

For the first few minutes...

Everything looked exactly like every other dinner we had shared during Paradox.

People were laughing.

Someone had already started making fun of another person's food choices.

The waiters looked mildly concerned after seeing the size of our group.

It all felt...

Normal.

Then I looked towards Aman.

Something felt different.

Not dramatic.

Just...

Different.

He wasn't laughing as much.

He wasn't joining the conversations the way he usually did.

At first, I wondered whether he was simply exhausted.

We all were.

Paradox had taken almost everything out of us.

But after knowing someone for months, you slowly begin recognising the small changes.

The smile that isn't completely real.

The unusually quiet replies.

The way someone looks present...

Without actually being present.

I leaned towards him.

"Sab theek hai?"

He looked at me for a second before answering.

"Haan."

It wasn't convincing.

I knew him well enough to know that much.

A few minutes later, I asked again.

This time he sighed.

There was a pause.

Then he quietly told me what had been bothering him.

He felt hurt.

Not because of dinner itself.

Because of everything that had happened on the way there.

As he spoke, I remember feeling genuinely surprised.

Not defensive.

Surprised.

Because the version of the evening I had been carrying inside my head was completely different from the one he had just described.

I immediately started explaining what had happened from my side.

The bus.

Waiting near the road.

Asking Ansh to share the location.

Walking ahead only to collect the waiting token.

To me...

Those decisions had all been practical.

None of them had been personal.

While speaking, I remember thinking,

"Oh... this is just a misunderstanding."

I honestly believed that once I explained my intention, everything would become clear.

What I didn't realise...

Was that this conversation was happening at only one end of the table.

I was so focused on understanding why Aman was hurt...

That I never stopped to ask a much bigger question.

Was anyone else feeling the same way?

Looking back today...

That question changes everything.

Because while I was trying to repair one relationship...

I didn't realise that silence had already reached several others.

Not because they hated me.

Not because they wanted to distance themselves.

Simply because hurt often chooses silence before it chooses words.

And unfortunately...

I didn't know how to hear silence yet.

When dinner ended, I genuinely believed the misunderstanding had been resolved.

Aman and I had spoken.

I had explained what had happened from my side.

He had explained why he felt hurt.

We didn't raise our voices.

We didn't argue.

We simply talked.

As we stepped out of the restaurant that night, I remember feeling lighter.

I thought,

"Good."

"I'm glad we spoke."

If someone had asked me at that exact moment whether everything was okay...

I would've answered,

"Yes."

Without hesitation.

That answer would've been completely honest.

Because it was the truth...

At least from where I was standing.

Looking back today, I realise something that twenty-year-old me couldn't possibly have understood.

A misunderstanding doesn't end just because two people have spoken.

Not if more than two people were carrying the same hurt.

I didn't know that.

I walked back that night believing I had fixed the only problem that existed.

I had no idea there were conversations happening that I wasn't part of.

No idea that some people had quietly gone back to their rooms carrying emotions they never shared with me.

No idea that silence had already begun doing what silence does best.

Growing.

Not loudly.

Quietly.

Almost invisibly.

Perhaps that was my biggest mistake.

Not walking ahead.

Not taking the waiting token.

Not even making assumptions.

My biggest mistake was assuming that if anyone else had been hurt...

They would tell me.

Because that's what I would've done.

That assumption came from love.

Not arrogance.

I believed these people were my family.

I believed brothers don't hide disappointment from each other.

I believed friends simply say,

"Idiot... what you did wasn't right."

Then everyone laughs.

Then everyone moves on.

Life, unfortunately...

Doesn't always work that way.

Sometimes the people closest to us remain silent for exactly the same reason they matter so much.

They don't want another argument.

They don't want to create more discomfort.

So they wait.

Hoping we'll notice on our own.

And sometimes...

The person they're waiting for never realises there's anything to notice.

For days after that dinner, I carried only one version of the story.

My own.

Not because I thought it was the only truth.

Because I didn't know another truth existed.

That is why, when people later told me how they had felt that evening...

I wasn't shocked because they were hurt.

I was shocked because I had never realised they were.

That moment changed something inside me forever.

Leadership isn't just about making decisions.

It is also about noticing the people who quietly stop speaking.

And I failed at that.

Not intentionally.

But failure doesn't become smaller simply because the intention was good.

That lesson has stayed with me far longer than any certificate I received during Paradox.

Even today, whenever I lead a team, I ask myself one question far more often than I used to.

Who hasn't spoken yet?

Because sometimes...

The quietest person in the room is carrying the conversation that matters most.

Chapter 31

Different Versions of the Same Story

For a long time, I wanted to know who was right.

It seemed like the most obvious question.

If a misunderstanding had become this big, surely someone had to be wrong.

Someone had to be mistaken.

Someone had to have misunderstood.

I spent days replaying Paradox in my head.

Every venue.

Every conversation.

Every meal.

Every walk across the campus.

Every decision I had made.

I kept searching for the moment where everything had gone wrong.

At first, I thought I was searching for a mistake.

Eventually, I realised I was searching for something much more difficult.

Perspective.

That word sounds simple until it becomes personal.

We often say,

"Everyone has their own perspective."

It sounds like a nice sentence.

A mature sentence.

One that belongs in leadership books or motivational speeches.

I never truly understood what it meant until Paradox.

Because for the first time in my life, I found myself standing in front of two stories that completely contradicted each other.

The strange part was...

Neither of them was false.

The story I remembered was simple.

A bus arrived.

We ran.

We failed to stop it.

We waited.

We reached the gate.

I asked Ansh to share our location.

I walked ahead to collect a waiting token.

I noticed Aman was upset.

I spoke to him.

I thought we had sorted everything out.

I went back to my room believing the evening had ended peacefully.

That was the story I carried home.

Then I started listening.

Not to defend myself.

Not to prove anyone wrong.

Simply...

To understand.

One by one, people shared how they had experienced that same evening.

To someone else, it wasn't about a waiting token.

It was about being left behind.

To someone else, it wasn't about logistics.

It was about feeling unnoticed.

To someone else, it wasn't about a restaurant.

It was about feeling that the group had stopped moving together.

And to Aman...

It wasn't even only about that evening.

It was about many small moments that, in his eyes, had slowly started adding up.

I remember sitting quietly after hearing all of it.

Not because I disagreed.

Because I had genuinely never seen those moments that way.

The same evening.

The same roads.

The same restaurant.

The same people.

Yet somehow...

We had all walked away carrying different memories.

That frightened me.

Not because someone had misunderstood me.

Because I realised that I had misunderstood them too.

For days, I had kept asking myself,

"Why didn't they tell me?"

It took me much longer to ask the more uncomfortable question.

"Why didn't I notice?"

That question changed everything.

Because once I asked it...

The story stopped being about proving my intentions.

It became about understanding their experience.

And those are not the same thing.

For the first few days, I kept thinking about intentions.

"I never meant to hurt anyone."

I repeated that sentence to myself over and over again.

It was true.

But eventually I realised something uncomfortable.

Intentions belong to the person who acts.

Experiences belong to the person who receives those actions.

And the two don't always meet.

That was probably the hardest lesson I learned at twenty.

I had spent days explaining why I ran ahead.

Why I collected the waiting token.

Why I spoke to Aman first.

Every explanation was honest.

Every explanation was true.

Yet somehow...

None of those explanations changed one simple fact.

People had been hurt.

And that fact deserved more attention than my intentions.

That realisation changed the questions I was asking myself.

Instead of asking,

"Why didn't they understand what I meant?"

I started asking,

"Why did they feel what they felt?"

Those two questions sound almost identical.

They lead to completely different answers.

The first protects your ego.

The second challenges it.

For the first time, I stopped looking at the evening through my own eyes.

I imagined what it might have looked like if I had been standing somewhere else.

If I had been the person walking behind instead of ahead.

If I had watched a part of the group disappear into the distance.

If I had reached the restaurant feeling left behind before anyone had explained why.

Would I have felt hurt?

Honestly...

Maybe I would have.

And that thought humbled me.

Not because it proved I was wrong.

But because it proved that hurt doesn't always need bad intentions.

Sometimes...

Good people accidentally become the reason someone else feels alone.

Leadership books often tell you that decisions should be judged by intentions.

Life taught me something different.

Relationships are remembered by how people felt.

Not by the reasons we had in our heads.

That doesn't mean intentions don't matter.

They do.

Without them, there can be no trust.

But intentions alone cannot heal someone else's experience.

Only listening can do that.

That was the moment I stopped trying to explain myself.

Instead...

I decided to listen.

Really listen.

And the more I listened...

The more one thought kept returning.

If these people had become my family...

Then perhaps I had spent too much time explaining what I meant...

And too little time understanding what they had felt.

That was the day I opened WhatsApp.

Not because I had finally found the perfect explanation.

But because I had finally found the right reason to apologise.

Chapter 32

The Message We Never Thought We'd Have to Write

There is a strange kind of silence that follows understanding.

Not confusion.

Not anger.

Just...

Acceptance.

For several days, I had been searching for an answer.

Now I finally had one.

It wasn't the answer I wanted.

But it was the one I needed.

People I loved had been hurt.

Whether I intended it or not...

That was the truth.

And once I accepted that truth, another question immediately followed.

Now what?

I could continue explaining my intentions.

I could continue telling everyone why I had done what I had done.

Or...

I could simply tell them what mattered the most.

That I was sorry.

Not because I believed I was a terrible person.

Not because I believed every misunderstanding had been entirely my fault.

But because relationships had always mattered more to me than being proven right.

I opened WhatsApp.

The Sportify group stared back at me.

For a few moments, I simply looked at the screen.

The cursor blinked.

Waiting.

It is amazing how difficult a few words become when they are meant for people you love.

I started typing.

Deleted everything.

Started again.

Deleted it again.

Nothing sounded honest enough.

Nothing sounded like me.

Eventually...

I stopped trying to write the perfect message.

I decided to write the truthful one.

I began with the only sentence that felt real.

"First of all, I genuinely don't know how to say all this."

That wasn't a literary opening.

It wasn't carefully written.

It was simply the truth.

Because I genuinely didn't know how to explain everything that had been running through my mind.

As I continued writing, I realised I wasn't trying to defend myself anymore.

Every few paragraphs, I found myself writing the same sentence in different forms.

"I should have waited."

"I should have spoken to everyone."

"I shouldn't have assumed."

For the first time since Paradox had ended...

I wasn't writing as the Deputy Secretary of Sportify.

I wasn't writing as an organiser.

I was writing as a twenty-year-old who had accidentally hurt people he considered his own.

And somehow...

That made the words easier.

The message kept growing.

Longer than I had expected.

Longer than any message I had ever sent in that group.

Because every time I thought I had finished...

Another memory appeared.

Another person came to mind.

Another apology needed to be written.

As I wrote, one memory kept returning.

The dinner.

For days, I had tried to explain it.

Now...

I found myself apologising for it instead.

I told them about the bus.

About running ahead.

About waiting until I saw everyone walking towards us.

About asking Ansh to share the live location.

About walking ahead to collect the waiting token.

Every one of those decisions had made perfect sense inside my own head.

Looking back...

That wasn't enough.

I wrote something I had never admitted to myself before.

I should have waited.

Not because waiting would've saved five minutes.

Because sometimes five minutes spent together matter more than thirty minutes saved later.

Then I wrote about the restaurant.

Not the food.

Not the conversations.

The mistake I hadn't noticed until much later.

I told them that I had gone straight to Aman because I could see he was hurt.

At the time, I believed I was doing the right thing.

Today, I realised I had stopped looking around the room after that.

I had become so focused on understanding one person's pain...

That I had failed to notice the silence sitting beside everyone else.

That sentence was probably the hardest one to write.

Because it forced me to accept something uncomfortable.

Leadership isn't choosing the right person to listen to.

It's noticing the people who never ask to be heard.

As the message continued, I found myself writing something that surprised even me.

I wasn't apologising for walking ahead anymore.

I was apologising for assuming.

Assuming my closest friends would simply scold me if they were hurt.

Assuming silence meant everything was fine.

Assuming people always express disappointment the way I do.

Those assumptions had never come from arrogance.

They had come from affection.

I genuinely believed these people were my brothers and sisters.

I believed family tells you when you've messed up.

Paradox taught me something different.

Sometimes the people closest to you stay silent precisely because they love you.

Not because they don't care.

Because they don't know how to tell you that you've hurt them.

Then came the paragraph that took me the longest to write.

Not because the words were difficult.

Because every name carried a face.

Every face carried a memory.

Lata.

VSS.

Aman.

Methelesh.

Varad.

Ansh.

Deepak.

Saurabh.

Pratham.

Sarthak.

Anshul.

Jahanvi.

Pratishtha.

Shreyansh Bhaiya.

One by one, they stopped becoming names on my screen.

They became moments.

Conversations.

Shared meals.

Sleepless nights.

Victories.

Failures.

An entire year of my life.

That was when I finally understood why writing this message had felt so impossible.

I wasn't writing to teammates.

I was writing to family.

And that changes everything.

By the time I reached the last few lines, I wasn't worried anymore about whether everyone would agree with me.

I wasn't trying to convince anyone that my intentions had been pure.

Intentions no longer felt like the most important thing.

Relationships did.

So I ended the message with the only truth I knew hadn't changed.

"For me, you were never just a team."

"You were, and always will be, family."

I read the message one last time.

Not to check my grammar.

To ask myself one question.

"Is this honest?"

For the first time in many days...

The answer was yes.

I pressed **Send**.

Then I put my phone down.

There was nothing left to explain.

Only hope.

Hope that the people who had become my family would see, somewhere between all those words, the one thing I had been trying to say all along.

"I never stopped loving you all."

Chapter 33

Finally

There is one thing I wish every twenty-year-old understood.

The hardest conversation is almost never the one that ends a friendship.

It's the one that could save it.

Four days after sending that message to the team, I opened Aman's chat.

Unlike the group message, this one wasn't meant for everyone.

It wasn't about Sportify.

It wasn't about Paradox.

It wasn't even about the misunderstanding anymore.

It was about us.

For several minutes, I stared at the empty chat window.

The words felt heavier than they should have.

Not because I was afraid he would be angry.

Because I was afraid he wouldn't care enough to reply.

That fear sounds irrational now.

But at twenty, losing a friendship often feels far more frightening than losing an argument.

Eventually, I stopped overthinking.

I typed exactly what I was feeling.

I told him that I had heard many different versions of the story from many different people.

But I didn't want to know his feelings through someone else.

If our friendship meant anything...

I wanted to hear the truth from him.

Directly.

No filters.

No assumptions.

No third person standing in the middle.

I pressed send.

This time...

The wait felt much longer.

When his reply finally appeared, I opened it almost immediately.

The very first thing he did was destroy the biggest fear I had been carrying for days.

He wrote,

"I know you don't think like that."

I stared at that sentence for a while.

The rumour that had hurt me the most...

The one saying that I had ignored people because of money...

Was never the reason he was hurt.

In that single sentence, a weight quietly disappeared from my shoulders.

Then he told me something I wasn't prepared to hear.

"It wasn't the bus."

"It wasn't the waiting token."

"It was that I felt you left us behind."

Those words were much harder to read.

Because unlike the rumour...

They were real.

He wasn't questioning my character.

He was describing his experience.

And those are two very different things.

His next few messages forced me to look at the previous week from an entirely different angle.

For me, the misunderstanding had begun outside a restaurant.

For him...

It had begun much earlier.

As we continued talking, he told me something I had never realised.

It wasn't just about that dinner.

Over the previous few days, he had slowly started feeling that I was giving someone else the place that had once belonged to him.

He mentioned Shreyansh Bhaiya.

At first, I didn't understand.

Then he explained.

From his perspective, after my reconciliation with Bhaiya, I had changed.

I was spending more time with him.

Inviting him to moments that mattered.

Walking beside him.

Laughing with him.

And somewhere in all of that...

He had quietly started feeling left behind.

I remember putting my phone down for a moment after reading those messages.

Not because I agreed with everything.

Because I had genuinely never imagined that someone could see those days that way.

From my side, every incident had its own explanation.

Kampus Run.

The meeting in the ICSR office.

The movie.

Snow Zone.

Every moment had happened naturally.

Sometimes by coincidence.

Sometimes because people simply happened to be in the same place.

I started telling him those stories.

Not to prove him wrong.

Only to show him what I had been seeing.

I told him how Shreyansh Bhaiya had handled Kampus Run when I had completely frozen under pressure.

How he and Saksham had happened to arrive at ESB while we were already sitting there.

How the movie plan hadn't been ours at all.

How Snow Zone had happened because someone else suggested it.

How, after Shambhavi got hurt because of my own mistake, I stayed with them out of guilt more than anything else.

As I typed those messages, I realised something.

I wasn't changing his memories.

I was simply allowing him to see mine.

And then...

He did the same for me.

He told me that none of those individual incidents had hurt him by themselves.

It was the pattern.

One moment never breaks a friendship.

A hundred small moments can.

Reading that sentence, I stopped trying to explain.

Because for the first time, I understood what he had been trying to tell me all along.

He wasn't accusing me of choosing someone else.

He was telling me how it had felt from where he was standing.

There is a huge difference between those two things.

That conversation taught me something I wish I had learned much earlier.

People don't always remember what happened.

They remember how what happened made them feel.

And feelings don't become less real simply because someone else's intentions were different.

Perhaps that is why we finally began understanding each other.

Not because either of us won the argument.

But because, for the first time in many days...

Neither of us was trying to.

As our conversation continued, I realised something almost ironic.

For days, I had believed Aman didn't want to talk to me.

At the very same time...

He had believed I didn't want to talk to him.

Neither of us had been completely right.

Neither of us had been completely wrong.

We had simply been waiting.

Waiting for the other person to take the first step.

He told me that after the dinner, he had been deeply hurt.

So hurt that, in those moments, he wasn't in a state where he could listen to anyone.

I remembered walking up to him in the restaurant.

Trying to pull him into the conversation.

Trying to get him to sit with us.

I remembered asking Ansh to speak to him.

Later, even asking others to check on him.

From my side, I had thought,

"I'm trying."

From his side...

He was carrying a hurt that made every attempt feel too late.

Neither memory erased the other.

Both existed together.

Then he said something that made me smile.

"Kaash ye saari baatein aamne-saamne ho jaati."

I read that sentence twice.

Because he was right.

Everything we were finally saying over WhatsApp...

Should have been said while sitting across a table.

Not four days later.

Not after assumptions had grown.

Not after other people's versions of the story had filled the empty spaces between us.

Just...

Face to face.

I laughed quietly when the conversation became lighter.

In the middle of everything, he suddenly changed the topic.

"Sorry se kya hoga... Gemd do."

That was Aman.

Even after one of the most emotional conversations we'd ever had...

He still found a way to end it with a joke.

And somehow...

That joke told me more than another apology ever could.

It told me that the friendship was still alive.

Maybe not exactly where we had left it.

Maybe carrying a few scars.

But alive.

Before we ended the conversation, I apologised one last time.

This time, not because I felt responsible for every misunderstanding.

But because I knew one thing with complete certainty.

If my actions, however unintentionally, had made one of the people closest to me feel left behind...

Then I was genuinely sorry.

His reply surprised me.

He apologised too.

For a few moments, I simply stared at the screen.

It felt strange.

Both of us had spent days believing we were the one who had been hurt the most.

Now both of us were apologising to each other.

Maybe that's how real friendships survive.

Not because one person wins.

Not because one person is declared right.

But because, at some point, both people decide that the relationship matters more than the argument.

When I locked my phone that afternoon, nothing in the past had changed.

The dinner was still the dinner.

The misunderstandings had still happened.

The silence had still existed.

But something inside me had become lighter.

Not because every question had been answered.

Because the most important one had.

We had finally started talking again.

Chapter 34

When We Were Twenty

People often ask me what Paradox taught me.

For a long time, I answered with things that sounded impressive.

Leadership.

Teamwork.

Event management.

Communication.

Crisis handling.

Those answers weren't wrong.

They just weren't complete.

Years later, I realised that the biggest lessons had nothing to do with organising events.

They had everything to do with understanding people.

When we are twenty, we think good intentions are enough.

We believe that if our heart is in the right place, people will automatically understand us.

Life doesn't always work that way.

Sometimes you can love people deeply...

And still hurt them.

Sometimes you can make the most practical decision...

And someone else remembers it as the loneliest moment of their week.

Sometimes both stories are true.

That idea frightened me at first.

Today...

It comforts me.

Because it reminds me that relationships aren't built by never making mistakes.

They're built by having the courage to return after making them.

Looking back now, I don't think the most important thing I did after Paradox was organising events.

Or receiving a certificate.

Or standing on a stage.

I think the most important thing I did...

Was asking someone,

"Tell me your version."

That question changed me.

It made me realise that listening isn't simply waiting for your turn to speak.

Listening is accepting that another person's truth may exist beside your own.

Not instead of it.

Beside it.

That lesson has stayed with me far longer than any title I ever held.

Today, whenever I lead a team, I ask myself questions I never asked when I was twenty.

Who hasn't spoken yet?

Who looks quieter than usual?

Who is smiling only because everyone else is?

Who is carrying something they haven't found the words to say?

Those questions came from Paradox.

More specifically...

They came from my mistakes during Paradox.

And strangely enough...

I'm grateful for them.

Not because I'm proud of those mistakes.

Because they forced me to become a better listener.

A better teammate.

A better friend.

Perhaps that's what growing up really is.

Not becoming someone who never makes mistakes.

Becoming someone who learns to recognise them before they become someone else's pain.

If there is one thing I hope this book leaves behind, it isn't the memory of Kampus Run.

Or the monkey.

Or Snow Zone.

Or even Sportify.

I hope it leaves behind a simple reminder.

Tell people when they matter.

Tell people when they've hurt you.

Tell people when you're sorry.

Don't wait for pride to become silence.

Because silence has a habit of growing much faster than love.

And sometimes...

All a friendship is waiting for...

Is one honest conversation.

Epilogue

If We Meet Again

Sometimes I wonder what would happen if all of us met again.

Not because of Paradox.

Not because of Sportify.

Just...

Because enough time had passed.

I imagine someone creating a WhatsApp group again.

The name would probably be something ridiculous.

Half the people would mute it within five minutes.

The other half would spend three days deciding the venue.

Someone would inevitably say,

"Bhai, Chennai hi karte hain."

Someone else would reply,

"Budget dekh lo pehle."

Some things, I hope, never change.

I imagine walking through the gates of IIT Madras once more.

Older.

Hopefully a little wiser.

Probably carrying a laptop instead of a volunteer badge.

Maybe with a few more responsibilities than I had when I was twenty.

But I know exactly what would happen.

The moment I saw those familiar faces...

None of us would feel older.

Aman would still interrupt someone halfway through a sentence.

Methelesh would still somehow find a reason to argue.

Varad would still look calm while secretly solving everyone else's problems.

Ansh would still laugh before finishing his own joke.

Sarthak would still pretend he wasn't emotional about any of this.

Shreyansh Bhaiya would smile the same way he always did before saying something that somehow made everything feel simpler.

Someone would definitely bring up the monkey.

Someone would remind me that I still owe Shambhavi an apology for Snow Zone.

Someone would ask whether I ever managed to stay awake through an entire movie.

And somebody...

Without fail...

Would ask,

"Paradox reunion kab?"

We would laugh.

The same way we always did.

For a few hours, nobody would care what job we had.

Nobody would ask about salaries.

Nobody would remember designations.

Secretary.

Deputy Secretary.

Department Head.

Volunteer.

Those titles would have stayed behind years ago.

Only names would remain.

Only friendships.

Only memories.

Eventually, evening would arrive again.

Just like it always does.

People would begin leaving.

Flights.

Trains.

Families waiting back home.

Real life would call all of us once more.

Before leaving, we'd probably hug each other a little longer than necessary.

Not because we were sad.

Because we would know something we didn't understand when we were twenty.

These moments don't happen forever.

As we walked away, someone would shout from a distance,

"Milte bain jaldi!"

All of us would reply,

"Pakka."

Whether "jaldi" meant next month...

Next year...

Or ten years later...

Nobody would know.

But this time, I think we'd understand something we didn't back then.

Growing up doesn't mean leaving people behind.

It means carrying them with you.

Every lesson.

Every mistake.

Every laugh.

Every apology.

Every impossible week that somehow became unforgettable.

When I began writing this book, I thought I was writing about Paradox.

Halfway through, I thought I was writing about Sportify.

Today, after writing the last page...

I think I was simply writing about people.

About the strange, beautiful way complete strangers become family.

About how easily we hurt the people we love.

About how much courage it takes to say,

"I'm sorry."

And about how, if we're lucky...

Some friendships survive long enough to hear it.

If you are reading this years from now, and you happened to be part of that journey...

Thank you.

Thank you for every early morning.

Every late-night meeting.

Every disagreement.

Every inside joke.

Every Google Sheet.

Every venue change.

Every meal.

Every memory.

You made my twenties more beautiful than I could have imagined.

And if, someday...

Life brings all of us back to the same place again...

I hope we don't spend the evening talking about registrations, certificates or positions.

I hope we simply sit together.

Order too much food.

Laugh too loudly.

Take one blurry group photo.

And, for just a little while...

Become twenty again.

Because I have realised something after all these years.

We weren't building events.

We were building memories.

We just didn't know it yet.

Before You Close This Book

If you've read this far...

Thank you.

Not because you finished a book.

But because, for a little while, you chose to walk beside a group of twenty-year-olds who were simply trying to figure life out.

Everything you read in these pages happened during one small chapter of our lives.

The events ended.

The registrations closed.

The certificates were distributed.

The venues were cleaned.

The WhatsApp groups slowly became quieter.

Life moved forward.

Just as it always does.

But I hope one thing never changes.

I hope every time June arrives, the people who lived those days remember them with a smile.

I hope we remember Kampus Run before we remember the stress.

The monkey before the chaos.

Snow Zone before the misunderstandings.

The beach before the deadlines.

The conversations before the silence.

And the friendships before everything else.

Because when I look back now...

I don't remember Paradox as a festival.

I remember it as a week where ordinary people unknowingly became part of each other's lives forever.

If you were one of those people...

Thank you.

Thank you for every laugh.

Every disagreement.

Every early morning.

Every late-night meeting.

Every phone call.

Every Google Sheet.

Every venue change.

Every meal.

Every memory.

You helped write this story long before I ever did.

And if you weren't there...

I hope this book reminded you of your own people.

Your own summer.

Your own campus.

Your own version of being twenty.

Because every generation has one.

Every person has one.

A time that never feels extraordinary while you're living it.

Until years later...

When you realise those ordinary days quietly became the stories you'll spend the rest of your life telling.

Take care of your people.

Tell them when they matter.

Call them before "later" becomes "too late."

And if life is kind enough to bring you all back together someday...

Don't spend the evening talking about achievements.

Talk about the moments nobody else remembers.

Those are usually the ones that mattered the most.

— **Krish Gupta**

Deputy Secretary, Sportify (2025–26)

Forever grateful to everyone who made "When We Were Twenty" possible.

Acknowledgements

It feels strange writing this page.

For nearly three hundred pages, I tried to tell a story that was never mine alone.

Every memory in this book exists because someone else was standing beside me when it happened.

So before I close this journey, there are a few people I want to thank.

To my parents,

Thank you for giving me the freedom to chase experiences that often made no sense on paper. Thank you for trusting me when I chose responsibilities over comfort, trains over vacations, meetings over weekends, and memories over sleep. Everything I became during those years was possible because home always remained my safest place.

To the IIT Madras BS Degree community,

Thank you for creating a place where strangers from every corner of the country could become teammates, friends, and eventually family. This degree gave me much more than an education. It gave me people.

To Sportify,

You were never just a student society.

You were classrooms without walls.

You taught me leadership without teaching it.

You taught me failure without humiliating me.

You taught me responsibility before I was ready for it.

Most importantly...

You taught me that people will always matter more than positions.

No certificate could ever measure what you gave me.

To Aman,

Thank you for walking beside me through one of the most important years of my life.

We celebrated victories together.

We made mistakes together.

We misunderstood each other.

And most importantly...

We chose to understand each other again.

That is a friendship I will always be grateful for.

To Shreyansh Bhaiya,

Thank you for believing in me long before I believed in myself.

Thank you for every difficult conversation, every lesson that never sounded like a lecture, and every time you quietly reminded me that leadership begins with listening.

You shaped far more of this journey than you probably realise.

To every member of Sportify,

Methelesh.

Varad.

Ansh.

Deepak.

Saurabh.

Sarthak.

Pratham.

Ashish.

Anshul.

Jahanvi.

Pratishtha.

Lata.

VSS.

Nikhil.

And every volunteer, coordinator, department head and friend whose name may not appear on this page but whose presence fills every chapter of this book -

Thank you.

Some of you appear for entire chapters.

Some only for a few pages.

Yet every single one of you changed this story.

I hope you recognise yourselves somewhere in these memories.

To everyone who was part of Paradox 2026,

Whether we spoke once or a hundred times...

Whether we organised together, competed together, argued together or simply crossed paths on campus...

Thank you for making one week unforgettable.

And finally...

To you, the reader.

Whether you knew us personally or not...

Thank you for spending your time with a group of ordinary twenty-year-olds who were simply trying to build something meaningful.

If, somewhere in these pages, you remembered your own college friends...

Your own team...

Your own hostel...

Your own summer...

Then this book has already done everything I hoped it would.

Thank you for carrying our story with you.

With gratitude,

Krish Gupta

One Last Thing...

If this book has taught me anything..

It is that memories are not made on extraordinary days.

They are made on ordinary days that nobody realises are extraordinary until much later.

So...

Call your friends.

Take the photograph.

Go on the trip.

Say yes to the plan.

Stay a little longer after dinner.

Watch the sunset.

Play that one last game.

Laugh a little louder.

Forgive a little sooner.

Apologise before your ego convinces you not to.

Tell people they matter while they are still there to hear it.

One day...

Without anyone announcing it...

Those ordinary moments will quietly become the stories you spend the rest of your life telling.

That is what happened to us.

And perhaps...

One day...

It will happen to you too.

See you somewhere down the road.

— **Krish Gupta**

For the Sportify Team (2025–26).

Thank you for making my twenties unforgettable.

This book is for all of us.